

Unit 1 Study Guide

Biology 11A · Chapters 1, 2, 3 and 4 · built from lecture slides

How to use this. Each card gives you the plain-words answer first, the exam wording underneath, and a memory trick. Read one, cover it, then say it back in your own words before you check. Each card is marked IN LECTURE or READING GUIDE: lecture cards come straight from his slides, so do those first. The dashed box at the bottom is the part that earns the depth points, so do not skip it.

Every section opens with a one-page picture sheet. If you only have ten minutes before the exam, look at those six pages and nothing else.

After the sections: diagrams to label from memory, a **Go deeper** appendix with a harder version of every question, then 131 multiple choice and 25 short answer questions, with the answer key at the very back.

Big Ideas — picture sheet

The six ideas the course is built on, plus how science is done. Every diagram from this section, no text. Ten-minute review.

The six ideas this whole course hangs on

Organization & emergence

parts combine into more

Structure relates to function

shape explains the job

Information storage & flow

DNA to RNA to protein

Energy & matter transformation

metabolism, energy flow

Interactions within systems

organism and environment

Evolution

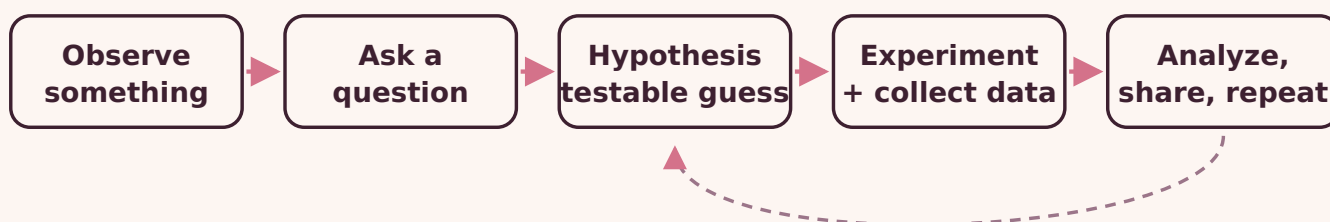
unity AND diversity of life

Evolution is the unifying theme. It accounts for both unity and diversity.

If a lecture topic feels random, ask which of these six it belongs to. That is how the course is built.

The scientific process

Peer review and repetition happen at every arrow, not just the last one



Results send you back to revise the hypothesis. Science loops, it does not end.

One experiment: does fertilizer make basil grow taller?

GROUP A — control

0 mL fertilizer



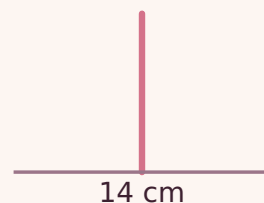
GROUP B

5 mL fertilizer



GROUP C

10 mL fertilizer



Independent = amount of fertilizer (what I change on purpose)

Dependent = height in cm (what I measure)

Controlled = same soil, light, water, pot, basil variety · **Control group** = Group A

Three words people mix up constantly

Hypothesis

Narrow, testable
proposed explanation

"Ginkgo improves
memory in Alzheimer's"

Scale: one question

Theory

Broad explanation
backed by tons of evidence

"Evolution by
natural selection"

Scale: whole field

Law

Describes WHAT happens,
not why. Often math.

" $F = ma$ "
Gravity, thermodynamics

Scale: a pattern

A hypothesis never "grows up" into a law. They answer different kinds of questions.

A hypothesis has to be able to fail

YES Testable

"Plants given fertilizer will
grow taller than plants without."

a result could prove this wrong

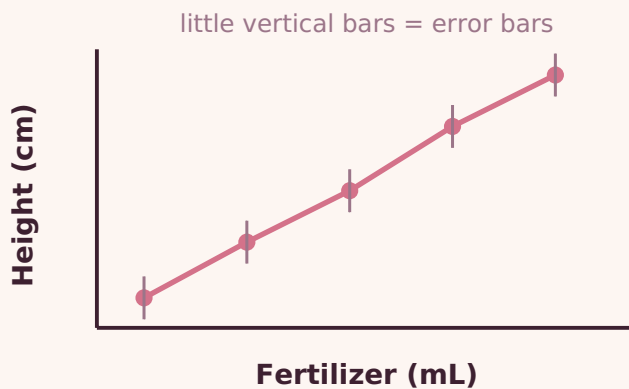
NO Not testable

"Plants grow because
they want to."

no result could ever prove this wrong

If nothing could disprove it, it is not a hypothesis. It is an opinion.

Building a graph, not just reading one



1. Independent on x, dependent on y

2. Label both axes WITH units

3. Pick the right type

bar = separate categories · line = continuous change
scatter = looking for a relationship

4. Scale evenly, start sensibly

uneven spacing is how graphs lie

5. Title it, and add error bars if you have them

Big Ideas

Ch 1 · concepts + method · 12 cards

IN LECTURE

What is biology?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Biology is the scientific study of life. That is the whole definition. The word 'scientific' is doing real work in it: biology studies life using the methods of science, not by opinion or authority.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Biology is the scientific study of life. Living things possess numerous characteristics that collectively set them apart from the nonliving world, and biology investigates those characteristics at every level of organization.

MEMORY TRICK

Bio = life, ology = study of. Do not overbuild this one. His slide is four words: the scientific study of life.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say it in one sentence, then say why 'scientific' matters in that sentence.

WRITE IT OUT

What are the six concepts that organize this whole course?

The six ideas this whole course hangs on

Organization & emergence

parts combine into more

Structure relates to function

shape explains the job

Information storage & flow

DNA to RNA to protein

Energy & matter transformation

metabolism, energy flow

Interactions within systems

organism and environment

Evolution

unity AND diversity of life

Evolution is the unifying theme. It accounts for both unity and diversity.

If a lecture topic feels random, ask which of these six it belongs to. That is how the course is built.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Organization and emergence. Structure relates to function. Information storage, flow, and exchange. Energy and matter transformation. Interactions within systems. Evolution. He said focusing on these helps you organize everything else, and evolution is the one that ties it all together.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The unifying concepts framing the course: organization and emergence across levels of biological organization; the relationship of structure to function at every level; storage, flow, and exchange of genetic information; transformation of energy and matter; interactions within and between systems and the environment; and evolution, which accounts for both the unity and the diversity of life.

MEMORY TRICK

If a topic feels random, ask which of the six it belongs to. Photosynthesis is energy and matter. The double helix is information. A red blood cell's shape is structure and function. Evolution is the umbrella over all of it.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

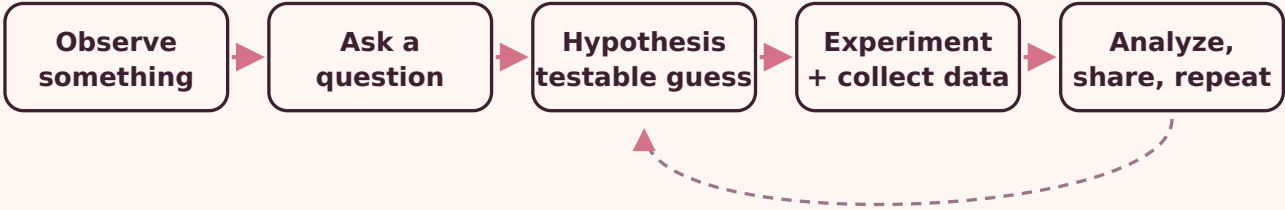
Take any topic from this unit and say which theme it belongs to and why. That is the kind of connection that earns depth points.

WRITE IT OUT

Walk through the steps of the scientific process.

The scientific process

Peer review and repetition happen at every arrow, not just the last one



Results send you back to revise the hypothesis. Science loops, it does not end.

IN PLAIN WORDS

You notice something strange, ask why, make a guess you can actually test, run a test, then look at what happened and tell other people. Their questions send you back to the start.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Observation leads to a question, which leads to a testable hypothesis with a prediction. An experiment generates data, data are analyzed, results are communicated through peer review and publication, and outcomes generate new questions. The process is iterative and non-linear, not a one-way staircase.

MEMORY TRICK

Ozzy Always Hides Extra Cash Regularly: Observe, Ask, Hypothesize, Experiment, Conclude, Repeat.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Your professor loves this one: what do scientists actually DO at each step? Say the verb out loud for each box.

WRITE IT OUT

Control vs independent vs dependent variable. Define all three using one experiment.

One experiment: does fertilizer make basil grow taller?

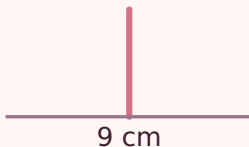
GROUP A — control

0 mL fertilizer



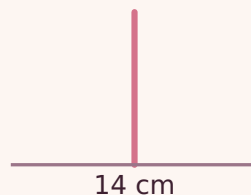
GROUP B

5 mL fertilizer



GROUP C

10 mL fertilizer



Independent = amount of fertilizer (what I change on purpose)

Dependent = height in cm (what I measure)

Controlled = same soil, light, water, pot, basil variety · **Control group** = Group A

IN PLAIN WORDS

Independent is the one thing you change on purpose. Dependent is what you measure to see if your change did anything. Controlled variables are everything you deliberately keep identical. The control group is the version that gets no treatment, so you have something to compare against.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The independent variable is manipulated by the researcher. The dependent variable is the measured response, and it depends on the independent variable. Controlled variables are held constant across all groups to eliminate confounding factors. The control group receives no experimental treatment and establishes the baseline.

MEMORY TRICK

I change the Independent. I Detect the Dependent. Control = everything constant, plus the group that gets nothing.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Careful, this trips people up: a controlled VARIABLE and a control GROUP are not the same thing. Say the difference out loud.

WRITE IT OUT

Hypothesis vs scientific theory vs scientific law.

Three words people mix up constantly

Hypothesis

Narrow, testable
proposed explanation

"Gingko improves
memory in Alzheimer's"

Scale: one question

Theory

Broad explanation
backed by tons of evidence

"Evolution by
natural selection"

Scale: whole field

Law

Describes WHAT happens,
not why. Often math.

"F = ma"
Gravity, thermodynamics

Scale: a pattern

A hypothesis never “grows up” into a law. They answer different kinds of questions.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A hypothesis is a small testable guess about one specific thing. A theory is a huge explanation that survived decades of testing. A law describes a pattern that always happens but does not explain why it happens.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A hypothesis is a proposed explanation for a narrow set of phenomena, based on prior observation and background knowledge, and it must be testable and falsifiable. A scientific theory is a broad, well-substantiated explanation supported by a large body of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry. A scientific law is a descriptive generalization, often mathematical, that states what consistently occurs under given conditions without explaining the mechanism.

MEMORY TRICK

Hypothesis = a Hunch. Theory = THE big explanation. Law = what happens, Like clockwork. A hypothesis does NOT get promoted into a theory and a theory does NOT become a law. They are different jobs, not ranks.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

The exam trap is 'just a theory.' Explain out loud why calling evolution 'just a theory' misuses the word.

WRITE IT OUT

What makes a hypothesis a good one?

A hypothesis has to be able to fail

YES Testable

"Plants given fertilizer will grow taller than plants without."

a result could prove this wrong

NO Not testable

"Plants grow because they want to."

no result could ever prove this wrong

If nothing could disprove it, it is not a hypothesis. It is an opinion.

IN PLAIN WORDS

You have to be able to prove it wrong. If no possible result would ever make you say 'okay, I was wrong,' it is not science.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A scientific hypothesis must be testable and falsifiable. It generates a specific prediction in if-then form, and the experiment must be capable of producing a result that would disconfirm it.

MEMORY TRICK

If nothing could prove it wrong, it is not a hypothesis. It is an opinion.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Give one testable hypothesis and one untestable claim, and say why the second one fails.

WRITE IT OUT

How do you read and interpret a scientific graph?

IN PLAIN WORDS

X axis is usually the thing the scientist changed. Y axis is what they measured. Read the title, read both axis labels with their units, then look for the trend before looking at any single point.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Convention places the independent variable on the x-axis and the dependent variable on the y-axis. Interpretation requires identifying the variables and units, the trend or relationship (positive, negative, none), the presence of error bars indicating variability, and the sample size before drawing conclusions.

MEMORY TRICK

DRY MIX. Dependent, Responding, Y-axis. Manipulated, Independent, X-axis.

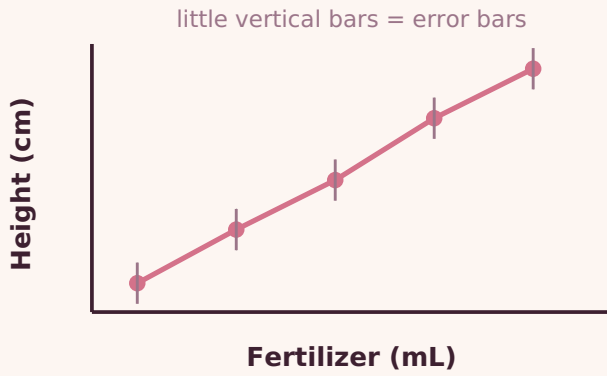
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Practice this sentence shape: 'As [independent] increased, [dependent] _____, which suggests _____.'

WRITE IT OUT

How do you construct a graph from your own data?

Building a graph, not just reading one



- 1. Independent on x, dependent on y
- 2. Label both axes WITH units
- 3. Pick the right type
bar = separate categories · line = continuous change
scatter = looking for a relationship
- 4. Scale evenly, start sensibly
uneven spacing is how graphs lie
- 5. Title it, and add error bars if you have them

IN PLAIN WORDS

Put what you changed on the bottom, what you measured on the side, label both with units, pick the right kind of graph, keep the spacing even, and give it a title. Bar graphs for separate categories, line graphs for something changing continuously, scatter plots when you are looking for a relationship.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Graph construction follows convention: independent variable on the x-axis, dependent variable on the y-axis, both axes labeled with units, consistent interval scaling, and a descriptive title. Bar graphs display discrete categorical data, line graphs display continuous data across a range, and scatter plots display the relationship between two continuous variables. Error bars represent variability, typically standard deviation or standard error, and overlapping error bars suggest the difference between groups may not be meaningful.

MEMORY TRICK

DRY MIX again for the axes. For picking the type: Bars for Buckets, Lines for Long continuous change, Scatter for Searching for a relationship.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Take the fertilizer experiment and describe the graph you would draw. Say the axis labels including the units, then say which type of graph and why.

WRITE IT OUT

How do you critique somebody else's experimental design?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Ask four things. Was there a control group? Did they only change one thing at a time? Did they test enough subjects? Could something else explain the result?

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Evaluate for: presence of an appropriate control group, isolation of a single independent variable, adequate sample size, random assignment, replication, blinding where relevant, and confounding variables that could offer an alternative explanation for the observed effect. Correlation in the data does not establish causation.

MEMORY TRICK

C-SOC: Control group, Sample size, One variable, Confounders.

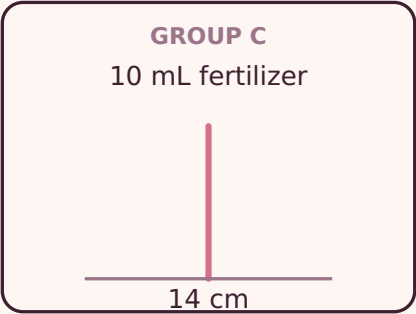
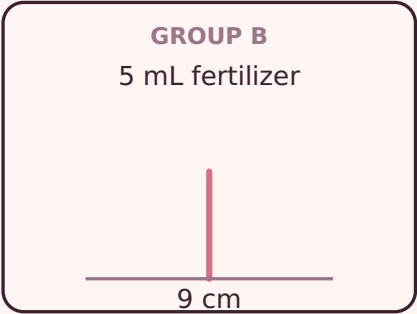
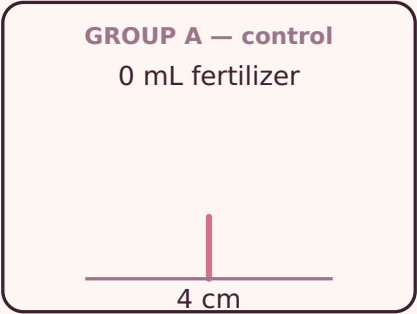
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Design a deliberately bad experiment, then tear it apart out loud. Finding the flaw is easier than describing it, so make yourself describe it.

WRITE IT OUT

How would you design an experiment from scratch?

One experiment: does fertilizer make basil grow taller?



Independent = amount of fertilizer (what I change on purpose)
Dependent = height in cm (what I measure)
Controlled = same soil, light, water, pot, basil variety · **Control group** = Group A

IN PLAIN WORDS

Start with a question, turn it into a testable hypothesis, decide the one thing you will change and the one thing you will measure, list everything you will keep identical, include a group that gets no treatment, use enough subjects, repeat it, then decide in advance how you will analyze the results.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Experimental design requires: a testable, falsifiable hypothesis with a specific prediction; a single manipulated independent variable; a defined and measurable dependent variable; identified controlled variables held constant across groups; an appropriate control group; adequate sample size with random assignment; replication; and a predetermined method of analysis. Blinding is used where expectation could bias measurement.

MEMORY TRICK

Same C-SOC checklist you use to tear an experiment apart, just run forwards instead of backwards. If you can critique one, you can build one.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Design an experiment testing whether background music affects study performance. Say the hypothesis, the independent variable, the dependent variable, three controlled variables, and the control group.

WRITE IT OUT

Why do scientists publish and peer review?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Because one person can fool themselves. Other experts pick the work apart, and other labs try to get the same result. Anything that survives that is far more trustworthy.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Peer review subjects methodology and conclusions to evaluation by independent experts before publication. Replication by independent groups tests reliability. Community scrutiny is a built-in error-correcting mechanism, and it is what distinguishes science from individual assertion.

MEMORY TRICK

Science is a group project where everybody is trying to catch your mistakes, and that is the feature, not the bug.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why a single unreplicated study is weak evidence, even if the scientist is famous.

WRITE IT OUT

Basic science vs applied science.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Basic science is finding out how something works because nobody knows yet. Applied science uses what we already know to solve a specific problem.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Basic (pure) science expands fundamental knowledge without a predetermined practical application. Applied science uses existing knowledge to address a defined problem. Basic research frequently enables later applied breakthroughs that were not foreseeable at the time.

MEMORY TRICK

Basic asks 'how does this work?' Applied asks 'how do I fix this?' Basic today is applied in twenty years.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

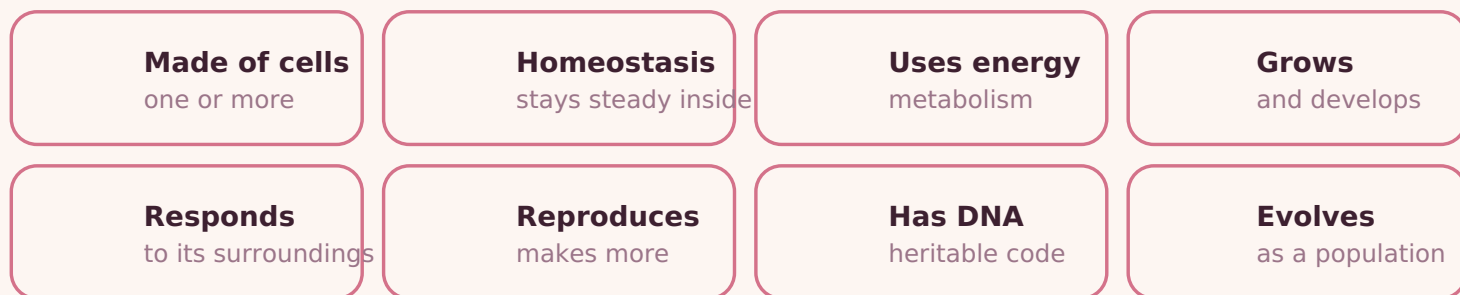
Give a real example where basic research later made a medical treatment possible.

WRITE IT OUT

What Is Life — picture sheet

What counts as alive, framed around the Mars rover question. Every diagram from this section, no text. Ten-minute review.

The checklist for being alive



A virus only ticks the last two boxes.

No cells, no metabolism, no homeostasis, no independent reproduction.

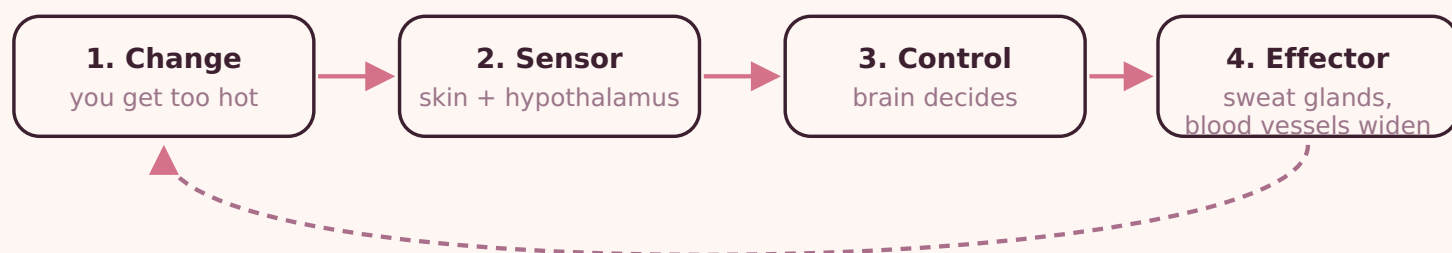
That is the whole “are viruses alive” debate in one picture.

Scoring a virus against the checklist

Made of cells	NO
Own metabolism / energy	NO
Homeostasis	NO
Grows and develops	NO
Reproduces on its own	NO
Has genetic material	YES
Evolves by natural selection	YES

Two out of seven. That is why the answer is “on the border of life,” not a plain yes or no.

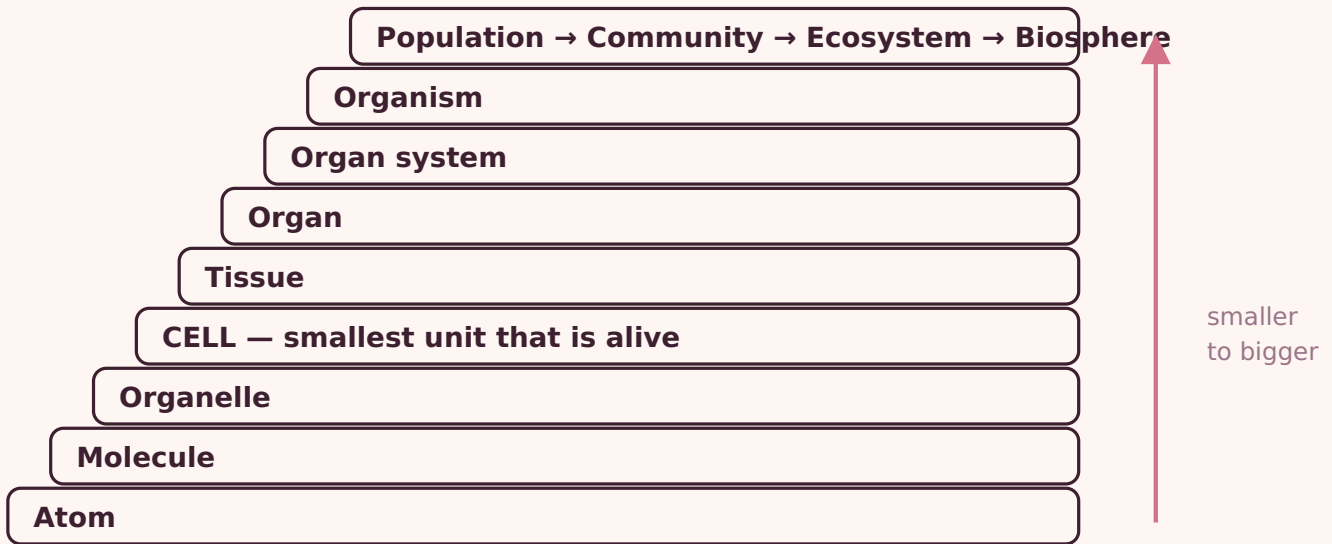
Negative feedback: how your body holds the line



5. Temperature drops back down, which switches the response off

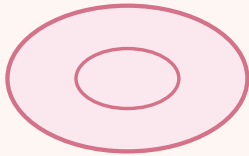
It is called **NEGATIVE** feedback because the response reverses the original change.

Levels of biological organization



Each step up gains properties the step below did not have. That is emergence.

Shape is the reason it can do its job



red blood cell
dented disc, no nucleus

More surface area

more room to pick up oxygen

Flexible and thin

squeezes single file through capillaries

No nucleus

more space inside for hemoglobin

The pattern to use

"It is shaped like ____,
which means it can ____,
which is why it ____."

Works for mitochondria folds,
root hairs, hair keratin, anything.

What Is Life

Ch 1.2 · 9 cards

IN LECTURE

What properties define something as alive?

The checklist for being alive

Made of cells
one or more

Homeostasis
stays steady inside

Uses energy
metabolism

Grows
and develops

Responds
to its surroundings

Reproduces
makes more

Has DNA
heritable code

Evolves
as a population

A virus only ticks the last two boxes.

No cells, no metabolism, no homeostasis, no independent reproduction.
That is the whole “are viruses alive” debate in one picture.

IN PLAIN WORDS

His list, from the slide: order, regulation, growth and development, energy processing, response to the environment, reproduction, and evolution. Biologists call something alive if it displays these properties collectively, not just one or two.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The properties by which biologists identify life, as presented in lecture: order (organization and complexity), regulation (maintenance of homeostasis), growth and development, energy processing (metabolism, the transformation of energy and matter), response to the environment, reproduction, and evolutionary adaptation. Living things possess these characteristics collectively; the collection, rather than any single item, distinguishes living from nonliving.

MEMORY TRICK

Seven on his slide, with pictures: pine cone (order), lizard (regulation), hatching reptile (growth and development), cheetah eating (energy processing), Venus flytrap (response), monkey and baby (reproduction), leaf insect (evolution). Picture the slide and the list comes back.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

List all seven from memory, then do what the rover activity asked: decide what evidence would convince you those Martian objects were alive.

WRITE IT OUT

Are viruses alive? Argue both sides.

Scoring a virus against the checklist

Made of cells	NO
Own metabolism / energy	NO
Homeostasis	NO
Grows and develops	NO
Reproduces on its own	NO
Has genetic material	YES
Evolves by natural selection	YES

Two out of seven. That is why the answer is “on the border of life,” not a plain yes or no.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Not alive: a virus is not made of cells, it cannot make its own energy, and it cannot copy itself without hijacking someone else's machinery. Alive: it carries genetic material, it evolves fast, and it reproduces once it is inside a host.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Arguments against life status: viruses are acellular, lack metabolic machinery and ribosomes, cannot generate ATP, and are obligate intracellular parasites incapable of autonomous replication. Arguments for: they possess nucleic acid genomes, undergo mutation and natural selection, replicate and produce progeny, and occupy ecological roles. Many biologists resolve this by describing viruses as being at the border of life, or as alive only within a host cell.

MEMORY TRICK

A virus is a USB stick. It holds real information, but plug it into nothing and it does nothing forever.

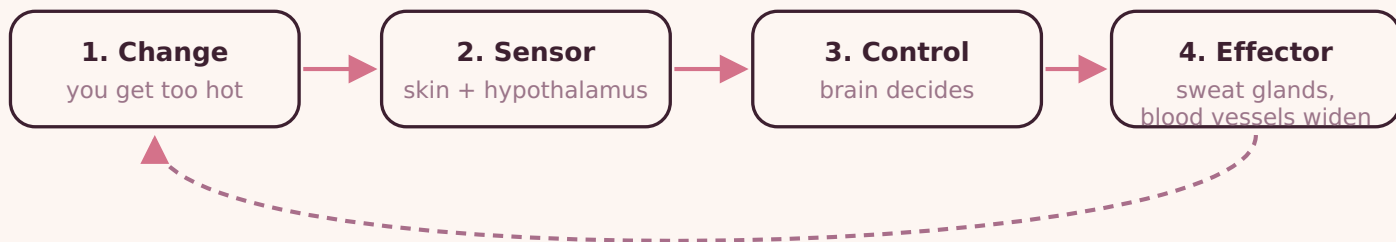
SAY IT OUT LOUD

The professor assigned a whole reading on this, so it is almost certainly a short answer. Practice a 4-sentence answer: one side, other side, the specific property that decides it, your position.

WRITE IT OUT

What is homeostasis? Give an example.

Negative feedback: how your body holds the line



5. Temperature drops back down, which switches the response off

It is called **NEGATIVE** feedback because the response reverses the original change.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Keeping your insides steady even when the outside changes. You stay around 98.6 F whether it is winter or summer.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Homeostasis is the maintenance of a relatively stable internal environment despite external fluctuation, achieved through negative feedback loops involving a sensor, a control center, and an effector. Examples include thermoregulation by sweating and shivering, blood glucose regulation by insulin and glucagon, and blood pH held near 7.4 by buffer systems.

MEMORY TRICK

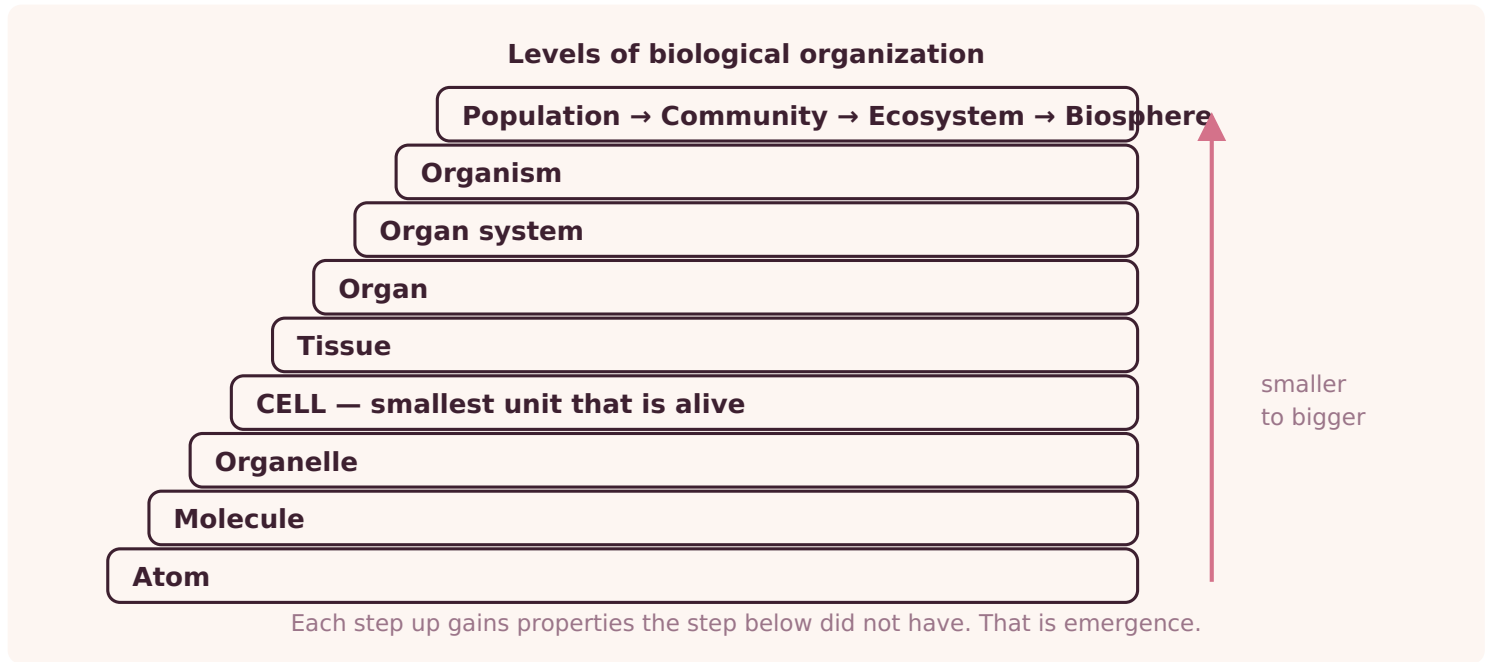
Home + stasis = keeping the house the same. A thermostat is literally a homeostasis machine.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Trace one loop out loud: you get too hot, then what senses it, then what responds, then what happens to the temperature.

WRITE IT OUT

Rank the levels of biological organization.



IN PLAIN WORDS

His diagram runs molecules, organelles, cells, tissues, organs, organisms, populations, communities, ecosystems, biosphere. Each step up gains properties the level below did not have, and he labels those EMERGENT PROPERTIES in red on the slide.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Levels of biological organization, as diagrammed in lecture: molecules, organelles, cells, tissues, organs, organisms, populations, communities, ecosystems, and the biosphere. Properties that appear at a higher level and are absent from the components at the level below are emergent properties. Life is characterized by complexity and by this organization into levels.

MEMORY TRICK

All My Organs Can Take Over Our Own Planet, Creating Excellent Biology: Atom, Molecule, Organelle, Cell, Tissue, Organ, Organ system, Organism, Population, Community, Ecosystem, Biosphere.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say the ladder in order from his diagram, then say where emergent properties appear and give one example.

WRITE IT OUT

What is emergence? Give an example using two levels.

IN PLAIN WORDS

When you combine parts, the combination can do something none of the parts could do alone. A single heart muscle cell twitches. Put millions together into a heart and you get a pump that moves blood through a whole body.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Emergent properties are characteristics that arise from the specific arrangement and interaction of components at a lower level of organization, and that are not present in the isolated components. Example: individual neurons transmit electrical signals, but the organized network of neurons in a brain produces memory and consciousness, which no single neuron possesses.

MEMORY TRICK

The wetness of water. One H₂O molecule is not wet. A glass of them is. Nothing was added except arrangement.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Make up your OWN emergence example using two levels from the ladder. Reciting the textbook one does not count unless you can explain the logic behind it.

WRITE IT OUT

READING GUIDE

What is reductionism? Give an example using two levels.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Breaking something complicated into its pieces to understand it. You study individual DNA molecules to understand how a whole organism inherits traits.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Reductionism is the approach of explaining a complex system by analyzing its simpler constituent parts. Example: studying the molecular structure of DNA (molecule level) to explain heredity in organisms (organism level). Reductionism is powerful but incomplete, because it can miss emergent properties that only exist at higher levels.

MEMORY TRICK

Reduce = zoom IN. Emerge = zoom OUT. They are opposite directions on the same ladder, and biology needs both.

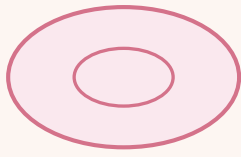
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why reductionism alone is not enough to understand a living thing. Link it back to emergence.

WRITE IT OUT

Give an example of structure relating to function.

Shape is the reason it can do its job



red blood cell
dented disc, no nucleus

More surface area

more room to pick up oxygen

Flexible and thin

squeezes single file through capillaries

No nucleus

more space inside for hemoglobin

The pattern to use

"It is shaped like ___,
which means it can ___,
which is why it ___."

Works for mitochondria folds,
root hairs, hair keratin, anything.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The shape of a thing is the reason it can do its job. Red blood cells are flat discs with a dent in the middle, which gives them more surface area to grab oxygen and lets them squeeze through narrow capillaries.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Form determines function at every level of biology. Examples: the biconcave disc of an erythrocyte maximizes surface-area-to-volume ratio for gas exchange; the alpha helix of keratin provides tensile strength in hair; root hairs increase absorptive surface area; the folded cristae of mitochondria increase the membrane area available for ATP synthesis.

MEMORY TRICK

If you can describe the shape, you can usually guess the job. A funnel, a hook, a net, a sponge. Biology reuses the same shapes for the same reasons.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Pick a structure and reason forward: 'it is shaped like ___, which means it can ___, which is why it ___.'

WRITE IT OUT

IN LECTURE

What is the most fundamental unit of life, and why?

IN PLAIN WORDS

The cell. It is the smallest thing that can do everything on the life checklist by itself. Anything smaller, like an organelle or a molecule, cannot survive alone.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The cell is the basic unit of life, as stated in cell theory: all living organisms are composed of one or more cells, the cell is the fundamental unit of structure and function, and all cells arise from pre-existing cells. The cell is the smallest entity that independently exhibits all characteristics of life, including metabolism, homeostasis, and reproduction.

MEMORY TRICK

Cells are the smallest thing that can still tick every box on the life checklist.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why a mitochondrion is not the fundamental unit of life even though it has DNA.

WRITE IT OUT

Put natural selection in your own words.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Individuals in a population are all slightly different. Some of those differences make survival and reproduction easier in that particular environment. Those individuals have more offspring, and their traits become more common over generations. The environment does the choosing.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Natural selection requires: heritable variation within a population, overproduction of offspring, differential survival and reproduction based on that variation, and change in allele frequency over generations. Individuals do not evolve; populations do. Selection acts on existing variation and does not create traits on demand.

MEMORY TRICK

VISTA: Variation, Inheritance, Selection, Time, Adaptation. Or shorter: nature does not create the winners, it just removes the losers.

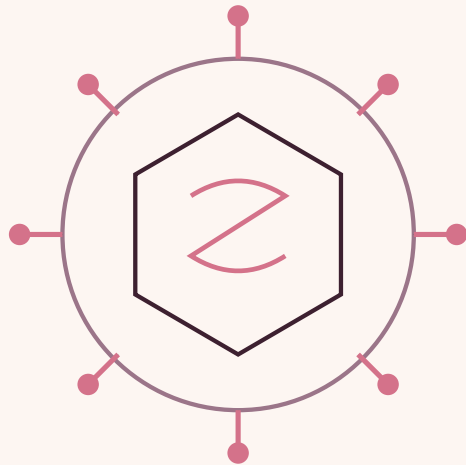
SAY IT OUT LOUD

The most common exam error is saying an organism 'adapts on purpose' or 'evolves because it needs to.' Say the correct version out loud until the wrong phrasing feels weird.

WRITE IT OUT

Viruses — picture sheet

Taught inside Chapter 1, as the test case for the definition of life. Every diagram from this section, no text. Ten-minute review.



Parts of a virus

Spikes (glycoproteins)

the key that fits a host cell's lock. No match, no infection.

Envelope

stolen host membrane. Not all viruses have one. Soap destroys it.

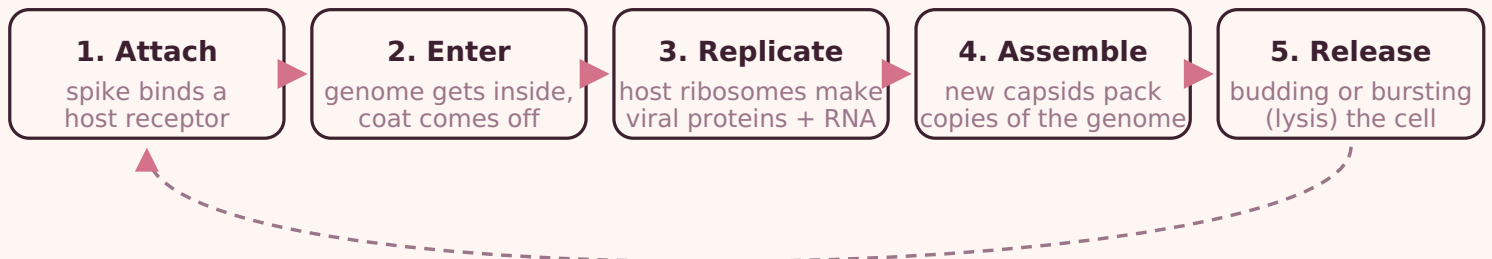
Capsid

protein shell built from repeating subunits. Protects the cargo.

Nucleic acid

DNA or RNA, single or double stranded. The instructions. That is

How an RNA virus hijacks a cell



New viruses go find new cells. One infected cell can release thousands.

The whole point: a virus owns no ribosomes, no enzymes, no ATP. Step 3 is impossible without a host.

Why the flu shot changes every year

DNA polymerase

ATGCATG
ATGCATG

proofreads and fixes its mistakes

RNA polymerase

AUGCAUG
AUGAAUG

no proofreading, the error stays in

Every uncorrected error is a mutation. Multiply by thousands of copies per infected cell and new variants appear fast.

This is natural selection happening in real time, inside a body.

Scoring a virus against the checklist

Made of cells	NO
Own metabolism / energy	NO
Homeostasis	NO
Grows and develops	NO
Reproduces on its own	NO
Has genetic material	YES
Evolves by natural selection	YES

Two out of seven. That is why the answer is “on the border of life,” not a plain yes or no.

The checklist for being alive

Made of cells

one or more

Homeostasis

stays steady inside

Uses energy

metabolism

Grows

and develops

Responds

to its surroundings

Reproduces

makes more

Has DNA

heritable code

Evolves

as a population

A virus only ticks the last two boxes.

No cells, no metabolism, no homeostasis, no independent reproduction.

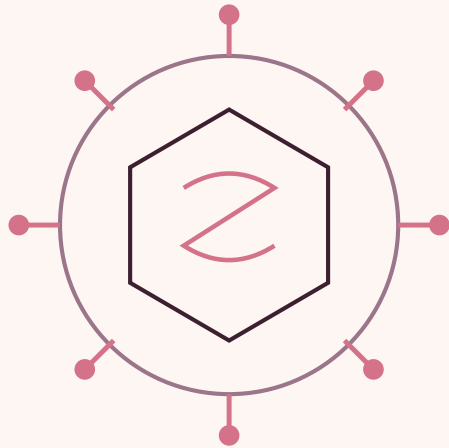
That is the whole “are viruses alive” debate in one picture.

Viruses

Ch 1 · with What Is Life · 8 cards

IN LECTURE

Describe the basic structure of a virus.



Parts of a virus

Spikes (glycoproteins)

the key that fits a host cell's lock. No match, no infection.

Envelope

stolen host membrane. Not all viruses have one. Soap destroys it.

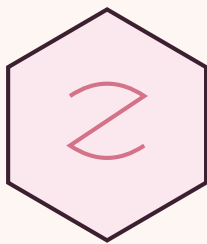
Capsid

protein shell built from repeating subunits. Protects the cargo.

Nucleic acid

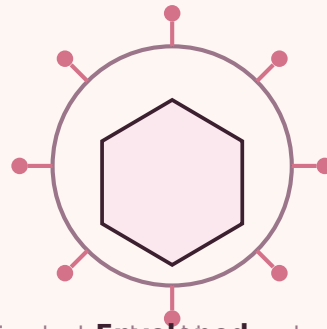
DNA or RNA, single or double stranded. The instructions. That is all.

Naked vs enveloped



Naked

capsid only - tough, survives on surfaces



Enveloped

stolen host membrane, and it is made of lipid. Soap pulls lipids apart, which is why handwashing wrecks enveloped viruses like

IN PLAIN WORDS

His definition: a virus is a submicroscopic infectious entity consisting of genetic material in a protein shell. That is it. A single particle is a virion. The shell is the capsid, built from repeating subunits called capsomeres. Some also have a viral envelope with proteins and glycoproteins on it. They run 20 to 500 nanometers and come as rods, spheres, or polyhedral shapes.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A virus is a submicroscopic infectious entity consisting of genetic material, DNA or RNA, enclosed in a protein shell. A single virus particle is termed a virion. The capsid is assembled from repeating protein subunits called capsomeres. Size ranges from roughly 20 to 500 nanometers. Morphologies include rods, spheres, and polyhedral forms. Some viruses possess a viral envelope derived from host membrane, bearing proteins and glycoproteins. Examples covered: bacteriophage (DNA), tobacco mosaic virus (RNA), adenovirus (DNA, naked, 70 to 90 nm), influenza virus (RNA, enveloped, 80 to 200 nm).

MEMORY TRICK

VIRION is one particle. CAPSID is the shell, made of CAPSOMERES, which are the repeating bricks. He used those exact words, so use them back.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say the parts using his vocabulary: virion, capsid, capsomeres, envelope, glycoproteins, genetic material. Then name which of his four examples are enveloped and which are naked.

WRITE IT OUT

Why is a virus so specific about which cells it infects?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Viruses are obligate intracellular parasites, meaning they cannot do anything without being inside a host cell. Host range is the set of species a given virus can infect. Measles has a narrow host range; West Nile is broad. Some viruses are even tissue specific. It works by lock and key: the virus's surface proteins have to fit the host cell's surface proteins.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Viruses are obligate intracellular parasites. Host range is the range of species a specific virus can infect, and it varies widely: measles has a narrow host range while West Nile virus is broad. Some viruses additionally exhibit tissue tropism, infecting only particular cell types within a host. Specificity results from a lock-and-key fit between viral surface proteins and host cell surface receptor proteins.

MEMORY TRICK

Lock and key, his words. Measles is narrow, West Nile is broad. That specific comparison was on the slide.

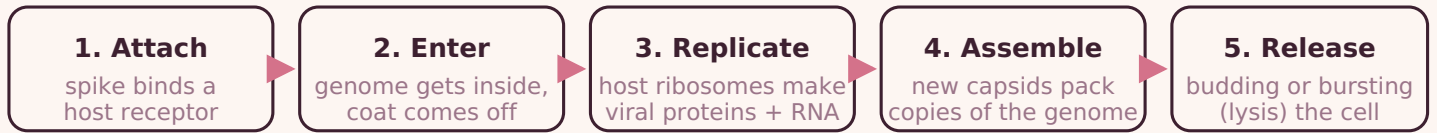
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Define host range and give his two contrasting examples. Then explain what physically determines it.

WRITE IT OUT

Walk through RNA virus replication inside a host cell.

How an RNA virus hijacks a cell



New viruses go find new cells. One infected cell can release thousands.

The whole point: a virus owns no ribosomes, no enzymes, no ATP. Step 3 is impossible without a host.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Attach to the cell, get inside and shed the coat, hijack the cell's machinery to copy the genome and make viral proteins, assemble new viruses, then leave by budding out or bursting the cell open.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The general cycle is attachment (spike binds host receptor), entry and uncoating (genome enters the cytoplasm), replication and biosynthesis (host ribosomes translate viral proteins; viral RNA-dependent RNA polymerase replicates the genome), assembly (new genomes packaged into newly synthesized capsids), and release by budding, which preserves the cell temporarily, or by lysis, which destroys it. RNA viruses mutate rapidly because RNA-dependent RNA polymerase lacks proofreading activity, which is why influenza vaccines are reformulated annually.

MEMORY TRICK

AURAR, say it as 'a roar': Attach, Uncoat, Replicate, Assemble, Release. The virus brings instructions and nothing else. Every tool belongs to the host.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Which step is literally impossible without a host, and why? That is the answer that decides the 'are viruses alive' question.

WRITE IT OUT

Why do RNA viruses mutate so fast?

Why the flu shot changes every year

DNA polymerase

ATGCATG
ATGCATG

proofreads and fixes its mistakes

RNA polymerase

AUGCAUG
AUGAAUG

no proofreading, the error stays in

Every uncorrected error is a mutation. Multiply by thousands of copies per infected cell and new variants appear fast.
This is natural selection happening in real time, inside a body.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The enzyme copying their genome makes mistakes and has no spell-check. Every mistake is a mutation, and with millions of copies made per infection, useful mutations show up fast.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

RNA-dependent RNA polymerase lacks the 3' to 5' exonuclease proofreading activity found in DNA polymerases, resulting in error rates orders of magnitude higher than DNA replication. Combined with enormous burst sizes and short generation times, this produces high genetic variability, rapid evolution of new variants, immune escape, and antiviral resistance.

MEMORY TRICK

No spell-check. DNA polymerase proofreads, RNA polymerase does not. That single missing feature explains flu shots every year.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Connect this to Chapter 1: how is viral variant emergence a real-time demonstration of natural selection?

WRITE IT OUT

Build a full answer to 'are viruses alive?'

Scoring a virus against the checklist

Made of cells	NO
Own metabolism / energy	NO
Homeostasis	NO
Grows and develops	NO
Reproduces on its own	NO
Has genetic material	YES
Evolves by natural selection	YES

Two out of seven. That is why the answer is “on the border of life,” not a plain yes or no.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Say what a virus can do (carry genes, reproduce inside a host, evolve), say what it cannot do (make energy, make proteins, reproduce alone, it is not even made of cells), then pick the property you think decides it, and commit to a position.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Case against: viruses are acellular, violating cell theory; they possess no metabolism, no ribosomes, and no capacity to generate ATP; they cannot reproduce independently and are obligate intracellular parasites; outside a host they are chemically inert particles. Case for: they possess genetic material, they replicate and produce progeny, they undergo mutation and natural selection, and they exert ecological and evolutionary pressure on all cellular life. Many biologists describe viruses as replicating entities at the boundary of life, or as alive only in the context of an infected cell.

MEMORY TRICK

Structure the answer: cannot, can, decide. The professor is grading the reasoning and the vocabulary, not which side you pick.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say a full 5-sentence answer out loud, timed. This is the single most likely short-answer question on the whole exam.

WRITE IT OUT

How do viruses fit into the characteristics-of-life checklist?

The checklist for being alive

Made of cells

one or more

Homeostasis

stays steady inside

Uses energy

metabolism

Grows

and develops

Responds

to its surroundings

Reproduces

makes more

Has DNA

heritable code

Evolves

as a population

A virus only ticks the last two boxes.

No cells, no metabolism, no homeostasis, no independent reproduction.

That is the whole “are viruses alive” debate in one picture.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Go down the list. Cells? No. Metabolism? No. Homeostasis? No. Response to stimuli? Arguably no. Growth and development? No. Reproduction? Only with help. Heredity? Yes. Evolution? Yes, and fast.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Applying the standard criteria: viruses fail cellular organization, independent metabolism, homeostasis, and autonomous growth. Reproduction occurs only within a host cell, so it is not independent. Viruses clearly satisfy heredity through nucleic acid genomes and evolutionary adaptation through mutation and selection. Meeting two of roughly eight criteria is why classification remains contested.

MEMORY TRICK

Two out of eight. She should be able to walk the checklist item by item and score the virus, because that is exactly what a good answer looks like.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Walk the whole checklist aloud, giving a yes or no plus one reason for each. Do it twice.

WRITE IT OUT

What is a virocell, and what did Patrick Forterre argue?

Scoring a virus against the checklist

Made of cells	NO
Own metabolism / energy	NO
Homeostasis	NO
Grows and develops	NO
Reproduces on its own	NO
Has genetic material	YES
Evolves by natural selection	YES

Two out of seven. That is why the answer is “on the border of life,” not a plain yes or no.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Forterre is a French microbiologist with a different way of settling the 'are viruses alive' argument. He says the virion, the particle floating around outside, is like a seed or a spore: not doing anything, just a dormant package. The living thing is the virocell, meaning the infected host cell taken together with the virus running it. In that view the virocell is a genuinely new organism whose job is producing new virions.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Patrick Forterre, a French microbiologist, proposed that a virion is analogous to the seed or spore of a virocell, the complex formed by a virus and its host cell. Under this framework, the virocell constitutes a novel organism whose function is the production of new virions. This reframes the question: rather than asking whether the inert particle is alive, it identifies the infected cell as the living form of the virus.

MEMORY TRICK

VIRION = the seed. VIROCELL = the plant. A seed is not doing much on its own, but nobody says a seed proves plants are not alive.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain Forterre's argument in three sentences, then say whether you find it convincing and why. He spent a whole slide on this, which means he wants you to be able to discuss it, not just recite it.

WRITE IT OUT

What is NASA's definition of life, and why does he use it?

The checklist for being alive

Made of cells

one or more

Homeostasis

stays steady inside

Uses energy

metabolism

Grows

and develops

Responds

to its surroundings

Reproduces

makes more

Has DNA

heritable code

Evolves

as a population

A virus only ticks the last two boxes.

No cells, no metabolism, no homeostasis, no independent reproduction.

That is the whole “are viruses alive” debate in one picture.

IN PLAIN WORDS

NASA says life is a self-sustained chemical system capable of undergoing Darwinian evolution. He opened the unit with a Mars rover finding objects that look like microbes, and this is the definition his framing keeps coming back to.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

NASA's working definition: life is a self-sustained chemical system capable of undergoing Darwinian evolution. It is used in astrobiology because it is substrate-independent, making no assumption about carbon, water, or cells, and therefore applicable to potential life that does not resemble Earth life. It sets two requirements: self-sustaining chemistry and heritable variation under selection.

MEMORY TRICK

Two requirements only: it keeps ITSELF going, and it EVOLVES. Notice that a virus fails the first and passes the second.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

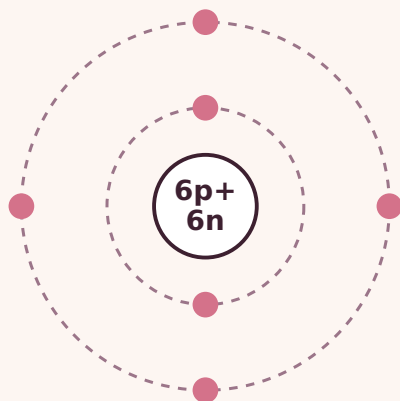
Apply NASA's definition to a virus out loud. It undergoes Darwinian evolution, clearly. But it is not self-sustained, because it cannot run its own chemistry. That is a clean, short, full-credit answer.

WRITE IT OUT

Chemistry & Water — picture sheet

Atoms, bonds, water and pH. The heaviest section, with calculations. Every diagram from this section, no text. Ten-minute review.

Carbon atom



Atomic number = 6

protons only. This is the ID badge.

Mass number = 12

protons + neutrons

Inner shell holds 2

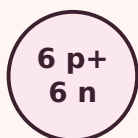
Next shell wants 8 (octet)

Carbon has 4 out there, needs 4 more, so it forms 4 bonds. Every time.

nucleus = protons (+) and neutrons (0) · electrons (–) orbit in shells

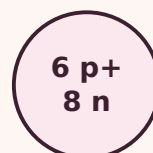
Isotopes: same element, extra neutrons

Carbon-12



stable, most common

Carbon-14



unstable, decays over time

h are still carbon and behave identically in chemistry. Only the weight and stability differ, which is what makes carbon-14

How an ion is made

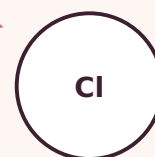
electron is handed over, not shared



1 lonely electron
in the outer shell

Na⁺
cation, positive

Cl⁻
anion, negative

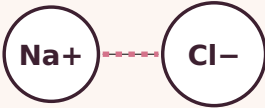


7 in the outer shell,
needs exactly 1 more

Opposite charges attract, and that attraction IS the ionic bond. In water it lets go and they separate again.

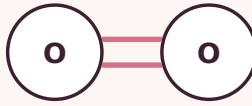
Three bonds, strongest to weakest

Ionic



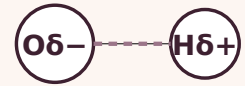
Electron is fully GIVEN away.
Opposite charges attract.
Falls apart in water → ions

Covalent



Electrons are SHARED.
Equal share = nonpolar
Unequal share = polar
Strongest of the three

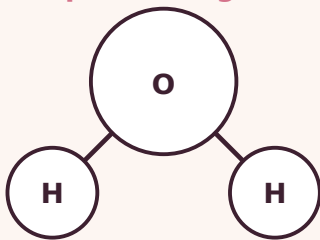
Hydrogen



No sharing at all. Just a weak tug between a $\delta+$ H and a nearby $\delta-$ O, N or F.
Weak alone, mighty in bulk

Why water is weird (and why you are alive because of it)

$\delta-$ partial negative



$\delta+$ $\delta+$
Oxygen hogs the shared electrons (higher electronegativity) → polar

1. Cohesion & adhesion

water sticks to water, and to other stuff → water climbs a tree trunk

2. High heat capacity

takes a lot of heat to warm up → your body temp stays steady

3. High heat of vaporization

escaping steam carries heat off → sweating cools you down

4. Universal solvent

dissolves anything polar or charged → blood, cytoplasm, ocean

All four come from ONE thing: hydrogen bonds between polar water molec

Water's four properties, in lecture order

Polarity causes all four. Every one traces back to hydrogen bonding.

1. "Sticky" behavior

Cohesion: water to water
Adhesion: water to other surfaces
water up a tree, surface tension, interstitial fluid

2. High heat capacity

Absorbs and releases a lot of heat with little temperature change
breaking and re-forming H bonds · coastal vs inland CA

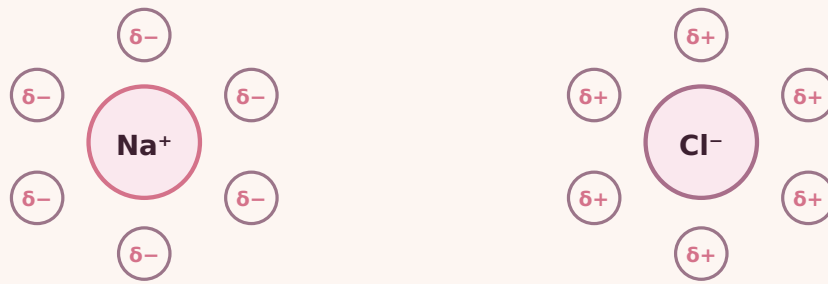
3. Exists in three states

Solid, liquid, gas · ice FLOATS
because molecules sit farther apart
drives the water cycle, distributes nutrients

4. Versatile solvent

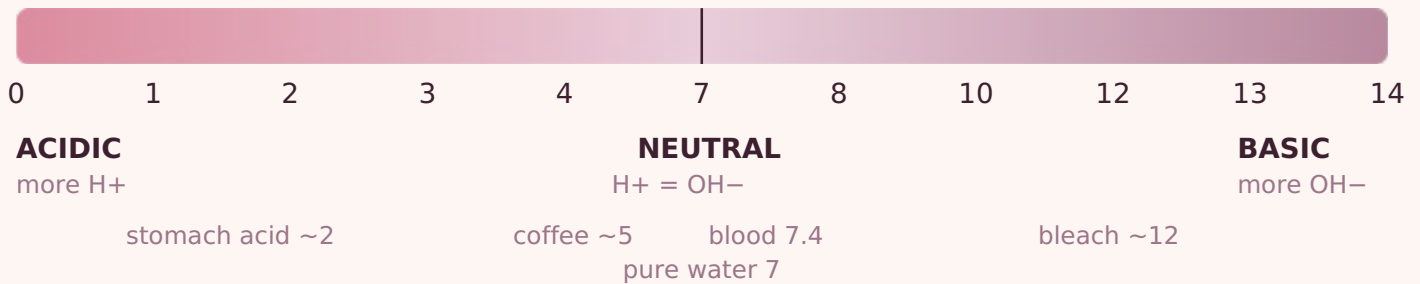
Polar dissolves polar: like dissolves like
Solvent = the dissolver · Solute = the dissolved
blood, cytoplasm, sap · ionic solutes dissociate

Why water dissolves salt



Water surrounds each ion with its opposite partial charge. That jacket is a hydration shell, and it keeps the ions apart so they cannot snap back together. Nonpolar oil gets no such jacket.

The pH scale



step is 10×. pH 4 is TEN times more acidic than pH 5, not one unit more. Buffers soak up spare H⁺ or OH⁻ to hold blood at

The three equations that solve every pH problem

$$[\text{H}^+] \times [\text{OH}^-] = 10^{-14}$$

$$\text{pH} = -\log [\text{H}^+]$$

$$[\text{H}^+] = 10^{-\text{pH}}$$

Worked: a solution has pH 3.

$[\text{H}^+] = 10^{-3} \text{ M}$ — just flip the sign of the pH

$[\text{OH}^-] = 10^{-14} \div 10^{-3} = 10^{-11} \text{ M}$ — subtract the exponents

Check: $-3 + -11 = -14$ ✓ the two exponents ALWAYS add to -14

Going from pH 4 to pH 6 is 2 units, so $[\text{H}^+]$ changed by $10^2 = 100\times$, and it DECREASED because pH went up.

Strong vs weak: how much of it lets go of its H⁺

STRONG acid (HCl)



nearly every molecule releases its H⁺
dissociates completely, no going back

WEAK acid (carbonic)



only a few let go, and they can take it back
a reversible reaction, both directions at once

That reversibility is exactly what makes a weak acid able to work as a buffer. A strong acid cannot buffer anything, because it has nothing left to give back.

The blood buffer equation he put on a slide



blood gets **ACIDIC** (extra H^+) → shifts **LEFT**

H^+ gets mopped up into H_2CO_3

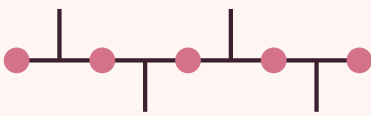
blood gets **BASIC** → shifts **RIGHT**



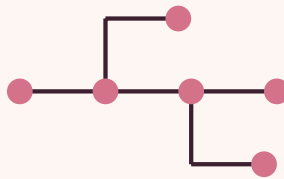
H^+ is released back

effect either way: pH is pulled back toward 7.35 to 7.45. Below 7.35 is acidosis, above 7.45 is alkalosis. Past 6.8 or 8.0, de

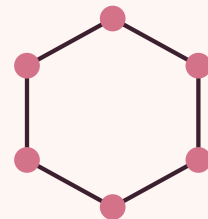
Four bonds is why carbon can build anything



Straight chain



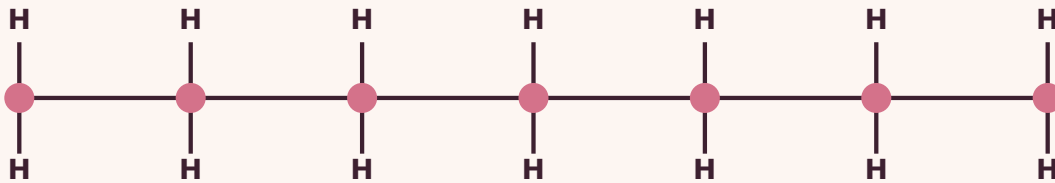
Branched



Ring

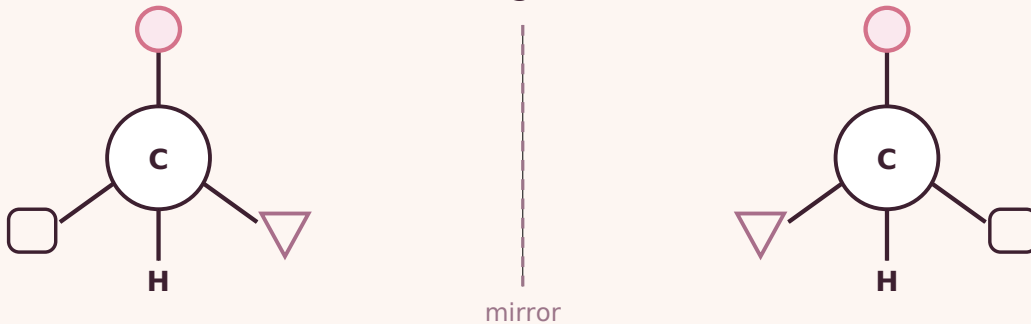
onds would only give you a line. Three gives you flat shapes. Four gives you three dimensions, and life needs three dimer

A hydrocarbon: only C and H, packed with energy



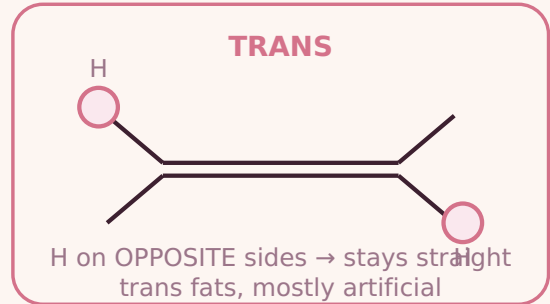
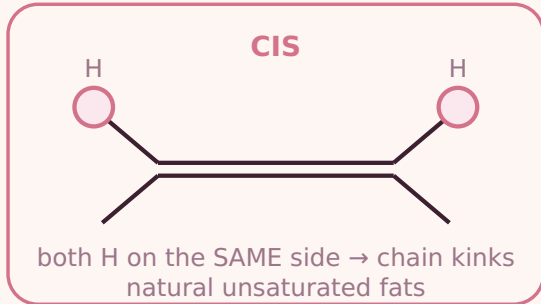
f those C-H bonds is a little packed battery, and none of them are polar, so the whole chain hides from water. That is a fa

Enantiomers: mirror images that are not the same



groups, same central carbon, but you cannot rotate one to land on the other. Your enzymes are shaped gloves, so only on

Cis vs trans: same bonds, different side of the double bond



A double bond cannot spin, which is the whole reason these are two different molecules instead of one.

Functional groups: the “charms” clipped onto a carbon skeleton

Hydroxyl —OH

polar · makes things water-loving
alcohols, sugars

Carbonyl —C=O

polar · ketone (middle) or
aldehyde (end of chain)

Carboxyl —COOH

ACIDIC · donates H⁺
amino acids, fatty acids

Amino —NH₂

BASIC · accepts H⁺
amino acids, the other end

Sulfhydryl —SH

forms disulfide bridges
locks protein shape (hair!)

Phosphate —PO₄²⁻

negative · energy transfer
ATP, DNA backbone, phospholipids

Methyl —CH₃

NONPOLAR · no reactivity
a tag, not a tool. Marks DNA.

Chemistry & Water

Ch 2 · 24 cards

IN LECTURE

What is matter, and what is an element?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Matter is anything that takes up space and has mass. An element is a pure substance that cannot be broken down any further by chemical means. There are 118 of them, and just four make up about 96 percent of your body.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Matter is any substance possessing mass and occupying volume. An element is a substance composed of a single type of atom that cannot be decomposed into simpler substances by ordinary chemical reactions. Carbon, hydrogen, oxygen, and nitrogen constitute approximately 96 percent of living matter by mass.

MEMORY TRICK

CHON is the four horsemen of biology: Carbon, Hydrogen, Oxygen, Nitrogen. Add phosphorus and sulfur and you have basically everything: C HOPKINS.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

What makes one element different from another? Answer with a number, not a word.

WRITE IT OUT

IN LECTURE

Element vs compound vs molecule. Which one is more inclusive?

IN PLAIN WORDS

An element is a pure substance that cannot be broken down by reactions. A compound is two or more DIFFERENT elements combined. A molecule is two or more atoms bonded together, whether they are the same or different. So molecule is the more inclusive term: O2 is a molecule but not a compound, while H2O is both.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

An element is a pure substance that cannot be decomposed into simpler substances by chemical reaction. A compound consists of two or more different elements combined in a fixed ratio. A molecule is two or more atoms held together by covalent bonds, regardless of whether those atoms are identical. Molecule is therefore the more inclusive category: O2 is a molecule but not a compound; H2O is both a molecule and a compound.

MEMORY TRICK

All compounds are molecules, but not all molecules are compounds. Compound needs DIFFERENT elements. O2 is just oxygen holding hands with itself.

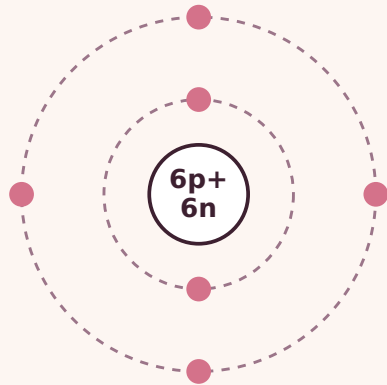
SAY IT OUT LOUD

He asked this directly on the slide: which is more inclusive? Say the answer and give one example that is a molecule but not a compound.

WRITE IT OUT

Describe the structure of an atom.

Carbon atom



Atomic number = 6

protons only. This is the ID badge.

Mass number = 12

protons + neutrons

Inner shell holds 2

Next shell wants 8 (octet)

Carbon has 4 out there, needs 4 more, so it forms 4 bonds. Every time.

nucleus = protons (+) and neutrons (0) · electrons (–) orbit in shells

IN PLAIN WORDS

A dense center made of protons (positive) and neutrons (no charge), surrounded by electrons (negative) that move around in layers called shells.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The nucleus contains protons (charge +1, mass ~1 amu) and neutrons (charge 0, mass ~1 amu). Electrons (charge -1, negligible mass) occupy orbitals within electron shells surrounding the nucleus. In a neutral atom, the number of protons equals the number of electrons.

MEMORY TRICK

Protons are Positive. Neutrons are Neutral. That leaves the electron to be the negative one.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Where is nearly all the mass, and where is nearly all the volume? They are not the same place.

WRITE IT OUT

How much does each subatomic particle weigh, and how do you find mass?

IN PLAIN WORDS

A proton is about 1 amu. A neutron is about 1 amu. An electron is about 1/2000 of an amu, which is basically nothing. So mass is just protons plus neutrons. Carbon has 6 protons and 6 neutrons, so mass 12.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Protons carry a charge of +1 and a mass of approximately 1 atomic mass unit. Neutrons are electrically neutral with a mass of approximately 1 amu. Electrons carry a charge of -1 and a mass of approximately 1/2000 amu, which is negligible for mass calculations. Mass number therefore equals protons plus neutrons. In a neutral atom, electron count equals proton count.

MEMORY TRICK

Electrons weigh basically nothing. When he asks for mass, count only the nucleus.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

His practice problem: a neutral nitrogen atom (7N) has an atomic mass of 16 amu. Give protons, electrons, and neutrons. Answer: 7 protons, 7 electrons, and 16 minus 7 equals 9 neutrons. Say the reasoning, not just the numbers.

WRITE IT OUT

How is an element's identity determined? Atomic number vs mass number.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The number of protons IS the element. Change the protons and it becomes a different element entirely. Atomic number = protons. Mass number = protons plus neutrons.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Atomic number equals the number of protons and uniquely defines the element. Mass number equals the sum of protons and neutrons. Atomic mass on the periodic table is a weighted average across naturally occurring isotopes, which is why it is rarely a whole number.

MEMORY TRICK

Protons are the social security number of the atom. Everything else can change; that cannot.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

An atom has 6 protons, 8 neutrons, 6 electrons. Name the element, the atomic number, the mass number, and whether it is an ion or an isotope.

WRITE IT OUT

What are isotopes, and why do they matter in medicine?

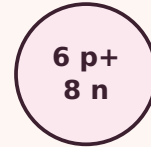
Isotopes: same element, extra neutrons

Carbon-12



stable, most common

Carbon-14



unstable, decays over time

Both are still carbon and behave identically in chemistry. Only the weight and stability differ, which is what makes carbon-14 useful in medicine.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Same element, different number of neutrons. Same chemistry, different weight. Some are unstable and give off radiation, and that radiation is something doctors can detect or aim.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Isotopes are atoms of the same element with differing neutron numbers, therefore differing mass numbers but identical atomic numbers and chemical behavior. Radioisotopes decay at predictable rates. Applications include carbon-14 radiometric dating, radioactive tracers in PET imaging, iodine-131 in thyroid treatment, and targeted radiation therapy.

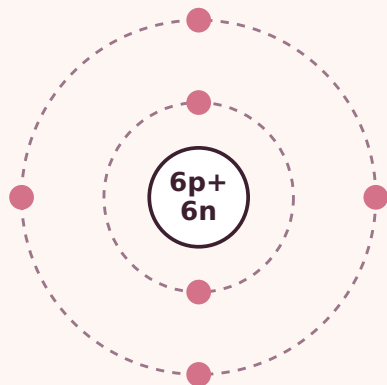
MEMORY TRICK

Iso = same, tope = place. Same place on the periodic table, different weight class. Isotope changes NEUTRONS; ion changes ELECTRONS. Different letters, different particles.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why an isotope behaves the same chemically but differently physically.

WRITE IT OUT

Explain electron shells and the octet rule.**Carbon atom****Atomic number = 6**

protons only. This is the ID badge.

Mass number = 12

protons + neutrons

Inner shell holds 2**Next shell wants 8 (octet)**

Carbon has 4 out there, needs 4 more, so it forms 4 bonds. Every time.

nucleus = protons (+) and neutrons (0) · electrons (–) orbit in shells

IN PLAIN WORDS

Electrons sit in layers around the nucleus. The first layer holds 2, the next ones want 8. An atom with a full outer layer is content and does not react. An atom with a partly filled outer layer will bond with something to fill it.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Electrons occupy shells of increasing energy. The first shell holds 2 electrons, the second and third hold 8 each in biologically relevant elements. The octet rule states that atoms tend to gain, lose, or share valence electrons to achieve a full outer shell. Valence electron count therefore determines reactivity and bonding capacity. Noble gases have full valence shells and are inert.

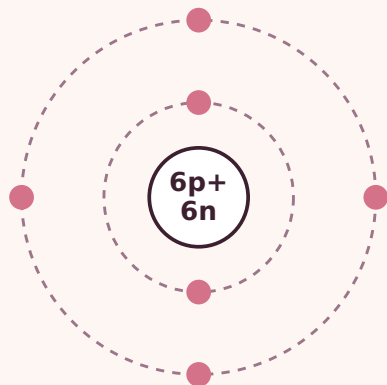
MEMORY TRICK

The outer shell is the atom's dating profile. Full = not looking. Missing one or two = extremely available.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Carbon has 4 valence electrons. Predict how many bonds it forms and explain why, without saying 'because the book said four.'

WRITE IT OUT

Draw a Bohr model and count valence electrons.**Carbon atom**

nucleus = protons (+) and neutrons (0) · electrons (–) orbit in shells

Atomic number = 6

protons only. This is the ID badge.

Mass number = 12

protons + neutrons

Inner shell holds 2**Next shell wants 8 (octet)**

Carbon has 4 out there, needs 4 more, so it forms 4 bonds. Every time.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Fill the first shell with 2, then the next with up to 8. Whatever ends up in the outermost shell is the valence electrons, and that number tells you how the atom will bond. Hydrogen has 1, carbon has 4, nitrogen has 5, oxygen has 6, sodium has 1, neon has 8 and therefore does nothing.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

In the Bohr model, electrons occupy shells of increasing energy: the first holds 2, the second and third hold 8 in biologically relevant elements. Valence electrons are those in the outermost shell and determine reactivity and bonding capacity. Hydrogen (1) has 1 valence electron; carbon (6) has 4; nitrogen (7) has 5; oxygen (8) has 6; sodium (11) has 1; neon (10) has a full outer shell of 8 and is chemically inert. Atoms with incomplete outer shells tend to gain, lose, or share electrons to fill them.

MEMORY TRICK

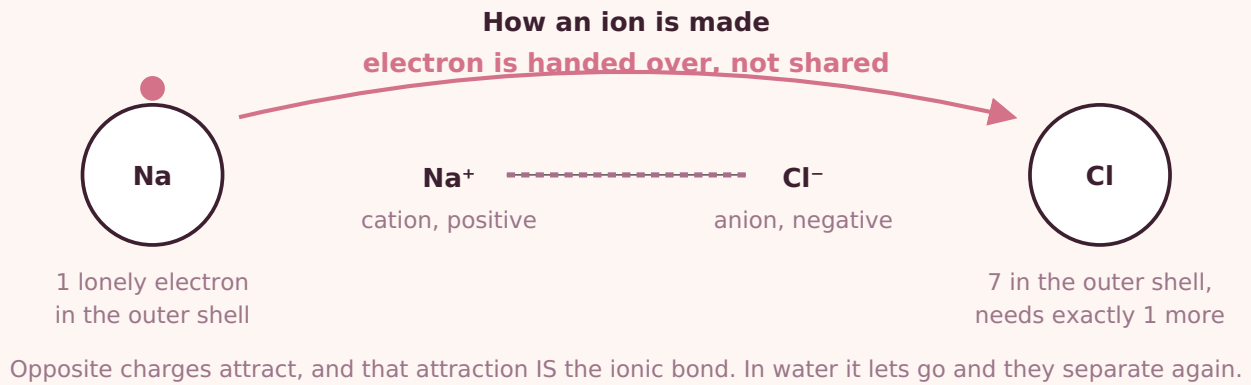
2 then 8. Count the leftovers. Full shell means unreactive, which is why neon does nothing and why he put it in the practice set as the odd one out.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

He asked the class to draw Bohr models for 6C, 8O, 7N, 11Na, and 10Ne and give valence electrons for each. Do all five out loud: 4, 6, 5, 1, 8.

WRITE IT OUT

What is an ion? Cation vs anion, and how does an ionic bond form?



IN PLAIN WORDS

An ion is an atom that gained or lost electrons, so it now has a charge. Lose electrons and you go positive (cation). Gain electrons and you go negative (anion). Two opposite ions stick together, and that attraction is the ionic bond. Living systems run on ions: sodium and potassium moving across membranes are what fire a nerve signal, calcium ions trigger muscle contraction and build bone, and chloride balances charge in blood.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

An ion is an atom or molecule with unequal proton and electron counts. A cation carries a net positive charge from electron loss; an anion carries a net negative charge from electron gain. An ionic bond is the electrostatic attraction between oppositely charged ions, formed by complete transfer of one or more electrons. Sodium chloride is the standard example; in aqueous solution it dissociates into Na^+ and Cl^- . Biologically important ionic species include Na^+ and K^+ , whose gradients across the plasma membrane generate the resting membrane potential and action potentials; Ca^{2+} , which triggers muscle contraction, neurotransmitter release, and forms hydroxyapatite in bone; Cl^- , which maintains charge balance and osmotic pressure; and Mg^{2+} , a cofactor for ATP-dependent enzymes.

MEMORY TRICK

CAT-ion is PAWS-itive. An ANION is A Negative ION. And ionic bonds are a breakup, not a partnership: one atom straight up takes the electron.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

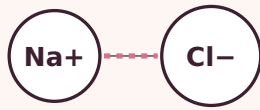
Name three ions your body depends on and say what each one does. Then explain why ionic compounds fall apart in water but covalent ones usually do not.

WRITE IT OUT

Covalent bonds: polar vs nonpolar, and what is electronegativity?

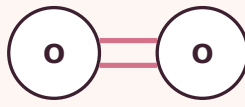
Three bonds, strongest to weakest

Ionic



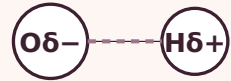
Electron is fully GIVEN away.
Opposite charges attract.
Falls apart in water → ions

Covalent



Electrons are SHARED.
Equal share = nonpolar
Unequal share = polar
Strongest of the three

Hydrogen



No sharing at all. Just a weak tug between a $\delta+$ H and a nearby $\delta-$ O, N or F.
Weak alone, mighty in bulk

IN PLAIN WORDS

A covalent bond is two atoms sharing electrons. If they pull equally, the sharing is fair and the bond is nonpolar. If one pulls harder, it hogs the electrons and gets a slightly negative end while the other gets a slightly positive end. That is polar. Electronegativity is just how hard an atom pulls.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A covalent bond forms when two atoms share one or more electron pairs. Electronegativity is an atom's tendency to attract shared electrons. Equal or near-equal electronegativity produces a nonpolar covalent bond (O_2 , CH_4 , hydrocarbons). Unequal electronegativity produces a polar covalent bond with partial charges denoted delta-plus and delta-minus (H_2O , NH_3). Oxygen, nitrogen, and fluorine are the most electronegative elements in biology.

MEMORY TRICK

Electronegativity ranking to remember: FONCl, pronounced 'fonkle.' $\text{F} > \text{O} > \text{N} > \text{Cl}$. Oxygen is the electron thief of biology.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Given any two atoms, explain the reasoning chain: electronegativity difference, then electron pull, then partial charges, then polarity.

WRITE IT OUT

What is a hydrogen bond, and why does something so weak matter so much?

IN PLAIN WORDS

When a hydrogen is attached to an oxygen or nitrogen, it becomes slightly positive and gets attracted to a slightly negative atom nearby. One of these is easy to break. But your body has trillions of them, and together they hold water, DNA, and proteins in shape.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A hydrogen bond is a weak electrostatic attraction between a hydrogen atom covalently bonded to a highly electronegative atom (O, N, or F) and another electronegative atom bearing a partial negative charge. Individual hydrogen bonds are roughly 1/20 the strength of a covalent bond, but their collective effect is substantial. They produce the emergent properties of water, hold the DNA double helix together (A-T with 2, G-C with 3), and stabilize protein secondary structure.

MEMORY TRICK

Hydrogen bonds are velcro. One hook is nothing. Ten thousand hooks hold your jacket shut. And their weakness is the point: DNA has to be able to unzip.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

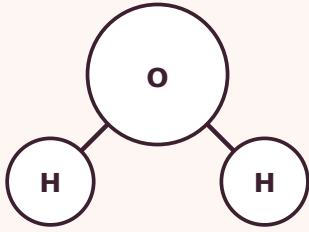
Explain why it would actually be bad if hydrogen bonds were strong.

WRITE IT OUT

Why is water polar, and what does that cause?

Why water is weird (and why you are alive because of it)

δ^- partial negative



δ^+ δ^+
Oxygen hogs the shared electrons
(higher electronegativity) → polar

1. Cohesion & adhesion

water sticks to water, and to other stuff → water climbs a tree trunk

2. High heat capacity

takes a lot of heat to warm up → your body temp stays steady

3. High heat of vaporization

escaping steam carries heat off → sweating cools you down

4. Universal solvent

dissolves anything polar or charged → blood, cytoplasm, ocean

All four come from ONE thing: hydrogen bonds between polar water molecules

IN PLAIN WORDS

Oxygen pulls the shared electrons harder than hydrogen does, so the oxygen side of a water molecule is slightly negative and the hydrogen side is slightly positive. Opposite ends attract each other, so water molecules cling together.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Water's bent molecular geometry combined with oxygen's high electronegativity produces an asymmetric charge distribution: partial negative at oxygen, partial positive at each hydrogen. This permanent dipole allows each water molecule to form up to four hydrogen bonds with neighbors, and this hydrogen bonding network is the single cause of all of water's emergent properties.

MEMORY TRICK

Water is a tiny magnet with a Mickey Mouse shape. If the molecule were straight instead of bent, the charges would cancel and water would be boring.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Trace it: electronegativity, then partial charges, then hydrogen bonds, then ONE specific property. That chain is the answer to most water questions.

WRITE IT OUT

The four properties of water, the way he lists them.

Water's four properties, in lecture order

Polarity causes all four. Every one traces back to hydrogen bonding.

1. “Sticky” behavior

Cohesion: water to water

Adhesion: water to other surfaces

water up a tree, surface tension, interstitial fluid

2. High heat capacity

Absorbs and releases a lot of heat
with little temperature change

breaking and re-forming H bonds · coastal vs inland CA

3. Exists in three states

Solid, liquid, gas · ice FLOATS

because molecules sit farther apart

drives the water cycle, distributes nutrients

4. Versatile solvent

Polar dissolves polar: like dissolves like

Solvent = the dissolver · Solute = the dissolved

blood, cytoplasm, sap · ionic solutes dissociate

IN PLAIN WORDS

1. Sticky behavior: water sticks to itself (cohesion) and to other things (adhesion), which is how water climbs a tree and how interstitial fluid clings around your cells. 2. High heat capacity: it soaks up or gives off a lot of heat while barely changing temperature itself, which is why the coast stays cool and inland California bakes. 3. It exists in all three states, and ice floats because the molecules spread farther apart when it freezes, which drives the water cycle. 4. Versatile solvent: like dissolves like, so polar things dissolve in it.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Water's emergent properties as presented in lecture: (1) cohesion and adhesion produced by hydrogen bonding, generating surface tension and capillary action, moving water through plant tissue and maintaining interstitial fluid; (2) high specific heat capacity, arising from the energy required to break and re-form hydrogen bonds, which moderates temperature both organismally and globally; (3) existence in solid, liquid, and gas phases, with ice less dense than liquid water because hydrogen bonds lock molecules into an open lattice, driving the water cycle and distributing water and nutrients; (4) solvent properties, where polar and ionic solutes dissolve because like dissolves like. Solvent is the dissolving medium; solute is what is dissolved.

MEMORY TRICK

His order: Sticky, Heat, States, Solvent. All four come from ONE thing, hydrogen bonding, which comes from polarity. If you can say that sentence, you can rebuild the whole list.

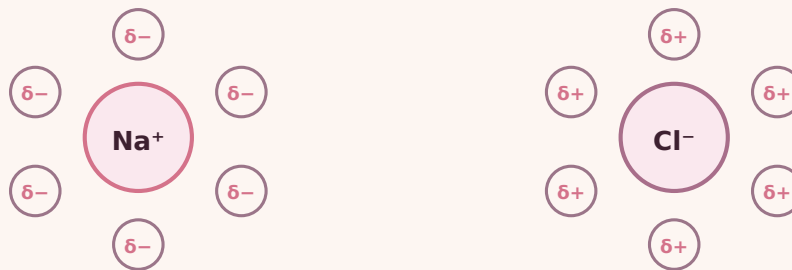
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Name all four IN HIS ORDER with one biological example each. Then say the one cause behind all of them.

WRITE IT OUT

Hydrophilic vs hydrophobic, and why water is called the universal solvent.

Why water dissolves salt



Water surrounds each ion with its opposite partial charge. That jacket is a hydration shell, and it keeps the ions apart so they cannot snap back together. Nonpolar oil gets no such jacket.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Hydrophilic means water-loving: anything polar or charged mixes with water. Hydrophobic means water-fearing: anything nonpolar, like oil, refuses to mix and clumps together instead. In vocabulary: the solvent is the dissolving medium, the solute is what gets dissolved. Ionic solutes like salt dissociate into separate ions; covalent ones like sugar just get surrounded and carried into solution without breaking apart.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Hydrophilic substances are polar or ionic and form favorable interactions with water, becoming solvated by hydration shells. Hydrophobic substances are nonpolar and cannot form hydrogen bonds with water, so they aggregate to minimize contact with it. Water is described as a universal solvent because it dissolves a wider range of polar and ionic substances than any other liquid, not because it dissolves literally everything. The hydrophobic effect drives membrane formation and protein folding. Lecture terminology: solvent is the dissolving medium, solute is the dissolved substance. Ionic compounds undergo dissociation, separating into individual ions each surrounded by water. Covalent molecules such as sucrose dissolve without dissociating: water collides with the solute, surrounds it, and carries it into solution intact.

MEMORY TRICK

Philic = friendly. Phobic = phobia, afraid. And remember: LIKE DISSOLVES LIKE. Polar dissolves polar, nonpolar dissolves nonpolar.

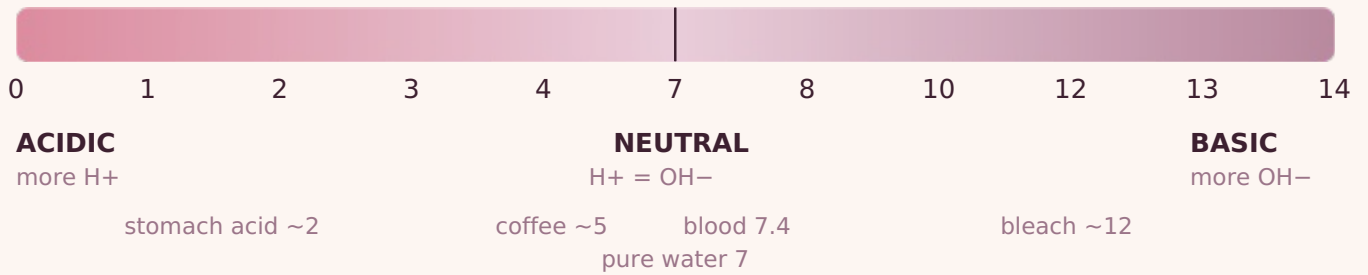
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say the difference between an ionic solute dissolving and a covalent one dissolving. Salt breaks into ions; sugar does not break at all.

WRITE IT OUT

Acids, bases, and the pH scale.

The pH scale



1 step is 10×. pH 4 is TEN times more acidic than pH 5, not one unit more. Buffers soak up spare H⁺ or OH⁻ to hold blood at

IN PLAIN WORDS

An acid dumps extra H⁺ into a solution. A base soaks H⁺ up, or adds OH⁻. pH measures how much H⁺ is floating around: low pH means lots of H⁺ and acidic, high pH means little H⁺ and basic, 7 is neutral.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

An acid is a proton donor, increasing hydrogen ion concentration. A base is a proton acceptor, decreasing hydrogen ion concentration or increasing hydroxide ion concentration. pH is the negative base-10 logarithm of hydrogen ion concentration, so each unit represents a tenfold change. At pH 7, hydrogen and hydroxide concentrations are equal. Human blood is maintained near 7.4.

MEMORY TRICK

Acid Adds H⁺. Base Bags H⁺. And the scale is backwards on purpose: MORE H⁺ means LOWER number, because of the negative in the log.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

How many times more acidic is pH 3 than pH 6? Say the reasoning, not just the number.

WRITE IT OUT

How do you actually calculate pH, [H⁺] and [OH⁻]?

The three equations that solve every pH problem

$$[\text{H}^+] \times [\text{OH}^-] = 10^{-14}$$

$$\text{pH} = -\log [\text{H}^+]$$

$$[\text{H}^+] = 10^{-\text{pH}}$$

Worked: a solution has pH 3.

[H⁺] = 10⁻³ M — just flip the sign of the pH

[OH⁻] = 10⁻¹⁴ ÷ 10⁻³ = 10⁻¹¹ M — subtract the exponents

Check: -3 + -11 = -14 ✓ the two exponents ALWAYS add to -14

Going from pH 4 to pH 6 is 2 units, so [H⁺] changed by 10² = 100×, and it DECREASED because pH went up.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Three facts do everything. Water dissociates into H⁺ and OH⁻. In any water solution, [H⁺] times [OH⁻] always equals 10 to the minus 14. And pH is the negative log of [H⁺], which in practice means: flip the sign of the exponent. If [H⁺] is 10 to the minus 3, pH is 3.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Water dissociates into hydrogen and hydroxide ions. The ion product of water is [H⁺][OH⁻] = 10⁻¹⁴. In pure water at 25 degrees Celsius, [H⁺] = 10⁻⁷ M and [OH⁻] = 10⁻⁷ M, giving pH 7. pH = -log[H⁺], so [H⁺] = 10^{-pH}. Because the two exponents must sum to -14, knowing one concentration gives the other by subtraction. The scale is logarithmic, so each pH unit represents a tenfold change in hydrogen ion concentration.

MEMORY TRICK

The exponents ALWAYS add to minus 14. That one fact solves most of his problems. pH 3 means [H⁺] is 10⁻³, so [OH⁻] must be 10⁻¹¹, because -3 and -11 add to -14.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Do his exact problems out loud. A solution has pH 9: [H⁺] is 10⁻⁹, [OH⁻] is 10⁻⁵. A solution has [OH⁻] of 10⁻¹²: [H⁺] is 10⁻², so pH is 2. pH goes from 2 to 5: that is 3 units, so 10³ = 1000 times, and [H⁺] DECREASED because pH went up.

WRITE IT OUT

Strong vs weak acids and bases.

Strong vs weak: how much of it lets go of its H^+

STRONG acid (HCl)



nearly every molecule releases its H^+
dissociates completely, no going back

WEAK acid (carbonic)



only a few let go, and they can take it back
a reversible reaction, both directions at once

That reversibility is exactly what makes a weak acid able to work as a buffer. A strong acid cannot buffer anything, because it has nothing left to give back.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A strong acid gives up almost all of its H^+ the moment it hits water, and it does not take them back. A weak acid only lets a few go, and it can grab them again. That ability to go both directions is what makes weak acids useful in the body.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Strong acids and bases dissociate essentially completely in aqueous solution, so hydrochloric acid becomes H^+ and Cl^- with effectively no reverse reaction. Weak acids and bases dissociate only partially and exist in equilibrium with their undissociated form, meaning the reaction proceeds in both directions simultaneously. Because a weak acid and its conjugate base coexist, the pair can absorb added H^+ or release H^+ as needed, which is the mechanism behind every biological buffer system, including bicarbonate in blood.

MEMORY TRICK

Strong acids are a one-way door. Weak acids are a revolving door, and only a revolving door can let traffic go both ways, which is exactly what a buffer has to do.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why a buffer has to be made from a WEAK acid. Then say what would happen to blood if the bicarbonate system used a strong acid instead.

WRITE IT OUT

What is a buffer, and why is it crucial?

IN PLAIN WORDS

A buffer is a chemical sponge for acidity. When acid shows up it absorbs H^+ , and when things get too basic it releases H^+ , so the pH barely moves.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A buffer is a system, typically a weak acid and its conjugate base, that resists changes in pH by accepting or donating hydrogen ions. The bicarbonate buffer system (carbonic acid and bicarbonate) maintains blood pH within roughly 7.35 to 7.45. Deviation outside this narrow range denatures enzymes and is rapidly fatal, which is why buffering is non-optional for life.

MEMORY TRICK

A buffer is a shock absorber for pH. Enzymes are the reason it matters: wrong pH, wrong protein shape, no reaction, dead.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Connect two chapters out loud: what does a pH change physically DO to a protein? That link between chapters is exactly the kind of depth question that earns full credit.

WRITE IT OUT

The bicarbonate equation: which way does it shift?

The blood buffer equation he put on a slide



blood gets **ACIDIC** (extra H^+) → shifts **LEFT**

H^+ gets mopped up into H_2CO_3

blood gets **BASIC** → shifts **RIGHT**



H^+ is released back

t effect either way: pH is pulled back toward 7.35 to 7.45. Below 7.35 is acidosis, above 7.45 is alkalosis. Past 6.8 or 8.0, dea

IN PLAIN WORDS

The equation is CO_2 plus water, going back and forth to carbonic acid, going back and forth to bicarbonate plus H^+ . If blood starts getting acidic, meaning extra H^+ , the reaction shifts LEFT to soak that H^+ back up. The net effect is that pH comes back up toward normal.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The bicarbonate buffer system: $\text{CO}_2 + \text{H}_2\text{O}$ reversibly forms H_2CO_3 , which reversibly dissociates into HCO_3^- and H^+ . If blood pH falls, indicating rising hydrogen ion concentration, the equilibrium shifts to the left: excess H^+ combines with bicarbonate to form carbonic acid and ultimately CO_2 and water, removing free hydrogen ions and raising pH back toward normal. If pH rises, the equilibrium shifts right, releasing H^+ and lowering pH. Normal blood pH is 7.35 to 7.45; below is acidosis, above is alkalosis, and beyond roughly 6.8 or 8.0 is fatal.

MEMORY TRICK

Too much H^+ on the right, so the reaction runs away from it, to the left. Le Chatelier in one sentence: a reaction shifts AWAY from whatever you add.

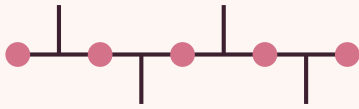
SAY IT OUT LOUD

He put the equation on a slide with two questions: which direction does it shift if blood becomes more acidic, and what is the net effect on pH? Say both. Left, and pH rises back toward normal.

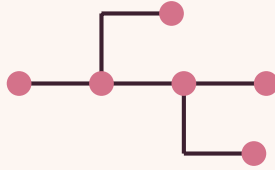
WRITE IT OUT

Why is carbon the backbone of life?

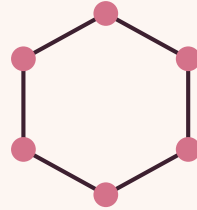
Four bonds is why carbon can build anything



Straight chain



Branched



Ring

bonds would only give you a line. Three gives you flat shapes. Four gives you three dimensions, and life needs three dimens

IN PLAIN WORDS

Carbon has four open bonding spots, so it can link to four different things at once, including other carbons. That lets it build chains, branches, and rings of basically unlimited complexity. No other common element is that versatile.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Carbon has four valence electrons and forms four stable covalent bonds. It bonds readily with itself (catenation) to form chains, branched structures, and rings, and it bonds with hydrogen, oxygen, nitrogen, phosphorus, and sulfur. This tetravalence combined with moderate bond strength generates the structural diversity required for biological macromolecules.

MEMORY TRICK

Carbon is LEGO. Four connection points means you can build anything. Silicon has four too, but its bonds are clumsier and it cannot make the same variety.

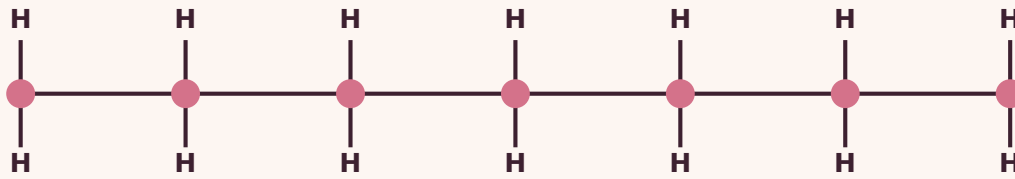
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why four bonds specifically creates diversity. Two would give you a chain, three gives flat shapes, four gives 3D branching.

WRITE IT OUT

What are hydrocarbons, and why do they store energy well?

A hydrocarbon: only C and H, packed with energy



of those C-H bonds is a little packed battery, and none of them are polar, so the whole chain hides from water. That is a fat

IN PLAIN WORDS

Molecules made of only carbon and hydrogen. They form because carbon links to itself in chains and fills every leftover bonding spot with hydrogen. Their C-H bonds hold a lot of energy, and because they are nonpolar they do not mix with water, so the body can pack them together tightly.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Hydrocarbons consist exclusively of carbon and hydrogen joined by nonpolar covalent bonds. They form by catenation, carbon bonding to carbon to build a skeleton, with hydrogen saturating the remaining valence positions. The many energy-rich C-H bonds release substantial energy on oxidation, making hydrocarbon chains efficient energy storage. Their nonpolarity makes them hydrophobic, so they aggregate rather than dissolve. Fatty acid tails are hydrocarbon chains, which is why fat stores more than twice the energy per gram of carbohydrate.

MEMORY TRICK

Hydrocarbon = just H and C, nothing else invited. All those C-H bonds are packed batteries.

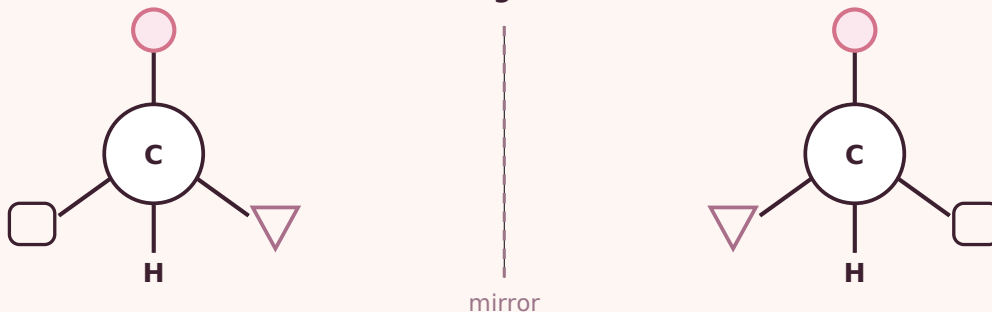
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why fat stores more energy per gram than sugar, using the words C-H bonds and water.

WRITE IT OUT

Isomers: structural, cis-trans, and enantiomers.

Enantiomers: mirror images that are not the same



r groups, same central carbon, but you cannot rotate one to land on the other. Your enzymes are shaped gloves, so only one

Aldose vs ketose: where is the C=O?

ALDOSE — glucose

C=O sits at the END of the chain



both are $C_6H_{12}O_6$
same atoms, different arrangement

KETOSE — fructose

C=O sits in the MIDDLE of the chain



= structural isomers of each other
that is why fructose tastes sweeter

IN PLAIN WORDS

Isomers are molecules with the exact same atoms arranged differently. Structural isomers have the atoms hooked up in a different order. Cis-trans isomers have the same order but different 3D positions around a double bond. Enantiomers are mirror images, like your left and right hand.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Isomers share a molecular formula but differ in structure. Structural isomers differ in the covalent arrangement of atoms (glucose vs fructose). Cis-trans (geometric) isomers differ in spatial arrangement around a carbon-carbon double bond, which cannot rotate freely. Enantiomers are non-superimposable mirror images arising from an asymmetric carbon. Biological receptors and enzymes are stereospecific, so enantiomers often have radically different effects. The thalidomide tragedy is the standard example: one enantiomer treated nausea, the other caused severe birth defects.

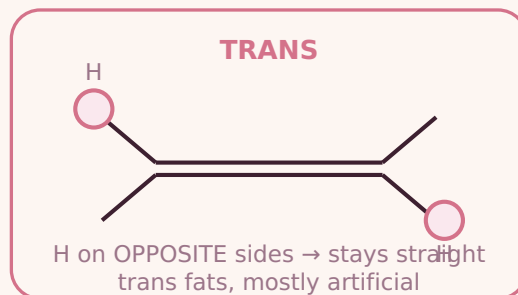
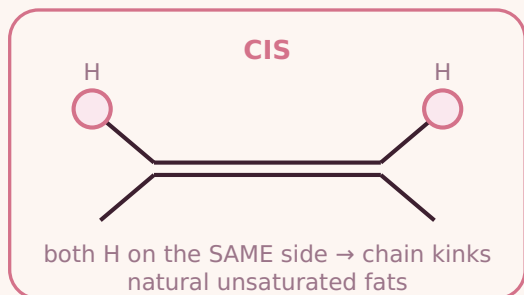
MEMORY TRICK

Enantiomer = your hands. Same fingers, same order, but a right glove will never fit your left hand. Your enzymes are the glove. On his slide, isomers show up under functional groups: structural isomers, ketones and aldehydes. Structural isomers are the part he taught directly.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why a cell can tell two enantiomers apart. The answer is about shape and receptors, not about chemistry.

WRITE IT OUT

Cis-trans isomers: how are they different from structural isomers?**Cis vs trans: same bonds, different side of the double bond**

A double bond cannot spin, which is the whole reason these are two different molecules instead of one.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Structural isomers have their atoms connected in a different order. Cis-trans isomers have the exact same connections, but groups sit on different sides of a double bond. Double bonds cannot spin, so the two arrangements are locked in and become genuinely different molecules.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Structural isomers differ in the covalent connectivity of their atoms. Geometric (cis-trans) isomers have identical connectivity but differ in spatial arrangement around a carbon-carbon double bond, which cannot rotate freely. In the cis configuration the like groups sit on the same side, producing a bend in the chain; in the trans configuration they sit on opposite sides, leaving the chain straight. Naturally occurring unsaturated fatty acids are almost entirely cis, which is why they kink; industrial hydrogenation produces trans fats that pack like saturated fats and raise LDL while lowering HDL.

MEMORY TRICK

CIS = same Side (both start with S). TRANS = across, like transatlantic. And the reason it matters at all: a double bond is a locked hinge, not a swivel.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why cis and trans are two different molecules but two ends of a single bond are not. The answer is about rotation.

WRITE IT OUT

IN LECTURE

Name all seven functional groups and what each one does.

Functional groups: the “charms” clipped onto a carbon skeleton

Hydroxyl —OH

polar · makes things water-loving
alcohols, sugars

Carbonyl —C=O

polar · ketone (middle) or
aldehyde (end of chain)

Carboxyl —COOH

ACIDIC · donates H⁺
amino acids, fatty acids

Amino —NH₂

BASIC · accepts H⁺
amino acids, the other end

Sulfhydryl —SH

forms disulfide bridges
locks protein shape (hair!)

Phosphate —PO₄²⁻

negative · energy transfer
ATP, DNA backbone, phospholipids

Methyl —CH₃

NONPOLAR · no reactivity
a tag, not a tool. Marks DNA.

IN PLAIN WORDS

They are the little attachments on a carbon skeleton that decide how a molecule actually behaves. Hydroxyl makes it water-friendly. Carbonyl makes sugars. Carboxyl is acidic. Amino is basic. Sulfhydryl makes bridges that lock shape. Phosphate carries energy and charge. Methyl is an inert tag.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Hydroxyl (-OH): polar, increases solubility, found in alcohols and sugars. Carbonyl (C=O): polar, aldehyde at a terminal carbon, ketone at an internal carbon. Carboxyl (-COOH): acidic, donates H⁺, present in amino acids and fatty acids. Amino (-NH₂): basic, accepts H⁺, present in amino acids. Sulfhydryl (-SH): forms disulfide bridges that stabilize tertiary protein structure. Phosphate (-OPO₃²⁻): negatively charged, central to ATP energy transfer and the nucleic acid backbone. Methyl (-CH₃): nonpolar and unreactive, functions as a tag that regulates gene expression.

MEMORY TRICK

Hey Cool Cats, All Sharks Phear Mermaids: Hydroxyl, Carbonyl, Carboxyl, Amino, Sulfhydryl, Phosphate, Methyl. Remember the acid/base pair: carbOXYL gives H⁺ away, aMINO takes it. They are the two ends of every amino acid.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Pick any three groups and say what they do to a molecule's solubility, charge, and reactivity. That is the depth version of this question.

WRITE IT OUT

Carbon & Macromolecules — picture sheet

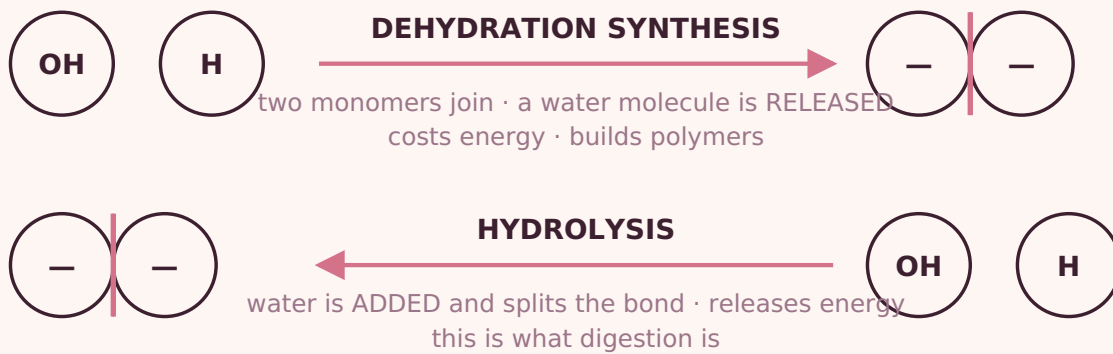
Carbon, functional groups, and the four classes of biological molecules. Every diagram from this section, no text. Ten-minute review.

Four classes, four building blocks

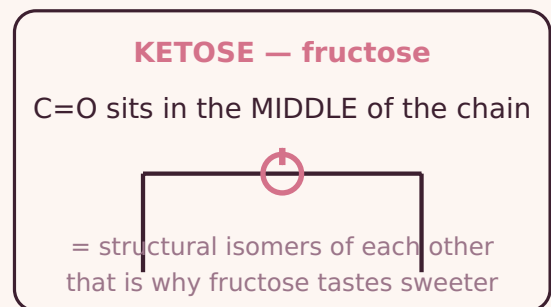
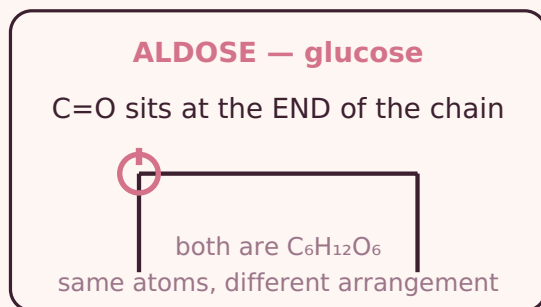
Carbohydrates monosaccharide quick energy, structure in plants	Lipids no true monomer glycerol + fatty acids, membranes, storage	Proteins amino acid enzymes, structure, transport, defense	Nucleic acids nucleotide stores and carries genetic information
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Lipids are the odd one out: they are grouped by a property (hating water), not by a shared building block.

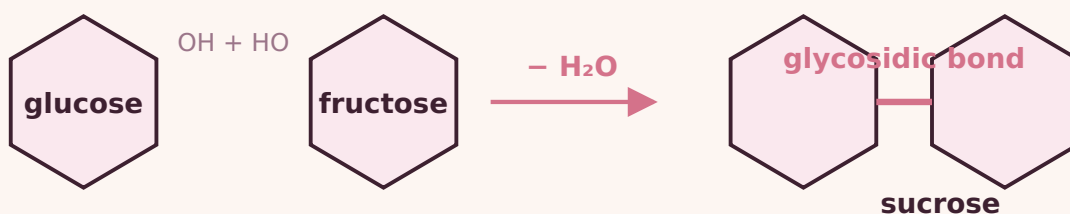
Building up vs breaking down



Aldose vs ketose: where is the C=O?



Making a disaccharide



lactose = glucose + galactose. Maltose = glucose + glucose. Lactose intolerance is simply missing the enzyme that cuts this bond

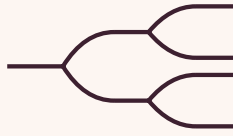
Same glucose monomer, three totally different builds

Starch



lightly branched
PLANT energy storage
alpha bonds
potatoes, rice, bread

Glycogen



heavily branched
ANIMAL energy storage
alpha bonds · liver & muscle
more ends = faster release

Cellulose



straight, stacked, zero branching
PLANT structure (cell wall)
BETA bonds
we lack the enzyme → fiber

Structural polysaccharides: sugar used as scaffolding

Cellulose

plant cell walls
pure glucose, beta bonds

Chitin

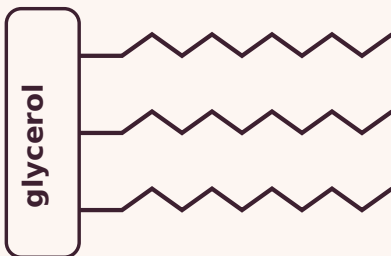
insect and crab shells
glucose with nitrogen added

Chitin

fungal cell walls
same molecule as the shells

Polysaccharides share the same trick: straight chains, beta linkages, stacked and hydrogen bonded into something rigid. Storage

Triglyceride: 1 glycerol + 3 fatty acid tails



SATURATED

no double bonds · straight · packs tight
SOLID at room temp · butter, lard



UNSATURATED

kinks stop tight packing
LIQUID at room temp · olive oil, fish

The molecule that makes cells possible



Head: phosphate group

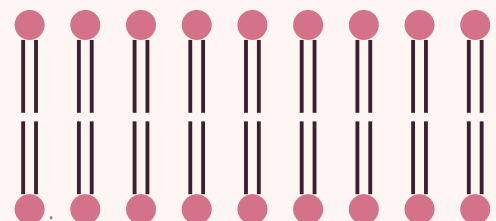
charged → HYDROPHILIC, loves water

Tails: 2 fatty acids

nonpolar → HYDROPHOBIC, hides from water

One molecule, two opposite personalities = amphipathic

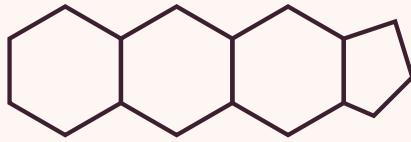
water outside the cell



water inside the cell

Heads face the water, tails hide in the middle.
Nobody built this. It assembles itself.

Steroids: four fused rings, no tails at all



three six-sided rings + one five-sided ring

Cholesterol

keeps membranes fluid, parent of the rest

Testosterone & estrogen

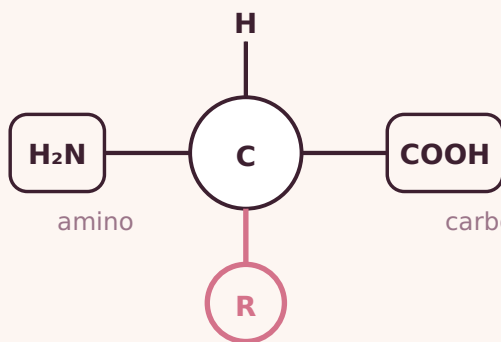
sex hormones

Cortisol

stress and metabolism

Nothing like a fat, but they are still nonpolar, so they are still lipids. Being nonpolar lets them walk straight through a membrane.

Amino acid: four things on one central carbon



The R group is the ONLY difference

Peptide bond



carboxyl of one meets amino of the next
H₂O comes out → it is dehydration synthesis again
Chain of these = polypeptide

Four levels of protein structure

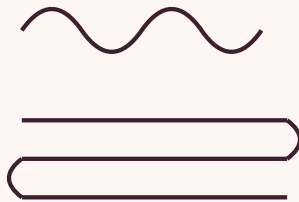
1° Primary



the sequence of amino acids

held by peptide bonds
DNA writes this

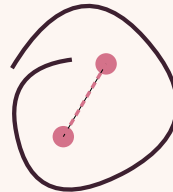
2° Secondary



alpha helix (coil) or
beta pleated sheet

hydrogen bonds in backbone

3° Tertiary



whole chain folds into
a 3D blob

R-group interactions, disulfide

4° Quaternary



2+ finished chains
assemble together
hemoglobin = 4 chains

Denaturation: the shape dies, the sequence lives



folded and working

Peptide bonds are untouched, so primary structure survives. Sometimes it can refold. A fried egg cannot.

heat, wrong pH, salt

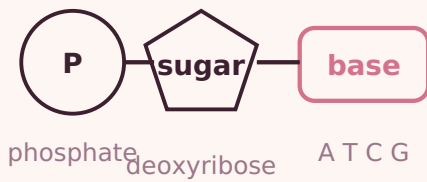


weak interactions break

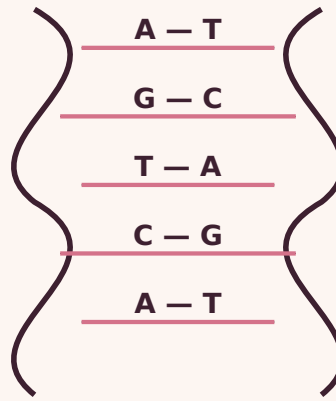


unfolded and useless

One nucleotide, then the double helix



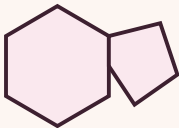
Three parts. Every single time.
Sugar + phosphate link up to form
the backbone of the whole strand.



Backbone of sugar and phosphate runs up the outside. Bases point inward.
A pairs with T using 2 hydrogen bonds, G pairs with C using 3.
Each strand is a template for rebuilding the other one.

Purines and pyrimidines: count the rings

PURINES — two rings



Adenine · Guanine
bigger

PYRIMIDINES — one ring



Cytosine · Thymine · Uracil
smaller

A purine always pairs with a pyrimidine. Big plus small keeps the helix exactly the same width all the way down.
Pure As Gold = PURines are A and G. CUT the PY = pyrimidines are C, U, T.

DNA vs RNA: four differences

DNA

double stranded helix
sugar = deoxyribose
bases A T C G
stays in the nucleus
the master blueprint, kept safe

RNA

single stranded
sugar = ribose (extra OH)
bases A U C G (U replaces T)
travels out to the ribosome
mRNA carries · tRNA delivers · rRNA builds

Carbon & Macromolecules

Ch 2c + 3 · 20 cards

IN LECTURE

What are the four classes of biological macromolecules, and what are their monomers?

Four classes, four building blocks

Carbohydrates monosaccharide quick energy, structure in plants	Lipids no true monomer glycerol + fatty acids, membranes, storage	Proteins amino acid enzymes, structure, transport, defense	Nucleic acids nucleotide stores and carries genetic information
---	--	---	--

Lipids are the odd one out: they are grouped by a property (hating water), not by a shared building block.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Carbohydrates, built from monosaccharides. Lipids, built from glycerol and fatty acids (the odd one out). Proteins, built from amino acids. Nucleic acids, built from nucleotides.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The four classes are carbohydrates (monomer: monosaccharide, polymer: polysaccharide), lipids (not true polymers; assembled from glycerol and fatty acid subunits), proteins (monomer: amino acid, polymer: polypeptide), and nucleic acids (monomer: nucleotide, polymer: DNA or RNA). Three of the four are true polymers; lipids are the exception because their subunits are not repeating identical units joined into a chain.

MEMORY TRICK

CLiPN, like 'clip-n': Carbs, Lipids, Proteins, Nucleic acids. Lipids are the rule-breaker in the group, remember that separately.

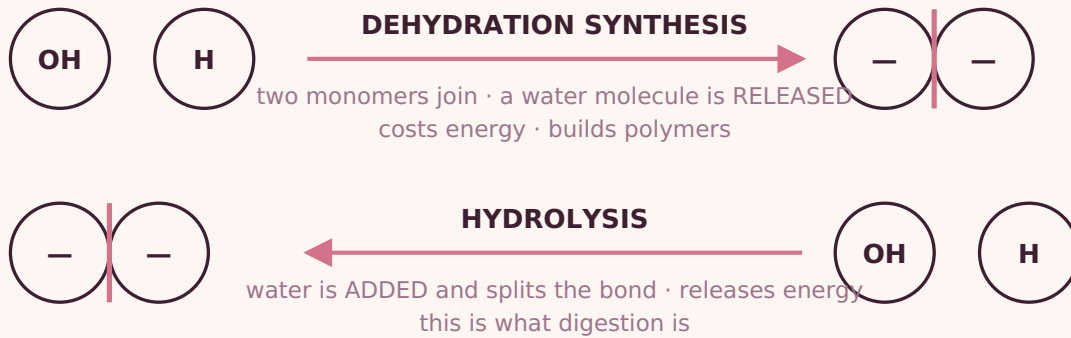
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Why are lipids not technically polymers? If you can answer that, you understand what a polymer actually is.

WRITE IT OUT

Dehydration synthesis vs hydrolysis.

Building up vs breaking down



IN PLAIN WORDS

To join two building blocks, the cell pulls out a water molecule and uses the leftover ends to link them. To break them apart, the cell adds a water molecule back in and splits the bond. Building removes water, breaking adds water.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Dehydration synthesis (condensation) joins two monomers with covalent bond formation and releases one molecule of water; it is endergonic and requires enzymes. Hydrolysis cleaves a covalent bond by adding one molecule of water, with the hydroxyl going to one fragment and the hydrogen to the other; it is exergonic and is the chemical basis of digestion.

MEMORY TRICK

DE-hydration removes water. HYDRO-lysis uses water to LYSE (cut). 'Lysis' always means splitting.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

How many water molecules are released when 10 amino acids form one chain? Say why it is 9, not 10.

WRITE IT OUT

READING GUIDE

What are carbohydrates, and what is the general formula?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Sugars and starches. Quick energy plus some structural jobs. The formula is roughly one carbon, two hydrogens, one oxygen, repeated.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Carbohydrates have the general empirical formula $(CH_2O)_n$, meaning a 1:2:1 ratio of carbon, hydrogen, and oxygen. The name means hydrated carbon. Functions include short-term energy supply, energy storage, structural support, and cell-surface recognition markers.

MEMORY TRICK

Carbo-HYDRATE literally means watered carbon. C with H₂O stuck to it.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Glucose is C₆H₁₂O₆. Check it against the ratio out loud.

WRITE IT OUT

Monosaccharides: name three and why they matter.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Glucose, fructose, and galactose. All three have the exact same atoms, $C_6H_{12}O_6$, but arranged differently. Glucose is the fuel every cell runs on.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Monosaccharides are single sugar units and the simplest carbohydrates. Glucose is the primary cellular fuel and the input to glycolysis and cellular respiration. Fructose is found in fruit and is the sweetest natural sugar. Galactose is a component of lactose. All three share the formula $C_6H_{12}O_6$ and are structural isomers of each other. Ribose and deoxyribose are five-carbon monosaccharides found in nucleic acids.

MEMORY TRICK

Mono = one. All three end in -ose, which is the sugar suffix. If it ends in -ose, it is a sugar.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Same formula, different molecule. Explain how that is possible, and name what we call that relationship.

WRITE IT OUT

Aldose vs ketose.

Aldose vs ketose: where is the $C=O$?

ALDOSE — glucose

$C=O$ sits at the END of the chain



both are $C_6H_{12}O_6$
same atoms, different arrangement

KETOSE — fructose

$C=O$ sits in the MIDDLE of the chain



= structural isomers of each other
that is why fructose tastes sweeter

IN PLAIN WORDS

Both have a $C=O$ group. If it sits at the end of the chain, it is an aldose, like glucose. If it sits in the middle, it is a ketose, like fructose.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Aldose sugars carry a carbonyl group at a terminal carbon, forming an aldehyde; glucose and galactose are aldoses. Ketose sugars carry the carbonyl at an internal carbon, forming a ketone; fructose is the standard ketose. The distinction affects ring structure and reactivity.

MEMORY TRICK

ALdose = At the end (A for the top of the chain). KETose = Kept in the middle. Glucose is an aldose, fructose is a ketose: 'G is at the end of the alphabet stretch, F is in the middle' if that helps.

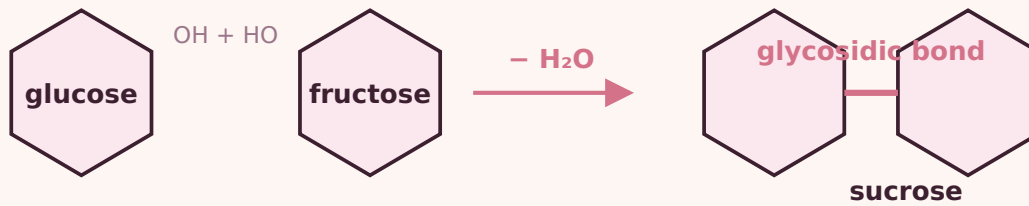
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Given any sugar structure, describe how to classify it in one sentence.

WRITE IT OUT

How do disaccharides form? Name three.

Making a disaccharide



tose = glucose + galactose. Maltose = glucose + glucose. Lactose intolerance is simply missing the enzyme that cuts this bc

IN PLAIN WORDS

Two single sugars join by dehydration synthesis, and the link between them is called a glycosidic bond. Sucrose is glucose plus fructose (table sugar). Lactose is glucose plus galactose (milk sugar). Maltose is glucose plus glucose (malt sugar).

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A disaccharide forms when two monosaccharides are joined by a glycosidic linkage via dehydration synthesis. Sucrose = glucose + fructose. Lactose = glucose + galactose. Maltose = glucose + glucose. Lactose intolerance results from insufficient lactase, the enzyme that hydrolyzes the glycosidic bond in lactose.

MEMORY TRICK

GF, GG, GG-alactose. Sucrose = Sweet Fructose. Lactose = Lactation, so milk. Maltose = Malt, so two glucoses from grain.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain lactose intolerance at the molecular level: which bond, which enzyme, what happens when the enzyme is missing.

WRITE IT OUT

Starch, glycogen, and cellulose: compare structure and function.

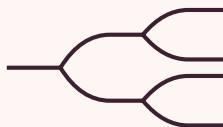
Same glucose monomer, three totally different builds

Starch



lightly branched
PLANT energy storage
alpha bonds
potatoes, rice, bread

Glycogen



heavily branched
ANIMAL energy storage
alpha bonds · liver & muscle
more ends = faster release

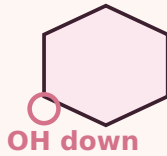
Cellulose



straight, stacked, zero branching
PLANT structure (cell wall)
BETA bonds
we lack the enzyme → fiber

Alpha vs beta glucose, and why it decides everything

ALPHA (α) glucose



Starch: 1-4 links, coiled
Glycogen: 1-4 and 1-6,
heavily branched

BETA (β) glucose



Cellulose: 1-4 links,
straight unbranched
We have no enzyme

Same glucose. One hydroxyl group flipped. Completely different molecule.

Alpha coils, so it stores energy. Beta stays straight and stacks, so it builds structure.

Starch and cellulose are both pure glucose. The only difference is which way that OH points.

IN PLAIN WORDS

All three are long chains of glucose, but built differently. Starch is plant storage, lightly branched. Glycogen is animal storage, heavily branched so energy can be released fast. Cellulose is plant structure, perfectly straight with a different kind of bond, which is why we cannot digest it. Its specifics: starch is 1-4 alpha linkages and coils into a helix. Glycogen is 1-4 plus 1-6 alpha linkages, which is where the heavy branching comes from. Cellulose is 1-4 BETA linkages, straight and unbranched.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

All three are glucose polymers. Starch (amylose and amylopectin) is the plant storage polysaccharide, with alpha glycosidic linkages and limited branching. Glycogen is the animal storage polysaccharide, stored in liver and muscle, with alpha linkages and extensive branching that provides many terminal ends for rapid enzymatic hydrolysis. Cellulose is the structural polysaccharide of plant cell walls, with beta glycosidic linkages that produce straight chains capable of hydrogen bonding into rigid microfibrils. Humans lack cellulase and cannot hydrolyze beta linkages, so cellulose passes through as dietary fiber. Chitin, the structural polysaccharide of arthropod exoskeletons and fungal cell walls, is a modified glucose polymer containing nitrogen. Lecture specifics: starch forms helical fibers via alpha 1-4 glycosidic linkages; glycogen is extensively branched via alpha 1-4 and alpha 1-6 linkages; cellulose forms unbranched linear fibers via beta 1-4 linkages. The alpha versus beta distinction refers to the orientation of the hydroxyl group on carbon 1 of glucose.

MEMORY TRICK

Alpha coils for storage, Beta is a Beam for building. Numbers to remember: starch 1-4, glycogen 1-4 AND 1-6 (the 1-6 is the branch point), cellulose 1-4 beta.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Why can a cow digest cellulose and you cannot? The answer is not about the cow's stomach shape.

WRITE IT OUT

Chitin and the other structural polysaccharides.

Structural polysaccharides: sugar used as scaffolding

Cellulose

plant cell walls
pure glucose, beta bonds

Chitin

insect and crab shells
glucose with nitrogen added

Chitin

fungus cell walls
same molecule as the shells

accharides share the same trick: straight chains, beta linkages, stacked and hydrogen bonded into something rigid. Storage

IN PLAIN WORDS

Chitin is what crab shells, insect exoskeletons, and mushroom cell walls are made of. It is glucose with a nitrogen group attached, built in straight beta chains just like cellulose. Same idea as cellulose: structure, not fuel.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Chitin is a structural polysaccharide of N-acetylglucosamine, a glucose derivative containing a nitrogen-bearing group, joined by beta glycosidic linkages. It forms the exoskeleton of arthropods and the cell walls of fungi. Like cellulose, its beta linkages permit straight chains that hydrogen bond into rigid sheets, and most animals lack the enzyme to digest it. Structural polysaccharides consistently use beta linkages and straight chains, while storage polysaccharides use alpha linkages and coil.

MEMORY TRICK

Alpha coils for storage, Beta is a Beam for building. Chitin is cellulose that went to the beach: same construction, nitrogen added, shells instead of stems.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say the general rule out loud: which linkage type builds structure, which stores energy, and what shape each one produces.

WRITE IT OUT

IN LECTURE

What defines a lipid, and what do lipids do?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Lipids are the greasy ones. What unites them is not a shared building block, it is that they are nonpolar and will not dissolve in water. They store energy, build membranes, insulate, cushion organs, and act as hormones.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Lipids are a chemically diverse group unified by hydrophobicity rather than by a common monomer. They are predominantly nonpolar and insoluble in water. Functions include long-term energy storage, membrane structure, thermal insulation, physical protection of organs, and chemical signaling as steroid hormones. Fat-soluble vitamins A, D, E, and K are also lipids.

MEMORY TRICK

Lipids are defined by what they refuse to do: mix with water. It is the only macromolecule class defined by a physical property instead of a building block.

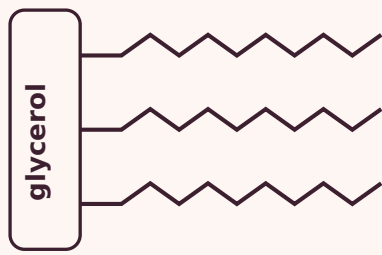
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Name three structurally different lipids and explain what makes all three count as lipids anyway.

WRITE IT OUT

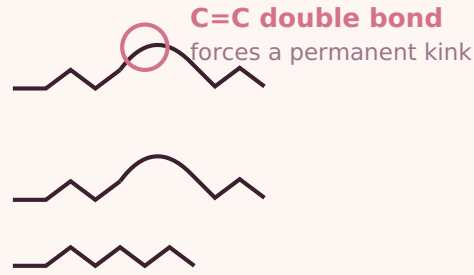
Structure of a triglyceride, and saturated vs unsaturated.

Triglyceride: 1 glycerol + 3 fatty acid tails



SATURATED

no double bonds · straight · packs tight
SOLID at room temp · butter, lard



UNSATURATED

kinks stop tight packing
LIQUID at room temp · olive oil, fish

IN PLAIN WORDS

One glycerol with three fatty acid tails attached. If the tails have no double bonds they are straight, pack tightly, and the fat is solid, like butter. If they have double bonds the tails kink, cannot pack tightly, and the fat is liquid, like olive oil.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A triglyceride consists of a glycerol backbone joined to three fatty acids by ester linkages formed through dehydration synthesis. Saturated fatty acids contain no carbon-carbon double bonds, are saturated with hydrogen, pack densely, and are solid at room temperature; they are predominantly of animal origin and are associated with raised LDL cholesterol. Unsaturated fatty acids contain one or more double bonds that introduce cis kinks preventing dense packing, and are liquid at room temperature; they are predominantly plant and fish oils. Trans fats are artificially hydrogenated unsaturated fats whose trans double bonds do not kink, so they behave like saturated fats while being more harmful, raising LDL and lowering HDL.

MEMORY TRICK

SATURATED = the carbon is SAT with hydrogen, no room for more, straight and stiff and SOLID. Unsaturated has room, so it bends. 'Fats are solid, oils are oily' and now you know why.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain the physical reason butter is solid using the words double bond, kink, and packing. That causal chain is what earns full credit.

WRITE IT OUT

Structure of a phospholipid, and why it forms membranes.

The molecule that makes cells possible



Head: phosphate group

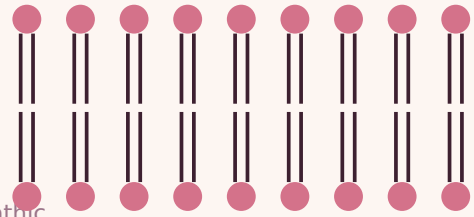
charged → HYDROPHILIC, loves water

Tails: 2 fatty acids

nonpolar → HYDROPHOBIC, hides from water

One molecule, two opposite personalities = amphipathic

water outside the cell



water inside the cell

Heads face the water, tails hide in the middle.
Nobody built this. It assembles itself.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A phosphate head that loves water, attached to two fatty acid tails that hate water. Drop a bunch in water and they automatically arrange into a double layer with all the heads facing out toward water and all the tails hiding inward. That double layer is your cell membrane.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A phospholipid has a glycerol backbone with two fatty acid chains and one phosphate-containing head group. The phosphate head is hydrophilic and the fatty acid tails are hydrophobic, making the molecule amphipathic. In aqueous environments, phospholipids spontaneously self-assemble into a bilayer with heads oriented toward water on both surfaces and tails sequestered in the interior. This arrangement is driven by the hydrophobic effect and creates a selectively permeable barrier, which is the physical basis of the cell as a distinct compartment.

MEMORY TRICK

A phospholipid is a lollipop with two legs. The head loves water, the legs hate it. Nobody assembles the membrane; it builds itself because that arrangement is the most stable.

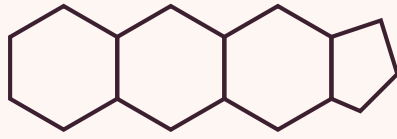
SAY IT OUT LOUD

This is a top-tier depth question: explain why the bilayer forms WITHOUT saying the cell builds it. The driver is the water, not the cell.

WRITE IT OUT

What makes steroids structurally different, and why are they still lipids?

Steroids: four fused rings, no tails at all



three six-sided rings + one five-sided ring

Cholesterol

keeps membranes fluid, parent of the rest

Testosterone & estrogen

sex hormones

Cortisol

stress and metabolism

ok nothing like a fat, but they are still nonpolar, so they are still lipids. Being nonpolar lets them walk straight through a men

IN PLAIN WORDS

Steroids are four rings fused together, not chains. They look nothing like fats. They count as lipids because they are still nonpolar and still refuse to mix with water.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Steroids consist of four fused carbon rings, three six-membered and one five-membered, with varying functional groups attached. They lack fatty acid chains entirely, yet are classified as lipids on the basis of hydrophobicity. Cholesterol is the precursor for all other steroids and regulates membrane fluidity. Testosterone and estrogen are steroid hormones; cortisol regulates stress response and metabolism. Being nonpolar, steroid hormones pass directly through the plasma membrane and bind intracellular receptors.

MEMORY TRICK

Four rings fused = steroid. Cholesterol gets a bad reputation but it is the parent molecule of your sex hormones and it keeps membranes from freezing solid.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why steroid hormones can walk straight through the cell membrane while protein hormones cannot.

WRITE IT OUT

List the functions of proteins.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Proteins do almost every job in the body. They speed up reactions, build structure, move things, carry messages, defend against infection, transport molecules, and store materials.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Protein functions include: enzymatic catalysis (amylase, DNA polymerase), structural support (collagen, keratin), transport (hemoglobin, membrane channel proteins), movement (actin and myosin), defense (antibodies), signaling (insulin and other peptide hormones), storage (casein, ferritin), and receptors for cell communication.

MEMORY TRICK

Proteins are the workforce. DNA is the manual, proteins are the workers. Every job you can name, some protein is doing it.

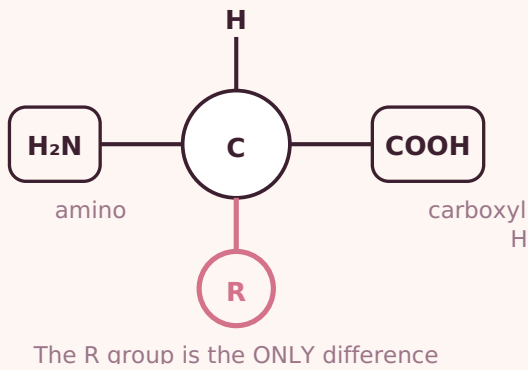
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Name one specific protein for each function. Specific examples are what separate a B answer from an A answer.

WRITE IT OUT

Structure of an amino acid, and how peptide bonds form.

Amino acid: four things on one central carbon



Peptide bond



carboxyl of one meets amino of the next
 H_2O comes out $\rightarrow$ it is dehydration synthesis again
 Chain of these = polypeptide

20 amino acids, sorted by their R group

NONPOLAR

hydrophobic

glycine, alanine, valine,
 leucine, isoleucine, methionine,
 phenylalanine, tryptophan, proline

buries INSIDE the folded protein

POLAR

hydrophilic

serine, threonine, cysteine,
 tyrosine, asparagine, glutamine
 cysteine makes disulfide bridges

faces OUT toward water

CHARGED

hydrophilic

acidic (–): aspartic, glutamic
 basic (+): lysine, arginine, histidine

faces OUT, forms ionic bonds

The R group is the ONLY difference between all 20, and it is what drives folding.

Nonpolar hides from water in the core, polar and charged face the water outside. That single rule explains tertiary structure.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A central carbon holding four things: an amino group, a carboxyl group, a hydrogen, and an R group. The R group is the only part that changes between the 20 amino acids, and it decides that amino acid's personality. Two amino acids join when the carboxyl of one bonds to the amino of the next, releasing water. He sorts the 20 into three groups by R group: nonpolar and hydrophobic, polar and hydrophilic, and electrically charged, which splits into acidic (negative) and basic (positive).

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

An amino acid consists of a central alpha carbon bonded to an amino group ($-\text{NH}_2$), a carboxyl group ($-\text{COOH}$), a hydrogen atom, and a variable R group (side chain). The R group determines whether the amino acid is nonpolar, polar, acidic, or basic, and therefore determines how that residue behaves during folding. A peptide bond is a covalent bond formed by dehydration synthesis between the carboxyl carbon of one amino acid and the amino nitrogen of the next. Chains of amino acids are polypeptides; one or more folded polypeptides constitute a protein. Lecture categorization of the 20 amino acids by side chain: nonpolar and hydrophobic (glycine, alanine, valine, leucine, isoleucine, methionine, phenylalanine, tryptophan, proline); polar and hydrophilic (serine, threonine, cysteine, tyrosine, asparagine, glutamine); electrically charged and hydrophilic, subdivided into acidic and negatively charged (aspartic acid, glutamic acid) and basic and positively charged (lysine, arginine, histidine).

MEMORY TRICK

Every amino acid is the same except the R group. R for 'the Rest of it' and R for 'the Reason they differ.' Twenty amino acids, twenty different R groups, that is the whole story.

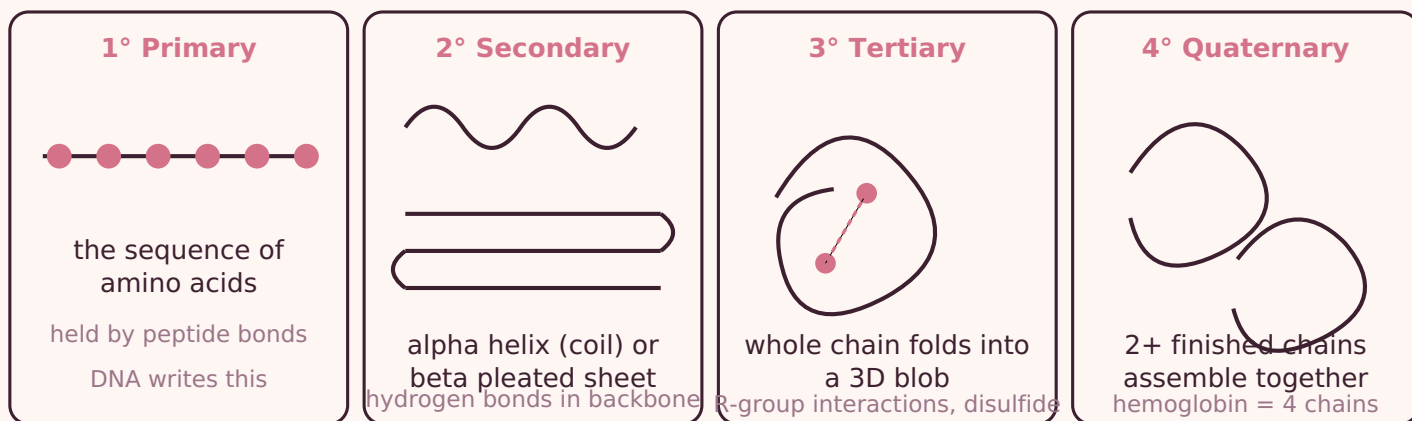
SAY IT OUT LOUD

His slide listed five questions he expects you to answer: what is the monomer of a protein, how many are there, what makes each different, what properties define the categories, and what bond links them. Answer all five out loud.

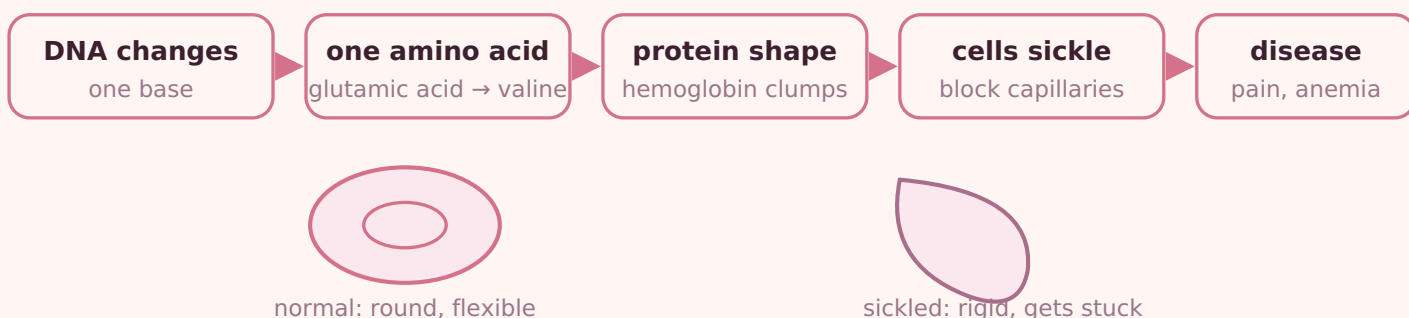
WRITE IT OUT

The four levels of protein structure.

Four levels of protein structure



Sickle cell: one amino acid, one disease



Primary structure decides tertiary structure. Tertiary structure decides whether it works.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Primary is the order of the amino acids, like letters in a word. Secondary is local twisting into coils or pleats, held by hydrogen bonds along the backbone. Tertiary is the whole chain folding into one 3D shape, driven by the R groups. Quaternary is two or more finished chains joining into one working unit.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Primary structure is the linear amino acid sequence, determined by the gene and joined by peptide bonds. Secondary structure comprises localized alpha helices and beta pleated sheets, stabilized by hydrogen bonds between backbone atoms, not R groups. Tertiary structure is the overall three-dimensional conformation of a single polypeptide, stabilized by R-group interactions including hydrophobic clustering, hydrogen bonds, ionic bonds, and covalent disulfide bridges. Quaternary structure is the assembly of multiple polypeptide subunits into a functional complex; hemoglobin with four subunits is the standard example. Not all proteins have quaternary structure. Lecture specifics: secondary structure arises from hydrogen bonding between backbone hydrogens and oxygens, with the alpha helix forming a hydrogen bond roughly every fourth amino acid. Tertiary structure is maintained by R-group interactions: hydrogen bonds, hydrophobic interactions, ionic bonds, and covalent disulfide bridges. Quaternary structure is maintained by covalent, ionic, and hydrogen bonds between subunits. Sickle cell anemia illustrates how a single amino acid substitution in primary structure alters tertiary structure and therefore function.

MEMORY TRICK

Think of a phone cord: the plastic and wire is primary, the coil is secondary, the tangled mess in your bag is tertiary, and two cords knotted together is quaternary. Key exam detail: SECONDARY uses backbone hydrogen bonds, TERTIARY uses R-group interactions. Professors love that distinction. His detail: the alpha helix hydrogen bonds roughly every 4th amino acid. And the four tertiary interactions are hydrogen bonds, hydrophobic interactions, ionic bonds, and disulfide bridges.

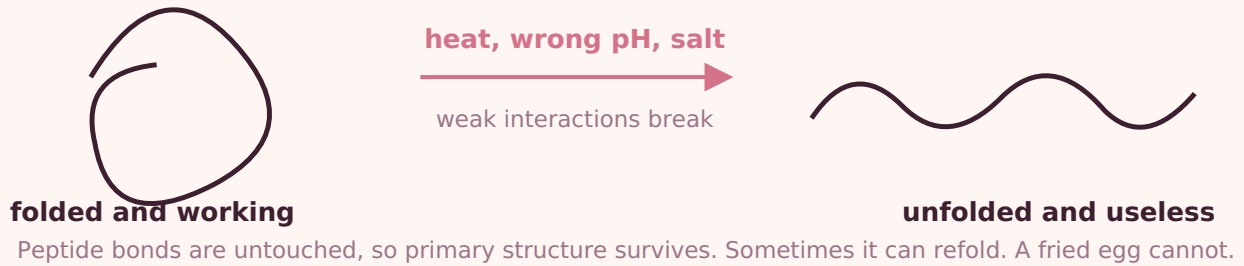
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Alpha helix and beta pleated sheet are which level? Say it, then say what holds them together.

WRITE IT OUT

What is denaturation, and is it reversible?

Denaturation: the shape dies, the sequence lives



IN PLAIN WORDS

Denaturation is a protein unfolding and losing its shape, so it stops working. Its four causes: changes in pH, heat, salinity, and polarity. The peptide bonds are untouched, so the amino acid sequence survives. Mild denaturation can sometimes reverse, which is called renaturation. Severe denaturation usually cannot.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Denaturation is the loss of secondary, tertiary, and quaternary structure through unfolding, without cleavage of peptide bonds, so primary structure is retained. Lecture causes: changes in pH, heat, salinity, and polarity. Because function depends on conformation, denatured proteins lose activity. Mild denaturation may permit renaturation when normal conditions return; severe denaturation is typically irreversible due to aggregation.

MEMORY TRICK

A fried egg never un-fries. Denaturation destroys the SHAPE, not the SEQUENCE, which is why primary structure survives every time.

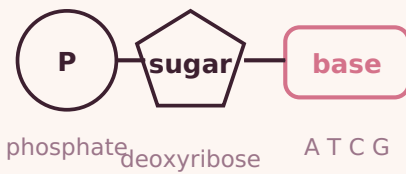
SAY IT OUT LOUD

He asked directly on a slide: what happens to hydrogen ion concentration as pH decreases or increases, and which bonds in a protein would that affect? Answer both. Lower pH means more H^+ , which disrupts ionic bonds and hydrogen bonds between R groups.

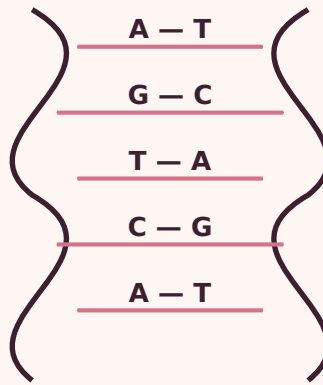
WRITE IT OUT

What are nucleic acids and nucleotides?

One nucleotide, then the double helix



Three parts. Every single time.
 Sugar + phosphate link up to form
 the backbone of the whole strand.



Backbone of sugar and phosphate runs up the outside. Bases point inward.
 A pairs with T using 2 hydrogen bonds, G pairs with C using 3.
 Each strand is a template for rebuilding the other one.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Nucleic acids are DNA and RNA, the molecules that store and carry genetic instructions. Their building block is the nucleotide, which is always three parts: a phosphate, a five-carbon sugar, and a nitrogenous base.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Nucleic acids are polymers of nucleotides that store, transmit, and express genetic information. Each nucleotide comprises a phosphate group, a pentose sugar (deoxyribose in DNA, ribose in RNA), and one nitrogenous base. Purines (adenine, guanine) have two rings; pyrimidines (cytosine, thymine, uracil) have one. Nucleotides are joined by phosphodiester bonds between the phosphate of one and the sugar of the next, forming the sugar-phosphate backbone.

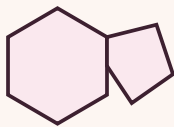
MEMORY TRICK

Three parts: Phosphate, Sugar, Base. PSB, like 'peanut butter sandwich' out of order. Pure As Gold = PURines are Adenine and Guanine (two rings). CUT the PY = pyrimidines are Cytosine, Uracil, Thymine (one ring).

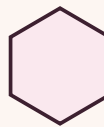
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Name the three parts without looking, then say which part differs between DNA and RNA.

WRITE IT OUT

Purines vs pyrimidines.**Purines and pyrimidines: count the rings****PURINES — two rings**

Adenine • Guanine
bigger

PYRIMIDINES — one ring

Cytosine • Thymine • Uracil
smaller

A purine always pairs with a pyrimidine. Big plus small keeps the helix exactly the same width all the way down.

Pure As Gold = PURines are A and G. CUT the PY = pyrimidines are C, U, T.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Two kinds of bases. Purines have two rings and are bigger: adenine and guanine. Pyrimidines have one ring and are smaller: cytosine, thymine, and uracil. A big one always pairs with a small one, which keeps the DNA ladder exactly the same width the whole way down.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Purines are double-ring nitrogenous bases: adenine and guanine. Pyrimidines are single-ring bases: cytosine, thymine (DNA only), and uracil (RNA only). Complementary base pairing always joins a purine to a pyrimidine, maintaining a constant helix diameter of about 2 nanometers. Adenine pairs with thymine via two hydrogen bonds; guanine pairs with cytosine via three, making G-C pairs more thermally stable.

MEMORY TRICK

Pure As Gold: PURines are Adenine and Guanine. CUT the PY: PYrimidines are Cytosine, Uracil, Thymine. And PYrimidines have a Y in the name and one ring, like one Y-shape.

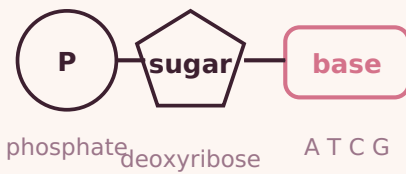
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Explain why the helix would not work if two purines ever paired together. Say it in terms of width.

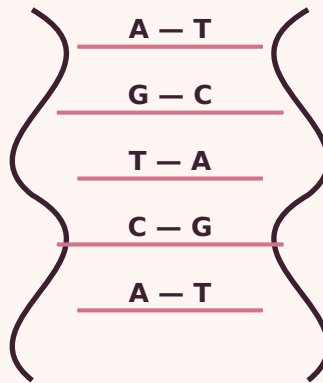
WRITE IT OUT

Describe DNA's double helix and complementary base pairing.

One nucleotide, then the double helix



Three parts. Every single time.
Sugar + phosphate link up to form the backbone of the whole strand.



Backbone of sugar and phosphate runs up the outside. Bases point inward.
A pairs with T using 2 hydrogen bonds, G pairs with C using 3.
Each strand is a template for rebuilding the other one.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Two strands twisted around each other like a spiral ladder. The sides are sugar and phosphate. The rungs are pairs of bases: A always pairs with T, G always pairs with C, held by hydrogen bonds. Because the pairing is fixed, one strand tells you exactly what the other says.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

DNA is an antiparallel double helix with a sugar-phosphate backbone on the exterior and nitrogenous bases oriented inward. Complementary base pairing joins adenine to thymine by two hydrogen bonds and guanine to cytosine by three hydrogen bonds. A purine always pairs with a pyrimidine, keeping helix width constant. Because each strand specifies the sequence of the other, each serves as a template during semiconservative replication, which is the structural basis for accurate inheritance.

MEMORY TRICK

Apples in the Tree, Cars in the Garage. A-T, C-G. And G-C has 3 hydrogen bonds while A-T has 2, so GC-rich DNA is harder to pull apart.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

The depth question: explain how the STRUCTURE makes accurate copying possible. Structure to function, again.

WRITE IT OUT

DNA vs RNA, and the three types of RNA.

DNA vs RNA: four differences

DNA

double stranded helix
sugar = deoxyribose
bases A T C G
stays in the nucleus
the master blueprint, kept safe

RNA

single stranded
sugar = ribose (extra OH)
bases A U C G (U replaces T)
travels out to the ribosome
mRNA carries · tRNA delivers · rRNA builds

IN PLAIN WORDS

DNA is double stranded, uses deoxyribose, uses the base T, and stays in the nucleus. RNA is single stranded, uses ribose, uses U instead of T, and travels out to do the work. mRNA carries the message, tRNA delivers amino acids, rRNA builds the ribosome itself.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

DNA is double-stranded, contains deoxyribose, uses thymine, and remains in the nucleus in eukaryotes as long-term genetic storage. RNA is typically single-stranded, contains ribose (with an additional hydroxyl group making it less chemically stable), uses uracil in place of thymine, and functions in the cytoplasm. Messenger RNA carries the transcribed coding sequence from nucleus to ribosome. Transfer RNA carries specific amino acids to the ribosome and reads codons via its anticodon. Ribosomal RNA is a structural and catalytic component of the ribosome.

MEMORY TRICK

DNA is the library book that never leaves the library. mRNA is the photocopy you carry out. U replaces T in RNA: 'U R the one that leaves.' Types: M for Message, T for Transfer/Taxi, R for Ribosome.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Why does the cell bother making a copy instead of sending the DNA itself? Answer in terms of protecting the original.

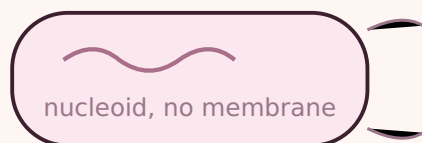
WRITE IT OUT

Cells — picture sheet

Chapter 4 plus Lab 4. Not in the reading guide, but it is in his lectures. Every diagram from this section, no text. Ten-minute review.

Prokaryotic vs eukaryotic

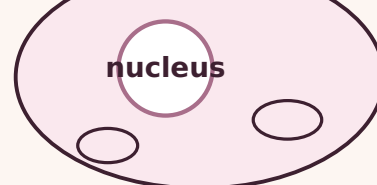
PROKARYOTE



- No nucleus, DNA loose in cytoplasm
- No membrane-bound organelles
- Small, 1–10 μm · has ribosomes
- Bacteria and archaea

· **Lab shapes: bacilli, spirilli, cocci**

EUKARYOTE



membrane-bound organelles

- True nucleus holding the DNA
- Many organelles, internal membranes
- Larger, 10–100 μm
- Animals, plants, fungi, protists

BOTH have: plasma membrane · protoplasm (cytoplasm) · DNA/RNA · ribosomes

Lab 4: what to identify in each specimen

Frog blood

plasma membrane
cytoplasm
nucleus
chromatin

Onion epidermis

plasma membrane
CELL WALL
cytoplasm
nucleus · chromatin

Elodea

plasma membrane
CELL WALL
cytoplasm
central vacuole · CHLOROPLAST

Cheek cell

plasma membrane
cytoplasm
nucleus
chromatin

Bacteria, three shapes



BACILLI — rods



SPIRILLI — spirals



COCCI — spheres

Plant cells give away the wall and the chloroplasts. Animal cells never have either one.

The organelle roster

Nucleus

houses DNA as chromatin
nucleolus makes ribosomes · pores in envelope

Ribosome

rRNA + protein complex

builds proteins · NOT membrane bound

Rough ER

ribosomes studded on it

makes and packages secretory proteins

Smooth ER

no ribosomes

lipid synthesis, detox, calcium storage

Golgi apparatus

modifies, sorts, ships

the post office of the cell

Lysosome

vesicle of digestive enzymes

breaks down waste and worn parts

Mitochondrion

makes ATP from food

own DNA · folded cristae · in all eukaryotes

Chloroplast

photosynthesis

own DNA · plants and algae only

Cytoskeleton

microtubules + microfilaments

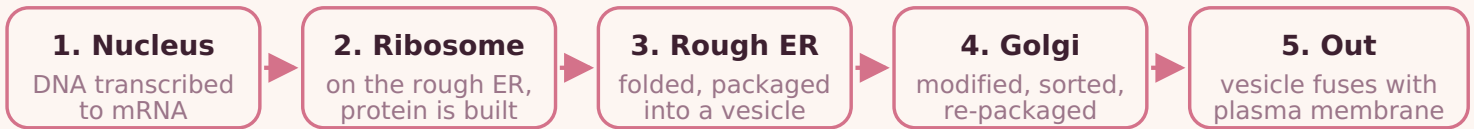
shape, support, movement, flagella

Plant cells also have: cell wall, central vacuole, chloroplasts

Animal cells have: centrioles, lysosomes, and usually no wall or large vacuole

Internal membranes do two things: compartmentalize the cell, and increase surface area for metabolism.

Tracing a secreted protein, start to finish



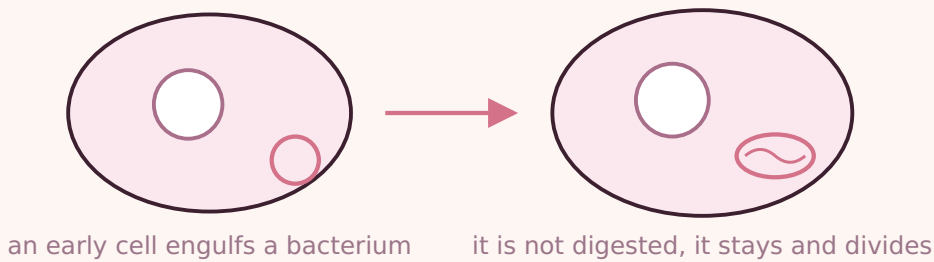
A LYSOSOMAL protein takes the same route until the Golgi, then stays inside

The Golgi tags it for delivery to a lysosome instead of shipping it out of the cell.

clear envelope • ER • Golgi • lysosomes • vesicles • plasma membrane = the endomembrane system

He asked you to trace both paths with a partner in class. That is an exam question waiting to happen.

Endosymbiosis: where mitochondria and chloroplasts came from



The evidence:

- they have their own DNA
- they have their own ribosomes
- they have a double membrane
- they divide on their own, like bacteria
- they are bacteria-sized

Mitochondria: animals, plants, fungi, most protists. Chloroplasts: plants and algae only, a second, later engulfing. The endomembrane system came from a different route: infolding of the plasma membrane. It is all membrane.

Cells

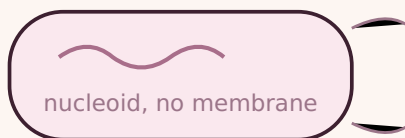
Ch 4 + Lab 4 · 9 cards

IN LECTURE

What is the cell theory, and who gets credit?

Prokaryotic vs eukaryotic

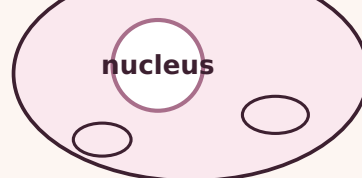
PROKARYOTE



- No nucleus, DNA loose in cytoplasm
- No membrane-bound organelles
- Small, 1–10 μm · has ribosomes
- Bacteria and archaea

· **Lab shapes: bacilli, spirilli, cocci**

EUKARYOTE



- True nucleus holding the DNA
- Many organelles, internal membranes
- Larger, 10–100 μm
- Animals, plants, fungi, protists

BOTH have: plasma membrane · protoplasm (cytoplasm) · DNA/RNA · ribosomes

IN PLAIN WORDS

Three statements. Every living thing is made of cells. The cell is the basic unit of structure and function. And every cell comes from a cell that already existed. Schleiden and Schwann worked out the first two in 1839, Virchow added the third in 1855.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Cell theory states: (1) all organisms are composed of one or more cells; (2) the cell is the fundamental structural and functional unit of life; (3) all cells arise from pre-existing cells by division. Schleiden and Schwann established the first two principles in 1839; Virchow added the third in 1855. Robert Hooke first observed and named cells in Micrographia in 1665.

MEMORY TRICK

S, S, then V. Schleiden and Schwann said what cells ARE, Virchow said where they COME FROM. Hooke just saw them first, in 1665, and named them after monastery rooms.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

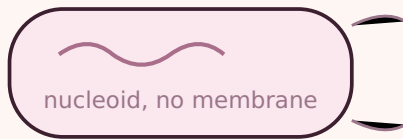
Say all three parts plus who added which. He put the names and years on the slide, which usually means he wants them.

WRITE IT OUT

Prokaryotic vs eukaryotic cells.

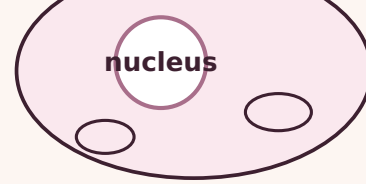
Prokaryotic vs eukaryotic

PROKARYOTE



- No nucleus, DNA loose in cytoplasm
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EUKARYOTE



- True nucleus holding the DNA
- Many organelles, internal membranes
- Larger, 10–100 μm
- Animals, plants, fungi, protists

BOTH have: plasma membrane · protoplasm (cytoplasm) · DNA/RNA · ribosomes

IN PLAIN WORDS

Prokaryotes have no nucleus and no membrane-bound organelles. Their DNA just floats in the cytoplasm. Eukaryotes have a real nucleus holding the DNA plus a whole set of organelles. Prokaryotes are small, eukaryotes are much bigger.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Prokaryotic cells lack a membrane-bound nucleus and lack membrane-bound organelles; their genetic material occupies a nucleoid region. They are typically 1 to 10 micrometers. Bacteria and archaea are prokaryotic. Eukaryotic cells possess a true nucleus enclosed by a nuclear envelope and an array of membrane-bound organelles, and are typically 10 to 100 micrometers. Animals, plants, fungi, and protists are eukaryotic. Both types possess a plasma membrane, cytoplasm, ribosomes, and DNA.

MEMORY TRICK

PRO = PRIOR to a nucleus. EU = TRUE nucleus. And the thing people forget: prokaryotes DO have ribosomes, because every cell has to make proteins.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Name what BOTH have, not just what differs. His slide listed three things all cells contain: plasma membrane, protoplasm, DNA/RNA. That is a likely question.

WRITE IT OUT

Lab 4: what do you identify in each specimen?

Lab 4: what to identify in each specimen

Frog blood

plasma membrane
cytoplasm
nucleus
chromatin

Onion epidermis

plasma membrane
CELL WALL
cytoplasm
nucleus · chromatin

Elodea

plasma membrane
CELL WALL
cytoplasm
central vacuole · CHLOROPLAST

Cheek cell

plasma membrane
cytoplasm
nucleus
chromatin

Bacteria, three shapes



BACILLI — rods



SPIRILLI — spirals



COCCI — spheres

Plant cells give away the wall and the chloroplasts. Animal cells never have either one.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Frog blood and cheek cells are animal, so plasma membrane, cytoplasm, nucleus, chromatin. Onion epidermis adds a cell wall. Elodea adds a cell wall, a central vacuole, and chloroplasts. Bacteria come in three shapes: rods (bacilli), spirals (spirilli), and spheres (cocci).

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Prokaryotic exploration: identify bacilli (rod-shaped), spirilli (spiral), and cocci (spherical) bacteria. Eukaryotic exploration: frog blood (plasma membrane, cytoplasm, nucleus, chromatin); onion epidermis (plasma membrane, cell wall, cytoplasm, nucleus, chromatin); Elodea (plasma membrane, cell wall, cytoplasm, central vacuole, chloroplast); human cheek cell (plasma membrane, cytoplasm, nucleus, chromatin). Cell wall and chloroplasts identify a plant cell; their absence identifies an animal cell.

MEMORY TRICK

Bacilli are Bars. Cocci are Circles. Spirilli are Spirals. For specimens: if you see a wall, it is a plant. If you see green, it is Elodea.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Given an unlabeled slide, say how you would tell a plant cell from an animal cell in one sentence.

WRITE IT OUT

The nucleus and ribosomes: what does each do?

The organelle roster

Nucleus

houses DNA as chromatin

nucleolus makes ribosomes · pores in envelope · makes proteins · NOT membrane bound

Ribosome

rRNA + protein complex

Rough ER

ribosomes studded on it

makes and packages secretory proteins

Smooth ER

no ribosomes

lipid synthesis, detox, calcium storage

Golgi apparatus

modifies, sorts, ships

the post office of the cell

Lysosome

vesicle of digestive enzymes

breaks down waste and worn parts

Mitochondrion

makes ATP from food

own DNA · folded cristae · in all eukaryotes

Chloroplast

photosynthesis

own DNA · plants and algae only

Cytoskeleton

microtubules + microfilaments

shape, support, movement, flagella and cilia

Plant cells also have: cell wall, central vacuole, chloroplasts

Animal cells have: centrioles, lysosomes, and usually no wall or large vacuole

Internal membranes do two things: compartmentalize the cell, and increase surface area for metabolism.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The nucleus holds the DNA, which sits loosely as chromatin. It is wrapped in a double membrane called the nuclear envelope, dotted with pores so things can get in and out. Inside is the nucleolus, which builds ribosomes. Ribosomes are made of rRNA plus protein, and they build proteins.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The nucleus contains the cell's genetic material as chromatin, a DNA-protein complex. It is bounded by a nuclear envelope of two membranes perforated by nuclear pores that regulate transport. The nucleolus within the nucleus synthesizes ribosomal subunits. Ribosomes are complexes of ribosomal RNA and protein that carry out protein synthesis. Ribosomes are not membrane-bound and are found in both prokaryotes and eukaryotes, either free in the cytosol or bound to the rough ER.

MEMORY TRICK

Nucleolus makes ribosomes. Two words that sound similar and are directly connected: nucleoLUS makes riboSOMES.

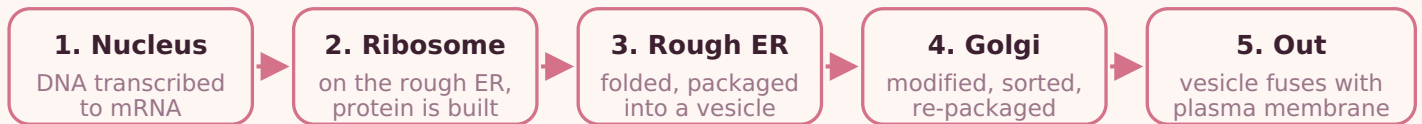
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Why does the nuclear envelope need pores? Answer in terms of what has to leave the nucleus.

WRITE IT OUT

Trace a protein through the endomembrane system.

Tracing a secreted protein, start to finish



A LYSOSOMAL protein takes the same route until the Golgi, then stays inside

The Golgi tags it for delivery to a lysosome instead of shipping it out of the cell.

nuclear envelope · ER · Golgi · lysosomes · vesicles · plasma membrane = the endomembrane system

He asked you to trace both paths with a partner in class. That is an exam question waiting to happen.

IN PLAIN WORDS

DNA in the nucleus is copied to mRNA. Ribosomes on the rough ER build the protein. The rough ER folds it and buds it off in a vesicle. The vesicle goes to the Golgi, which modifies, sorts, and repackages it. Then a vesicle carries it to the plasma membrane and fuses, releasing it outside the cell.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The endomembrane system comprises the nuclear envelope, endoplasmic reticulum, Golgi apparatus, lysosomes, vesicles, and plasma membrane, working together to modify, package, and transport proteins and lipids. Secretory pathway: transcription in the nucleus, translation by ribosomes on rough ER, folding and modification in the ER lumen, transport vesicle to the Golgi, further modification and sorting in the Golgi, and a secretory vesicle that fuses with the plasma membrane by exocytosis. A lysosomal protein follows the identical route until the Golgi tags it for delivery to a lysosome rather than for export.

MEMORY TRICK

Nucleus, Ribosome, Rough ER, Golgi, Out. The Golgi is the post office: everything passes through it and gets a shipping label that decides where it goes.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

He had the class trace this with a partner in lecture. Say both versions out loud: the secreted protein and the lysosomal protein, and where the two paths split.

WRITE IT OUT

Mitochondria, chloroplasts, lysosomes and the rest.

The organelle roster

Nucleus houses DNA as chromatin nucleolus makes ribosomes · pores in envelope	Ribosome rRNA + protein complex embeds proteins · NOT membrane bound	Rough ER ribosomes studded on it makes and packages secretory proteins
Smooth ER no ribosomes lipid synthesis, detox, calcium storage	Golgi apparatus modifies, sorts, ships the post office of the cell	Lysosome vesicle of digestive enzymes breaks down waste and worn parts
Mitochondrion makes ATP from food own DNA · folded cristae · in all eukaryotes	Chloroplast photosynthesis own DNA · plants and algae only	Cytoskeleton microtubules + microfilaments shape, support, movement, flagella and cilia

Plant cells also have: cell wall, central vacuole, chloroplasts

Animal cells have: centrioles, lysosomes, and usually no wall or large vacuole

Internal membranes do two things: compartmentalize the cell, and increase surface area for metabolism.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Mitochondria make ATP from food and are in basically every eukaryote. Chloroplasts do photosynthesis and are only in plants and algae. Lysosomes are bags of digestive enzymes that break down waste. Smooth ER makes lipids and detoxifies. The Golgi modifies and ships.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Mitochondria carry out cellular respiration, generating ATP; they have a double membrane with folded inner cristae that increase surface area, and are present in nearly all eukaryotes. Chloroplasts conduct photosynthesis, converting light energy to chemical energy, and occur only in plants and algae. Lysosomes are vesicles containing hydrolytic enzymes for intracellular digestion of macromolecules, damaged organelles, and engulfed material. Smooth ER synthesizes lipids, detoxifies compounds, and stores calcium. The Golgi apparatus modifies, sorts, and routes proteins and lipids. Plant-specific structures include the cell wall and central vacuole.

MEMORY TRICK

Mitochondria are the power plant, chloroplasts are the solar panel, lysosomes are the recycling center, Golgi is the post office, ER is the factory floor.

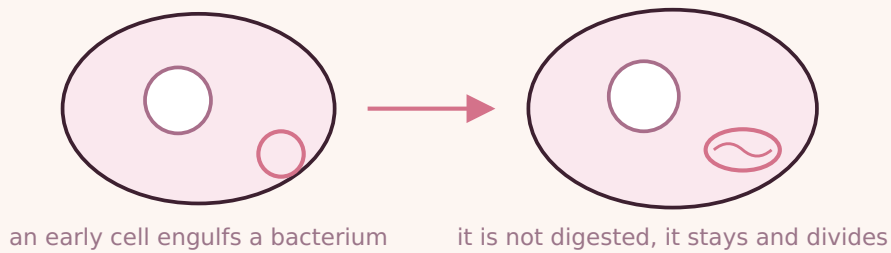
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Pick any organelle and say its job in one sentence, then say what would go wrong in the cell without it.

WRITE IT OUT

What is endosymbiosis, and what is the evidence?

Endosymbiosis: where mitochondria and chloroplasts came from



The evidence:

- they have their own DNA
- they have their own ribosomes
- they have a double membrane
- they divide on their own, like bacteria
- they are bacteria-sized

Mitochondria: animals, plants, fungi, most protists. Chloroplasts: plants and algae only, a second, later engulfing. The endomembrane system came from a different route: infolding of the plasma membrane. It is all membrane.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Long ago a large cell engulfed a bacterium and did not digest it. The bacterium stayed, kept dividing, and became the mitochondrion. Later, another cell engulfed a photosynthetic bacterium, which became the chloroplast. The evidence is that these organelles still act like bacteria: their own DNA, their own ribosomes, a double membrane, and they divide by themselves.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The endosymbiotic theory proposes that mitochondria and chloroplasts originated as free-living prokaryotes engulfed by an ancestral host cell and retained as endosymbionts. Supporting evidence: both possess their own circular DNA, their own prokaryote-type ribosomes, a double membrane consistent with engulfment, bacterial size, and independent division by binary fission. Mitochondria arose first and are present across eukaryotes; chloroplasts arose from a separate, later engulfment and are restricted to plants and algae. By contrast, the endomembrane system is thought to have arisen from infolding of the plasma membrane.

MEMORY TRICK

ENDO means inside, SYMBIOSIS means living together. Something moved in and never left. Remember the evidence as: own DNA, own ribosomes, double membrane, divides itself.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say the four pieces of evidence out loud. Then say how the endomembrane system's origin was different, because he put both on the same slide.

WRITE IT OUT

What does the cytoskeleton do?

The organelle roster

Nucleus

houses DNA as chromatin

nucleolus makes ribosomes · pores in envelope · contains proteins · NOT membrane bound

Ribosome

rRNA + protein complex

· makes proteins · NOT membrane bound

Rough ER

ribosomes studded on it

makes and packages secretory proteins

Smooth ER

no ribosomes

lipid synthesis, detox, calcium storage

Golgi apparatus

modifies, sorts, ships

the post office of the cell

Lysosome

vesicle of digestive enzymes

breaks down waste and worn parts

Mitochondrion

makes ATP from food

own DNA · folded cristae · in all eukaryotes

Chloroplast

photosynthesis

own DNA · plants and algae only

Cytoskeleton

microtubules + microfilaments

shape, support, movement, flagella and cilia

Plant cells also have: cell wall, central vacuole, chloroplasts

Animal cells have: centrioles, lysosomes, and usually no wall or large vacuole

Internal membranes do two things: compartmentalize the cell, and increase surface area for metabolism.

IN PLAIN WORDS

It is the cell's internal scaffolding. Microtubules are the thick hollow ones that give shape, act as tracks for moving things, and build flagella and cilia. Microfilaments are the thin ones involved in shape and in muscle movement.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The cytoskeleton provides structural support, maintains cell shape, anchors organelles, and enables movement. Microtubules are hollow tubes of tubulin that serve as tracks for organelle transport, form the mitotic spindle, and constitute the core of flagella and cilia. Microfilaments are thin actin polymers involved in cell shape, cytoplasmic streaming, amoeboid movement, and muscle contraction alongside myosin.

MEMORY TRICK

Microtubules are the big pipes and the highways. Microfilaments are the thin cables. Tubes move things, filaments pull things.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Name one structure built from microtubules and one process driven by microfilaments.

WRITE IT OUT

What are the three main functions of a cell?

The organelle roster

Nucleus

houses DNA as chromatin

nucleolus makes ribosomes · pores in envelope · proteins · NOT membrane bound

Ribosome

rRNA + protein complex

· makes proteins · NOT membrane bound

Rough ER

ribosomes studded on it

makes and packages secretory proteins

Smooth ER

no ribosomes

lipid synthesis, detox, calcium storage

Golgi apparatus

modifies, sorts, ships

the post office of the cell

Lysosome

vesicle of digestive enzymes

breaks down waste and worn parts

Mitochondrion

makes ATP from food

own DNA · folded cristae · in all eukaryotes

Chloroplast

photosynthesis

own DNA · plants and algae only

Cytoskeleton

microtubules + microfilaments

shape, support, movement, flagella and cilia

Plant cells also have: cell wall, central vacuole, chloroplasts

Animal cells have: centrioles, lysosomes, and usually no wall or large vacuole

Internal membranes do two things: compartmentalize the cell, and increase surface area for metabolism.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Make the molecules it needs for its own structure and function, transform energy and matter, and copy itself through cell division when needed.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Per lecture framing, a cell's principal functions are: synthesis of molecules supporting cellular structure and function; transformation of energy and matter (metabolism); and replication through cell division as required. Every organelle should be evaluated in terms of which of these three it serves.

MEMORY TRICK

Build, Burn, Divide. Whenever he asks about an organelle, figure out which of those three it is serving.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Pick three organelles and assign each one to one of these three functions. That is exactly the connection his slide asks you to make.

WRITE IT OUT

Tutoring & Practice Exam — picture sheet

From the ETC tutoring worksheets and the Unit One practice exam. Every diagram from this section, no text. Ten-minute review.

The checklist for being alive

Made of cells

one or more

Homeostasis

stays steady inside

Uses energy

metabolism

Grows

and develops

Responds

to its surroundings

Reproduces

makes more

Has DNA

heritable code

Evolves

as a population

A virus only ticks the last two boxes.

No cells, no metabolism, no homeostasis, no independent reproduction.

That is the whole “are viruses alive” debate in one picture.

One experiment: does fertilizer make basil grow taller?

GROUP A — control

0 mL fertilizer



GROUP B

5 mL fertilizer



GROUP C

10 mL fertilizer



Independent = amount of fertilizer (what I change on purpose)

Dependent = height in cm (what I measure)

Controlled = same soil, light, water, pot, basil variety · **Control group** = Group A

Three words people mix up constantly

Hypothesis

Narrow, testable
proposed explanation

"Ginkgo improves
memory in Alzheimer's"

Scale: one question

Theory

Broad explanation
backed by tons of evidence

"Evolution by
natural selection"

Scale: whole field

Law

Describes WHAT happens,
not why. Often math.

" $F = ma$ "
Gravity, thermodynamics

Scale: a pattern

A hypothesis never “grows up” into a law. They answer different kinds of questions.

Reading nuclide notation

mass number = protons + neutrons

charge: + means it LOST an electron

23

+

11

Na

atomic number = protons

So for $^{23}\text{Na}^+$ with atomic number 11

Protons = 11

Neutrons = $23 - 11 = 12$

Electrons = $11 - 1 = 10$ (it lost one)

Neutral atoms have equal protons and electrons. A + charge means electrons were lost, a - charge means electrons were gained.

What changes in each case

ISOTOPE

NEUTRONS

mass changes
chemistry stays the same
carbon-12 vs carbon-14

ION

ELECTRONS

charge changes
still the same element
Na vs Na^+

DIFFERENT ELEMENT

PROTONS

identity changes
an entirely new element
carbon vs nitrogen

Neutrons, electrons, protons. That is the whole worksheet in three words.

Functional groups: the “charms” clipped onto a carbon skeleton

Hydroxyl —OH

polar · makes things water-loving
alcohols, sugars

Carbonyl —C=O

polar · ketone (middle) or
aldehyde (end of chain)

Carboxyl —COOH

ACIDIC · donates H^+
amino acids, fatty acids

Amino —NH₂

BASIC · accepts H^+
amino acids, the other end

Sulfhydryl —SH

forms disulfide bridges
locks protein shape (hair!)

Phosphate —PO₄²⁻

negative · energy transfer
ATP, DNA backbone, phospholipids

Methyl —CH₃

NONPOLAR · no reactivity
a tag, not a tool. Marks DNA.

Writing the complementary strand

5'- A G G T C C G -3'

3'- T C C A G G C -5'

Two steps, in this order

1. Pair each base: A→T, T→A, G→C, C→G
2. Flip the direction: 5' becomes 3', antiparallel

The strands run ANTIPARALLEL, meaning opposite directions. If the given strand reads 5' to 3', its partner reads 3' to 5'.

Losing the direction label is the most common way to lose the point here.

DNA vs RNA: four differences

DNA

double stranded helix
sugar = deoxyribose
bases A T C G
stays in the nucleus
the master blueprint, kept safe

RNA

single stranded
sugar = ribose (extra OH)
bases A U C G (U replaces T)
travels out to the ribosome
mRNA carries · tRNA delivers · rRNA builds

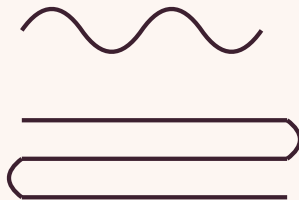
Four levels of protein structure

1° Primary



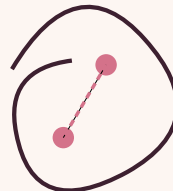
the sequence of amino acids
held by peptide bonds
DNA writes this

2° Secondary



alpha helix (coil) or beta pleated sheet
hydrogen bonds in backbone

3° Tertiary



whole chain folds into a 3D blob
R-group interactions, disulfide

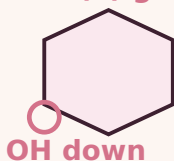
4° Quaternary



2+ finished chains assemble together
hemoglobin = 4 chains

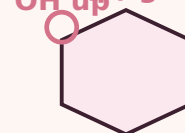
Alpha vs beta glucose, and why it decides everything

ALPHA (α) glucose



Starch: 1-4 links, coiled
Glycogen: 1-4 and 1-6, heavily branched

BETA (β) glucose

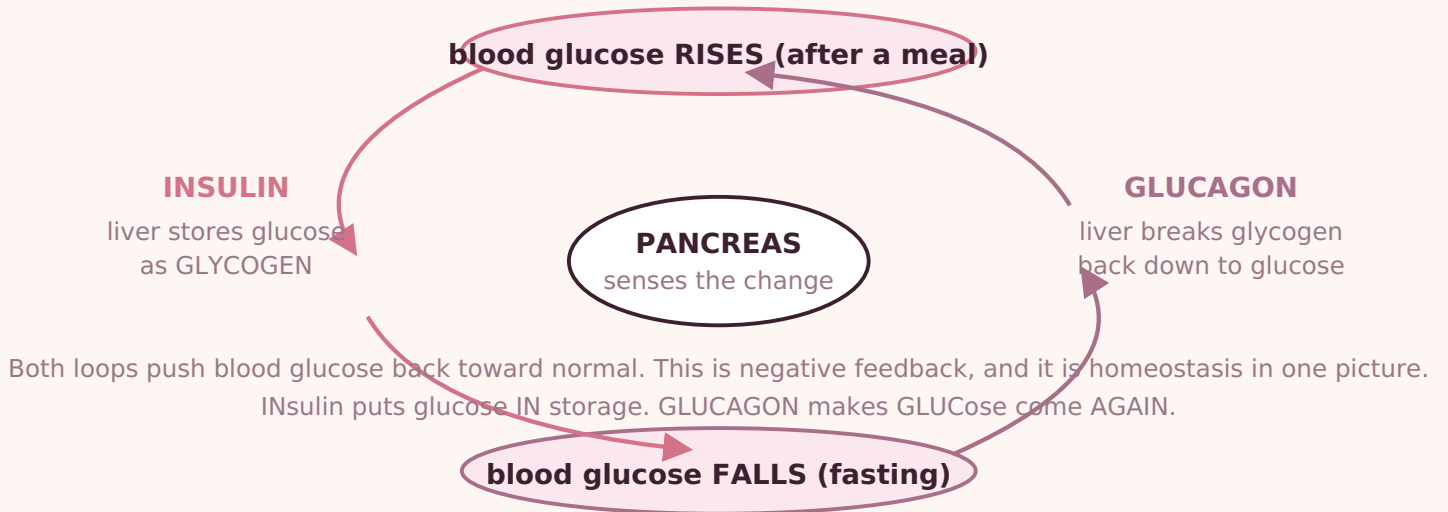


Cellulose: 1-4 links, straight unbranched
We have no enzyme

Same glucose. One hydroxyl group flipped. Completely different molecule.

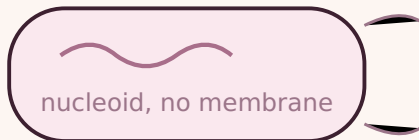
Alpha coils, so it stores energy. Beta stays straight and stacks, so it builds structure.
Starch and cellulose are both pure glucose. The only difference is which way that OH points.

Blood glucose regulation: the diagram they ask you to label



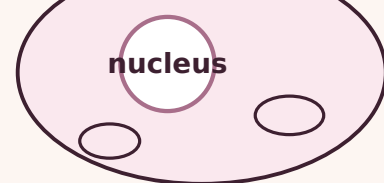
Prokaryotic vs eukaryotic

PROKARYOTE



- No nucleus, DNA loose in cytoplasm
- No membrane-bound organelles
- Small, 1-10 μm · has ribosomes
- Bacteria and archaea
- **Lab shapes: bacilli, spirilli, cocci**

EUKARYOTE



- True nucleus holding the DNA
- Many organelles, internal membranes
- Larger, 10-100 μm
- Animals, plants, fungi, protists

BOTH have: plasma membrane · protoplasm (cytoplasm) · DNA/RNA · ribosomes

Four classes, four building blocks

Carbohydrates

monosaccharide

quick energy,
structure in plants

Lipids

no true monomer

glycerol + fatty acids,
membranes, storage

Proteins

amino acid

enzymes, structure,
transport, defense

Nucleic acids

nucleotide

stores and carries
genetic information

Lipids are the odd one out: they are grouped by a property (hating water), not by a shared building block.

Tutoring & Practice Exam

ETC w/ Wren · 15 cards

PRACTICE EXAM

Name three characteristics that life and viruses SHARE.

The checklist for being alive

Made of cells
one or more

Homeostasis
stays steady inside

Uses energy
metabolism

Grows
and develops

Responds
to its surroundings

Reproduces
makes more

Has DNA
heritable code

Evolves
as a population

A virus only ticks the last two boxes.

No cells, no metabolism, no homeostasis, no independent reproduction.
That is the whole “are viruses alive” debate in one picture.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The study guide asks for exactly three. Safe answers: they contain genetic material, they reproduce (viruses need a host, but they do produce more of themselves), and they evolve through natural selection. You can also argue they show order, since a virion is a highly organized structure, and that they respond to their environment by binding specific host cells.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Shared characteristics: possession of nucleic acid genetic material (DNA or RNA); production of progeny, though viral reproduction is host dependent; evolutionary adaptation through mutation and natural selection; and structural order, since virions are precisely organized assemblies of capsomeres and nucleic acid. Viruses lack cellular organization, independent metabolism, homeostasis, and independent growth and development.

MEMORY TRICK

Genetic material, reproduction, evolution. Three that overlap, and the ones they fail are metabolism, homeostasis, cells, and growth.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say the three shared ones, then immediately say three they fail. Being able to do both is what the question is testing.

WRITE IT OUT

What is entropy, and how does it relate to energy in living systems?

IN PLAIN WORDS

Entropy is disorder. Energy naturally trends from higher organization to lower organization, meaning ordered energy spreads out and becomes less useful, usually as heat. Living things fight this by constantly taking in energy, which is why life needs a continuous supply.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Entropy is a measure of disorder or randomness in a system. Energy transformations are never fully efficient, and some energy is always dispersed as heat, increasing the entropy of the surroundings. Living systems maintain their internal order, a state of low entropy, only by continuously consuming energy and releasing heat, so the total entropy of the universe still increases. This is why energy must flow continuously through an ecosystem rather than cycling like matter does.

MEMORY TRICK

Entropy = things fall apart unless you spend energy. Your room does not clean itself, and neither does a cell.

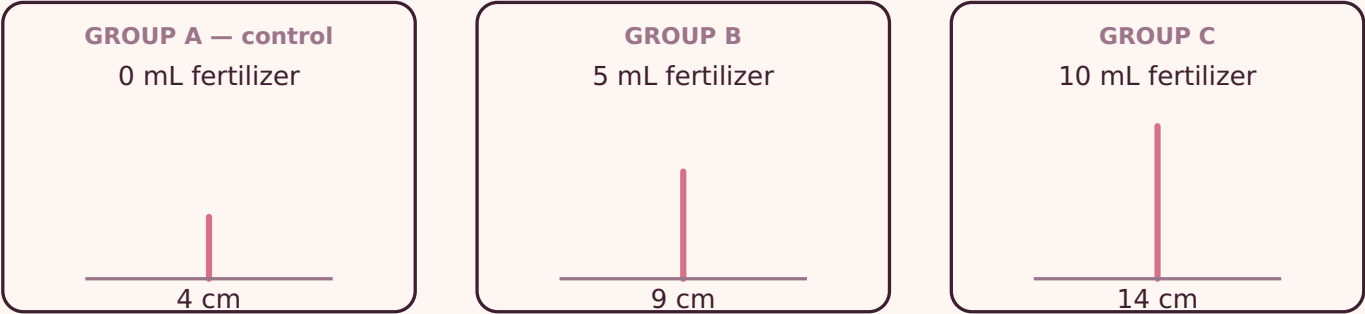
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say why energy flows through an ecosystem but matter cycles. Entropy is the reason, and this is a term on his vocabulary list.

WRITE IT OUT

Null hypothesis vs alternate hypothesis.

One experiment: does fertilizer make basil grow taller?



Independent = amount of fertilizer (what I change on purpose)
Dependent = height in cm (what I measure)
Controlled = same soil, light, water, pot, basil variety · **Control group** = Group A

IN PLAIN WORDS

The null hypothesis says there is NO effect, no difference, nothing going on. The alternate hypothesis says there IS an effect. You design the experiment to try to reject the null. For the sunflower worksheet: null is that soil pH has no effect on sunflower height, alternate is that soil pH does affect sunflower height.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The null hypothesis states that no relationship or difference exists between the variables under study. The alternate hypothesis states that a relationship or difference does exist. Experiments are structured to test whether the data justify rejecting the null hypothesis. Rejecting the null provides support for the alternate; failure to reject the null does not prove the null true, only that the evidence was insufficient.

MEMORY TRICK

NULL means NOTHING is happening. Alternate is the alternative to nothing. You never prove the null, you only fail to reject it.

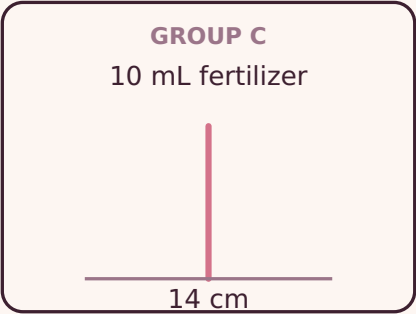
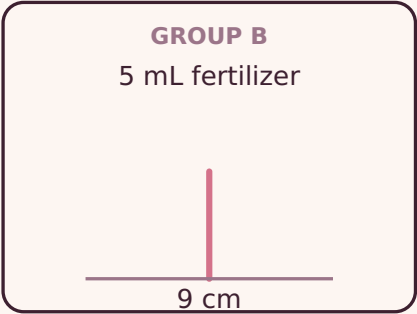
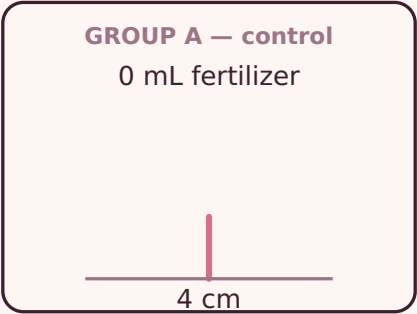
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Write both hypotheses for the sunflower experiment, then say the prediction in if-then form: if soil pH affects growth, then plants in the optimal pH will grow taller than plants outside it.

WRITE IT OUT

What are the components of experimental design?

One experiment: does fertilizer make basil grow taller?



Independent = amount of fertilizer (what I change on purpose)
Dependent = height in cm (what I measure)
Controlled = same soil, light, water, pot, basil variety · **Control group** = Group A

IN PLAIN WORDS

A testable hypothesis with a prediction, one independent variable you change, one dependent variable you measure, controlled variables held constant, a control group with no treatment, enough subjects, repetition, and a plan for analyzing the data.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Components of experimental design: a testable and falsifiable hypothesis with a stated prediction; a single manipulated independent variable; a measurable dependent variable; controlled variables held constant across all groups; a control group receiving no treatment to establish a baseline; adequate sample size with random assignment; replication of the experiment; and a predetermined method of data analysis.

MEMORY TRICK

Hypothesis, Independent, Dependent, Controlled, Control group, Sample size, Replication, Analysis. He asks this as a straight list question, so have the list ready.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

List all of them, then apply them to the sunflower experiment out loud: independent is soil pH, dependent is plant height in cm, controlled are sunlight, water, soil type, pot size and seed variety, and the control is the group at neutral pH.

WRITE IT OUT

Turning data into a law, then into a theory.

Three words people mix up constantly

Hypothesis

Narrow, testable
proposed explanation

"Gingko improves
memory in Alzheimer's"

Scale: one question

Theory

Broad explanation
backed by tons of evidence

"Evolution by
natural selection"

Scale: whole field

Law

Describes WHAT happens,
not why. Often math.

"F = ma"
Gravity, thermodynamics

Scale: a pattern

A hypothesis never “grows up” into a law. They answer different kinds of questions.

IN PLAIN WORDS

A law describes the pattern: sunflowers grow tallest at a soil pH around 6.6 to 6.8, and growth drops off above and below that. That is just what happens, no explanation. A theory explains why: soil pH affects the enzymes the plant needs to grow, so growth is best where those enzymes work best. And no, neither is permanent. Both can be revised with new evidence.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A scientific law is a descriptive generalization stating what consistently occurs under specified conditions, derived from repeated observation. From the data set, a law would state that sunflower growth peaks near pH 6.6 to 6.8 and declines on either side. A scientific theory is a broad, well-supported explanation of why the pattern occurs, here that soil pH alters the activity of enzymes required for growth. A law does not require a theory to exist, and a theory does not become a law. Both remain open to revision with new evidence.

MEMORY TRICK

Law = WHAT happens. Theory = WHY it happens. Neither becomes the other, and neither is set in stone.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Answer the worksheet's question 5 directly: how are your theory and law different, and do you need one to form the other? They describe versus explain, and no, you do not need one to make the other.

WRITE IT OUT

How do you read nuclide notation and draw the atom?

Reading nuclide notation

mass number = protons + neutrons

charge: + means it LOST an electron

23

+

11

Na

atomic number = protons

So for $^{23}\text{Na}^+$ with atomic number 11

Protons = 11

Neutrons = $23 - 11 = 12$

Electrons = $11 - 1 = 10$ (it lost one)

Neutral atoms have equal protons and electrons. A + charge means electrons were lost, a – charge means electrons were gained.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The top number is mass, the bottom number is atomic number, meaning protons. The charge tells you about electrons. For sodium-23 with atomic number 11 and a plus charge: 11 protons, 12 neutrons because 23 minus 11, and 10 electrons because it lost one.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

In nuclide notation the superscript is the mass number, the subscript is the atomic number equal to the proton count, and any charge is written to the upper right. Neutrons equal mass number minus atomic number. Electron count equals proton count in a neutral atom, decreased by the magnitude of a positive charge, or increased by the magnitude of a negative charge. For sodium-23 with a plus one charge: 11 protons, 12 neutrons, 10 electrons.

MEMORY TRICK

Top minus bottom equals neutrons. Plus charge means electrons were lost, so subtract. It reads backwards from how it feels.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Work the worksheet problem out loud: give protons, neutrons and electrons for sodium-23 plus, then describe the Bohr diagram you would draw, 2 in the first shell and 8 in the second.

WRITE IT OUT

Isotope, ion, different element: what varies in each?

What changes in each case

ISOTOPE

NEUTRONS

mass changes
chemistry stays the same
carbon-12 vs carbon-14

ION

ELECTRONS

charge changes
still the same element
Na vs Na⁺

DIFFERENT ELEMENT

PROTONS

identity changes
an entirely new element
carbon vs nitrogen

Neutrons, electrons, protons. That is the whole worksheet in three words.

IN PLAIN WORDS

An isotope has a varying number of neutrons. An ion has a varying number of electrons. Different elements have a varying number of protons. Three words, three particles.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Isotopes of an element differ in neutron number, therefore in mass number, while retaining identical chemical behavior. Ions differ in electron number relative to the neutral atom, producing a net charge while remaining the same element. Different elements differ in proton number, which is the atomic number and defines elemental identity.

MEMORY TRICK

Neutrons for isotopes, electrons for ions, protons for elements. The worksheet asks all three side by side, so learn them as a set.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say all three in one breath. This is a three-part worksheet question and almost certainly a set of exam questions.

WRITE IT OUT

Functional groups by their properties, the way the worksheet asks.

Functional groups: the “charms” clipped onto a carbon skeleton

Hydroxyl —OH
polar · makes things water-loving
alcohols, sugars

Carbonyl —C=O
polar · ketone (middle) or
aldehyde (end of chain)

Carboxyl —COOH
ACIDIC · donates H+
amino acids, fatty acids

Amino —NH₂
BASIC · accepts H+
amino acids, the other end

Sulfhydryl —SH
forms disulfide bridges
locks protein shape (hair!)

Phosphate —PO₄²⁻
negative · energy transfer
ATP, DNA backbone, phospholipids

Methyl —CH₃
NONPOLAR · no reactivity
a tag, not a tool. Marks DNA.

IN PLAIN WORDS

The back-pocket guide asks these as fill-in-the-blank. Hydroxyl creates polarity and hydrogen bonds. Carbonyl oxygen is double-bonded, and it makes ketones in the middle of a chain and aldehydes at the end. Carboxyl is in organic acids, donates H+, and gains a negative charge. Amino makes organic bases that accept H+. Sulfhydryl makes covalent crosslinks in proteins. Phosphate has four oxygens and a negative charge, and it makes the phospholipid head polar.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Hydroxyl (-OH): polar, forms hydrogen bonds, increases solubility. Carbonyl (C=O): the oxygen is double bonded; internal placement gives a ketone, terminal placement gives an aldehyde; ketones and aldehydes containing the same atoms are structural isomers. Carboxyl (-COOH): found in organic acids, donates hydrogen ions, acquires a negative charge, and can participate in ionic bonds. Amino (-NH₂): basic, accepts hydrogen ions, acquires a positive charge, participates in ionic bonds. Sulfhydryl (-SH): forms covalent crosslinks, specifically disulfide bridges, in proteins; slightly polar. Phosphate: carries four oxygens and a negative charge, makes the phospholipid head polar, and is central to energy transfer. Methyl (-CH₃): nonpolar and unreactive.

MEMORY TRICK

Polar groups: hydroxyl and carbonyl. Ionic groups: carboxyl, amino, and phosphate. That grouping is literally a fill-in-the-blank on the sheet.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Go down the blanks out loud: which groups are polar, which are ionic, how many oxygens on a phosphate and what charge, and which group makes covalent crosslinks.

WRITE IT OUT

How do you write a complementary DNA strand?

Writing the complementary strand



Two steps, in this order

1. Pair each base: A→T, T→A, G→C, C→G
2. Flip the direction: 5´ becomes 3´, antiparallel

The strands run ANTIPARALLEL, meaning opposite directions. If the given strand reads 5´ to 3´, its partner reads 3´ to 5´.

Losing the direction label is the most common way to lose the point here.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Two steps. Pair each base, A with T and G with C. Then flip the direction label, because the strands run antiparallel. So 5'-AGGTCCG-3' becomes 3'-TCCAGGC-5'.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

To construct a complementary strand, apply complementary base pairing to each nucleotide (A with T, T with A, G with C, C with G) and reverse the directionality, since the strands of DNA are antiparallel. Given 5'-AGGTCCG-3', the complement is 3'-TCCAGGC-5'. If the answer is written in the conventional 5' to 3' direction, it reads 5'-CGGACCT-3'.

MEMORY TRICK

Pair it, then flip the ends. Forgetting the 5' and 3' labels is the single most common way to lose the point here.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Do the longer one from the nucleotide worksheet out loud: ACGTTTCCAGGACGCGCAATGG. Complement is TGCAAAGGTCCTGCGCGTTACC, and say the direction labels as you go.

WRITE IT OUT

What is the flow of genetic information in a eukaryotic cell?

DNA vs RNA: four differences

DNA

double stranded helix
sugar = deoxyribose
bases A T C G
stays in the nucleus
the master blueprint, kept safe

RNA

single stranded
sugar = ribose (extra OH)
bases A U C G (U replaces T)
travels out to the ribosome
mRNA carries · tRNA delivers · rRNA builds

IN PLAIN WORDS

DNA to RNA to protein. DNA is transcribed into mRNA in the nucleus, the mRNA leaves through a nuclear pore, and ribosomes translate it into a chain of amino acids that folds into a protein.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

The flow of genetic information proceeds DNA to RNA to protein. Transcription occurs in the nucleus, producing messenger RNA from a DNA template. The mRNA exits through a nuclear pore to the cytoplasm. Translation occurs at ribosomes, where the mRNA sequence directs assembly of a polypeptide, which then folds into a functional protein. Thymine is found only in DNA; uracil is found only in RNA.

MEMORY TRICK

DNA makes RNA makes protein. Transcription then translation. And for the base question: T is DNA only, U is RNA only.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say the flow with the process names attached, then answer the study guide question: which base is only in DNA and which is only in RNA.

WRITE IT OUT

Polypeptide vs protein, and which level survives hydrogen bond disruption?

Four levels of protein structure

1° Primary

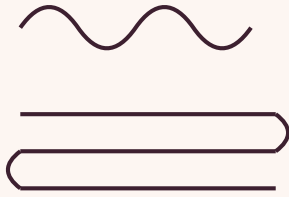


the sequence of
amino acids

held by peptide bonds

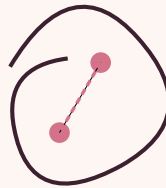
DNA writes this

2° Secondary



alpha helix (coil) or
beta pleated sheet
hydrogen bonds in backbone

3° Tertiary



whole chain folds into
a 3D blob

R-group interactions, disulfide

4° Quaternary



2+ finished chains
assemble together
hemoglobin = 4 chains

IN PLAIN WORDS

A polypeptide is the unfolded chain of amino acids. A protein is that chain folded into its working shape. And if hydrogen bonds get disrupted, primary structure is the level least affected, because primary structure is held by peptide bonds, which are covalent and much stronger.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

A polypeptide is an unfolded linear chain of amino acids joined by peptide bonds. A protein is one or more polypeptides folded into a specific functional conformation. Primary structure is maintained by covalent peptide bonds and is therefore least affected by disruption of hydrogen bonds. Secondary structure depends directly on backbone hydrogen bonding and is most vulnerable; tertiary and quaternary structures are also stabilized in part by hydrogen bonds among other interactions.

MEMORY TRICK

Polypeptide is the chain, protein is the chain folded. And for the hydrogen bond question: primary survives, because peptide bonds are covalent, not hydrogen bonds.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

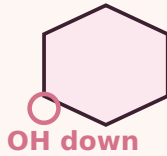
Say the difference between a polypeptide and a protein in one sentence, then say which structural level hydrogen bond disruption barely touches and why.

WRITE IT OUT

Amylase can only break alpha glucose linkages. What can it digest?

Alpha vs beta glucose, and why it decides everything

ALPHA (α) glucose



Starch: 1-4 links, coiled
Glycogen: 1-4 and 1-6,
heavily branched

BETA (β) glucose



Cellulose: 1-4 links,
straight unbranched
We have no enzyme

Same glucose. One hydroxyl group flipped. Completely different molecule.

Alpha coils, so it stores energy. Beta stays straight and stacks, so it builds structure.

Starch and cellulose are both pure glucose. The only difference is which way that OH points.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Glycogen, starch, and amylopectin, because all three are built from alpha glucose. It cannot touch cellulose or chitin, because those use beta linkages. This is the alpha versus beta rule turned into an applied question.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Amylase hydrolyzes alpha glycosidic linkages. Starch, including its branched component amylopectin, and glycogen are alpha-linked glucose polymers and are therefore substrates for amylase. Cellulose and chitin are beta-linked and cannot be hydrolyzed by amylase, which is why they pass through the human digestive tract undigested.

MEMORY TRICK

Alpha is what we can digest. Beta is fiber. Amylopectin is just the branched part of starch, so it is alpha too.

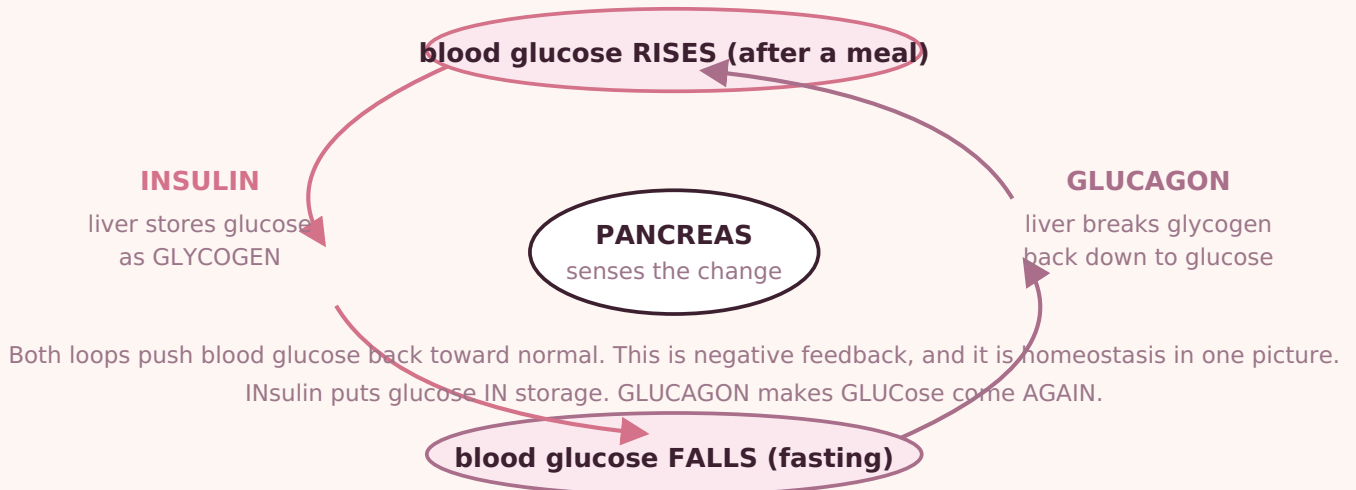
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say which polysaccharides amylase can break and which it cannot, and give the reason in terms of alpha versus beta linkages.

WRITE IT OUT

Label the blood glucose regulation diagram.

Blood glucose regulation: the diagram they ask you to label



IN PLAIN WORDS

Blood glucose rises after a meal. The pancreas releases insulin. The liver takes glucose out of the blood and stores it as glycogen, so glucose comes down. When blood glucose falls, the pancreas releases glucagon, the liver breaks glycogen back into glucose, and glucose goes up. Two opposite loops, both pushing back toward normal.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Blood glucose regulation is a negative feedback system. Elevated blood glucose stimulates pancreatic beta cells to secrete insulin, which promotes glucose uptake by cells and hepatic conversion of glucose to glycogen, lowering blood glucose. Depressed blood glucose stimulates pancreatic alpha cells to secrete glucagon, which promotes hepatic glycogenolysis, releasing glucose into the blood and raising blood glucose. The liver is the storage site and the pancreas is the sensor and signal source.

MEMORY TRICK

INsulin puts glucose IN storage. GLUCAGON makes GLUCose come AGAIN. Pancreas senses, liver stores.

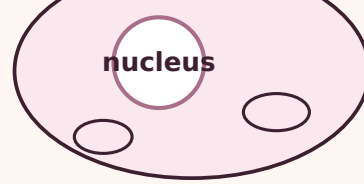
SAY IT OUT LOUD

Trace both directions out loud, naming the organ, the hormone, and what happens to glycogen in each. This diagram appears twice across the study guides, which is a strong hint.

WRITE IT OUT

Prokaryote vs eukaryote: the Venn diagram and the tricky ones.**Prokaryotic vs eukaryotic****PROKARYOTE**

- No nucleus, DNA loose in cytoplasm
- No membrane-bound organelles
- Small, 1–10 μm · has ribosomes
- Bacteria and archaea
- **Lab shapes: bacilli, spirilli, cocci**

EUKARYOTE

- True nucleus holding the DNA
- Many organelles, internal membranes
- Larger, 10–100 μm
- Animals, plants, fungi, protists

BOTH have: plasma membrane · protoplasm (cytoplasm) · DNA/RNA · ribosomes

IN PLAIN WORDS

Shared middle: protoplasm, DNA/RNA, cell membrane, ribosomes, living. Prokaryote only: simple. Eukaryote only: nucleus, organelles, complex. Two extras the worksheet tests: prokaryotes are simpler, they DO need to be small, their shapes are bacilli, cocci and spirilla, and their DNA lacks histones.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Shared features: plasma membrane, protoplasm, genetic material as DNA and RNA, ribosomes, and living status. Prokaryote-specific: structural simplicity, absence of a nucleus and of membrane-bound organelles, small size necessitated by reliance on diffusion. Eukaryote-specific: true nucleus, membrane-bound organelles, greater complexity and size. Prokaryotic DNA is not packaged with histone proteins, which is one structural difference from eukaryotic chromatin. Common prokaryotic morphologies are bacilli, cocci, and spirilla.

MEMORY TRICK

Middle of the Venn: membrane, protoplasm, DNA/RNA, ribosomes, living. And the worksheet's sneaky one: prokaryotic DNA lacks HISTONES, not guanine or RNA.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Fill the Venn out loud, then answer the four worksheet questions: simpler, false they do need to be small, bacilli cocci and spirilla, and histones.

WRITE IT OUT

Fill the macromolecule table: monomer, polymer, function.

Four classes, four building blocks

Carbohydrates monosaccharide quick energy, structure in plants	Lipids no true monomer glycerol + fatty acids, membranes, storage	Proteins amino acid enzymes, structure, transport, defense	Nucleic acids nucleotide stores and carries genetic information
--	---	--	---

Lipids are the odd one out: they are grouped by a property (hating water), not by a shared building block.

IN PLAIN WORDS

Carbohydrates: monomer monosaccharide, polymer polysaccharide, function energy and structure. Lipids: no true monomer, built from glycerol and fatty acids, function energy storage, membranes, hormones. Proteins: monomer amino acid, polymer polypeptide, function enzymes, structure, transport, defense. Nucleic acids: monomer nucleotide, polymer DNA and RNA, function storing and expressing genetic information.

HOW TO SAY IT ON THE EXAM

Carbohydrates: monosaccharide monomer, polysaccharide polymer, functions in fuel and structural support. Lipids: not true polymers, assembled from glycerol and fatty acid components, functions in long-term energy storage, membrane structure, and hormone signaling. Proteins: amino acid monomer, polypeptide polymer, functions include catalysis, structure, transport, movement, defense and signaling. Nucleic acids: nucleotide monomer, DNA and RNA polymers, functions to store, transmit, regulate and express hereditary information controlling cellular activities.

MEMORY TRICK

Four rows, and the lipid row is the one that breaks the pattern because it has no true monomer. Note that too, since the table will tempt you to invent one.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

Say all four rows across: class, monomer, polymer, function. The macromolecules study guide asks for the specific monomer of cellulose (beta glucose) and of protein (amino acid), so give the specific answer, not the general one.

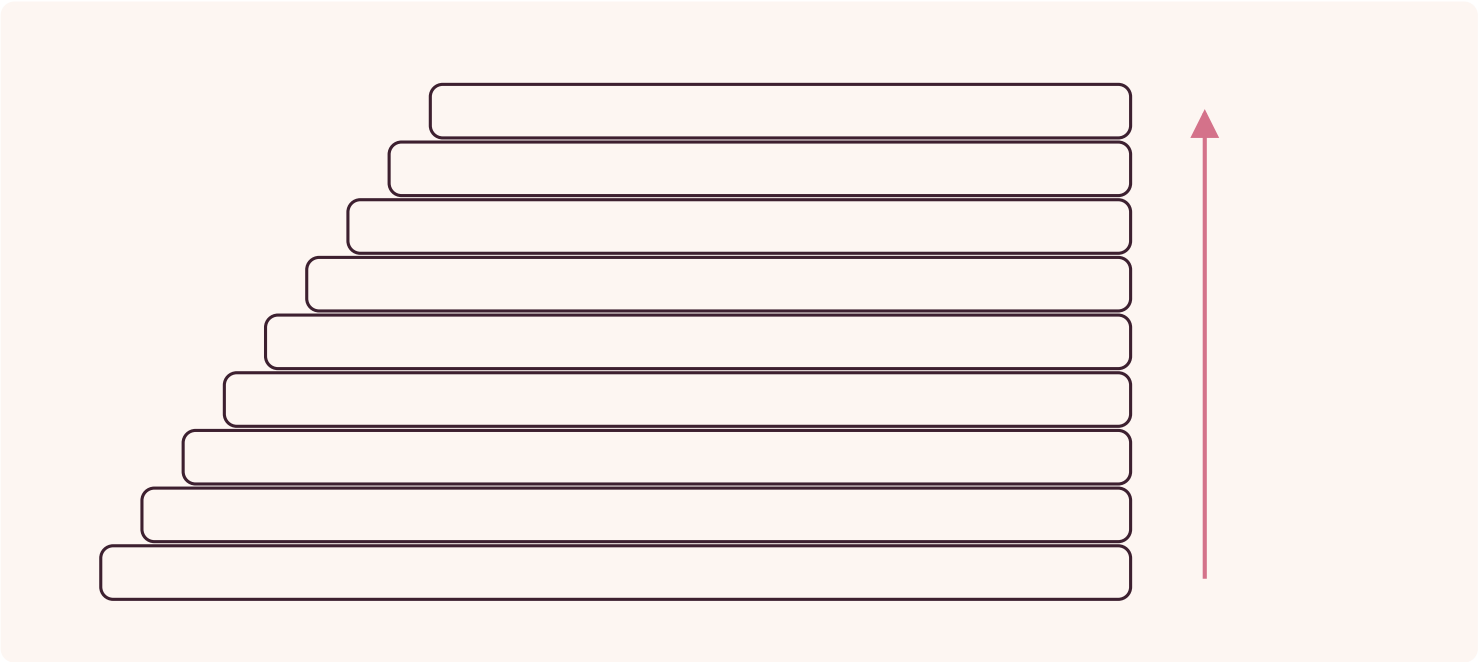
WRITE IT OUT

Label it from memory

Fill these in with a pen, then check them against the picture sheets

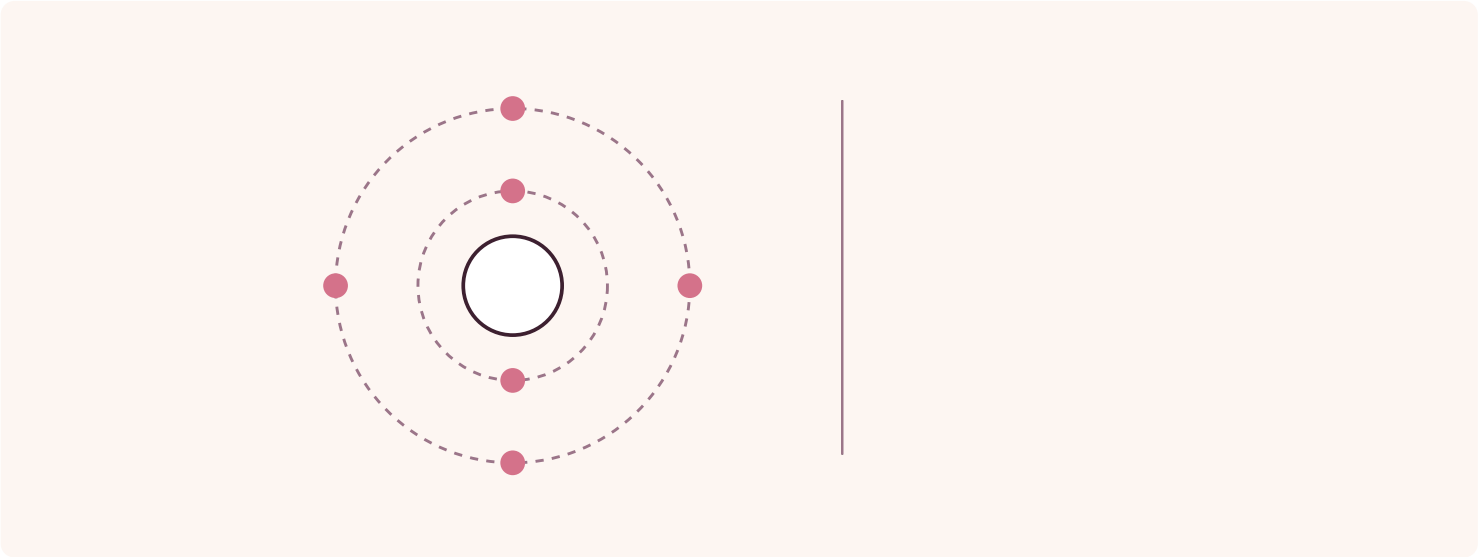
The ladder of biological organization

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.



The atom

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.



Water's four properties

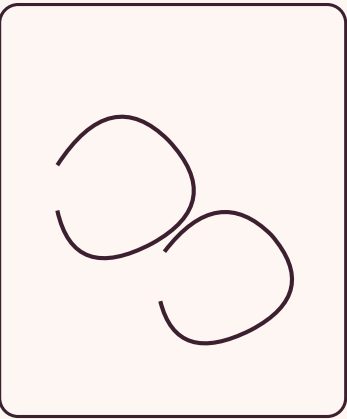
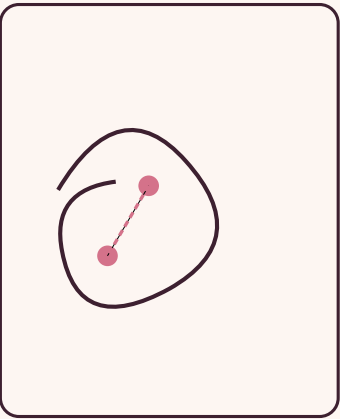
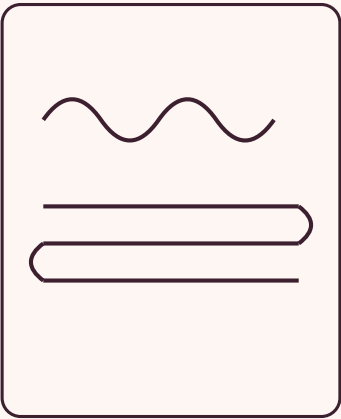
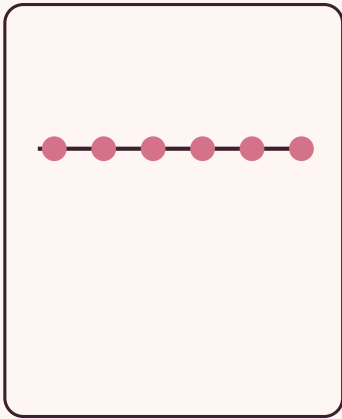
Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

The pH equations

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

The four levels of protein structure

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

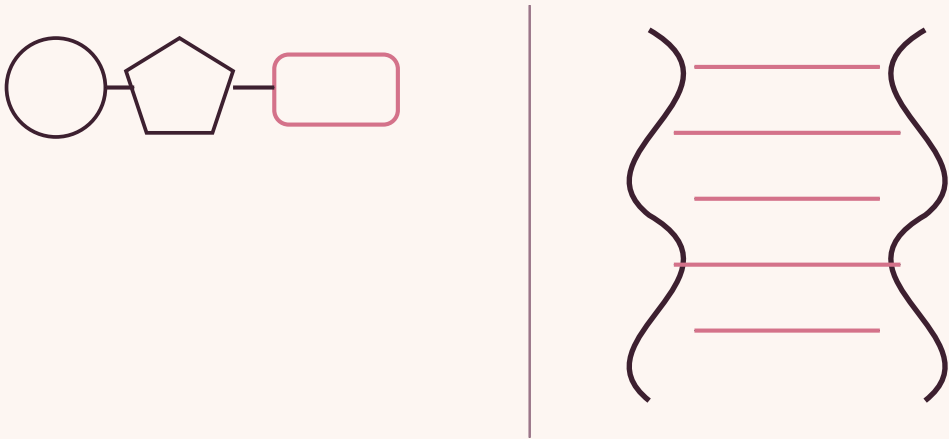


Amino acid R group categories

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

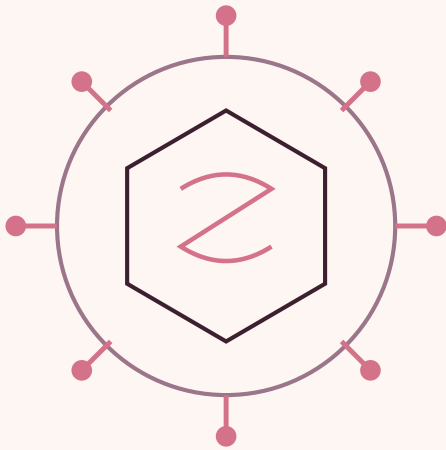
The nucleotide and the double helix

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.



The parts of a virus

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

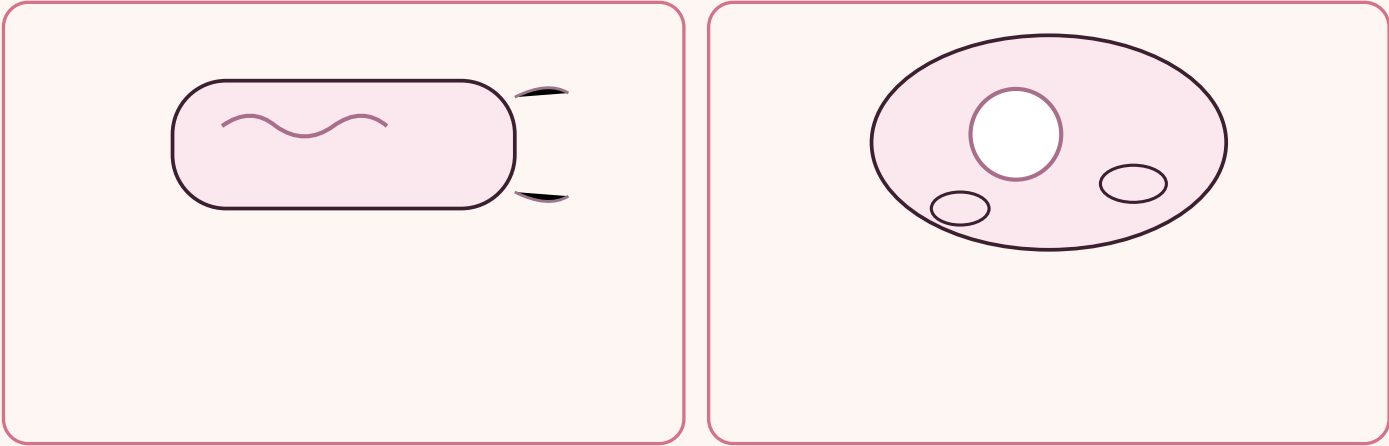


The seven functional groups

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

Prokaryote vs eukaryote

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

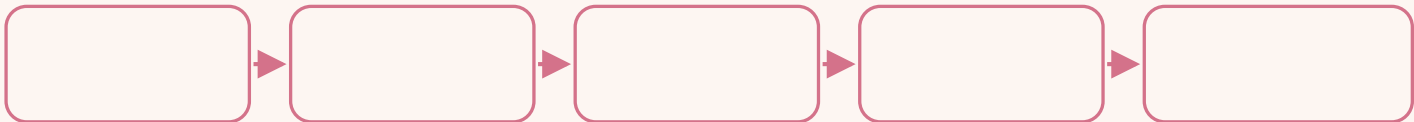


The organelle roster

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.

The endomembrane pathway

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.



Lab 4 specimens

Name every part, and for each one write what it does.



Go deeper

Optional. One entry per card, in the same order. A harder version of each question, why it matters in a pathology lab, and where it comes back later.

Skip this entirely if you are cramming. It is here for the day after the exam, and for the tutoring session you could not make.

Big Ideas

What is biology?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

His first slide paired a breaching orca with a cluster of bats. Why open with two wildly different animals? It sets up the theme he returns to all semester: life is enormously diverse, yet all of it runs on the same chemistry and the same genetic code. Unity and diversity, which is what evolution explains.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Every course after this one narrows this definition to a level: cells, tissues, organisms, populations.

What are the six concepts that organize this whole course?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Evolution is called the unifying theme because it explains two opposite-seeming facts at once: why all life shares the same DNA code, the same amino acids, the same ATP (unity, from common ancestry), and why life is so varied (diversity, from adaptation to different environments). One idea, both facts.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Every chapter of this course will be an instance of one of these six.

Walk through the steps of the scientific process.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

The textbook draws this as a clean loop, but real research almost never runs in order. Name two ways a real study departs from it. One: observation and hypothesis often swap, because a researcher starts with a hypothesis and goes looking for observations to test it. Two: results routinely send you back to fix the method rather than the hypothesis, which is not a step on any diagram.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

A pathology lab lives in the analysis and communication steps. A pathologist takes data (a slide, a stain, a lab value), interprets it against known patterns, and issues a report that another physician acts on. The report is the communication step, and it has consequences.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Every lab report you write in Chem 1A and A&B has this structure baked into it: purpose, hypothesis, method, results, discussion.

Control vs independent vs dependent variable. Define all three using one experiment.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

A study finds that people who drink more coffee have lower rates of a disease. Name the independent variable, the dependent variable, and then say why this study cannot claim coffee prevents the disease. The answer: it is observational, not experimental. Nobody assigned the coffee, so coffee drinkers may differ in a dozen other ways, and any of those could be the real cause. Correlation is not causation, and the reason is uncontrolled variables.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Clinical trials are this exact structure with lives attached. The treatment is the independent variable, the outcome is the dependent variable, and the control group gets a placebo. Blinding exists because knowing which group you are in changes the result.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This is the backbone of the MCAT's research design questions, which appear in every section, not just biology.

Hypothesis vs scientific theory vs scientific law.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

If a theory is so well supported, can it ever be wrong? Yes, and it has happened. The theory of spontaneous generation was mainstream until Pasteur's experiments. The point is not that theories are fragile, it is that they are the strongest thing science offers while still being revisable. Certainty is not on the menu.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

You will hear people misuse this word for the rest of your life. Being able to explain the difference cleanly is a small but real credibility marker in any science setting.

What makes a hypothesis a good one?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Rewrite this into a testable hypothesis: 'Stress is bad for health.' A workable version specifies a measurable exposure and a measurable outcome, for example: 'Adults reporting high perceived stress on a validated scale will show higher resting cortisol than adults reporting low stress.' Now both sides are measurable, and a result could contradict it.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Diagnostic reasoning works the same way. A differential diagnosis is a set of competing hypotheses, and each test ordered is designed to rule one out. A diagnosis you cannot test is not a diagnosis.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Writing testable hypotheses is the first graded skill in any research methods course and in any lab you join.

How do you read and interpret a scientific graph?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

A graph shows a treatment group averaging 20 and a control averaging 18, with error bars that overlap heavily. What can you conclude? Very little. Overlapping error bars suggest the difference may be within normal variation rather than a real effect. Always check the y-axis too, because starting it at 17 instead of 0 makes that small gap look enormous.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Reading figures critically is most of what you do with a scientific paper, and it is exactly what the MCAT tests in its passage sections.

How do you construct a graph from your own data?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

You measured heart rate at rest, after 1 minute, 3 minutes, and 5 minutes of exercise, in 20 people. What graph, and why? A line graph, because time is continuous and you want to show change across it, with error bars showing variation between the 20 people. A bar graph would work only if you were comparing separate categories, like three different exercise types.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Every lab report in Chem 1A will ask you to graph data and justify the format you picked.

How do you critique somebody else's experimental design?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

A supplement company reports that 8 out of 10 people felt more energetic after taking their product for a week. List every flaw. No control group, no blinding, self-reported and unmeasurable outcome, tiny sample, no randomization, no time control for placebo effect, and nothing ruling out that people who choose to take a supplement expect to feel better.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Journal clubs are this exercise done professionally, every week, for the rest of a medical career. The skill is not finding flaws, it is deciding whether a flaw is fatal to the conclusion or merely a limitation.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This is the highest-value transferable skill in this entire chapter.

How would you design an experiment from scratch?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Your design will have a flaw. Name yours before someone else does. In the music-and-studying example: how do you keep the difficulty of the study material equal across groups, and how do you stop people who already study with music from having an advantage? Random assignment handles the second. The first needs matched materials, and saying so out loud is what separates a designed experiment from a guess.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

When you approach a professor about research, showing up with a designed experiment rather than an idea is the difference between a polite no and a yes.

Why do scientists publish and peer review?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Peer review catches a lot, but it does not catch everything. What does it not catch? Fabricated data, usually. Reviewers evaluate the reasoning and methods described, not the raw numbers, and they rarely replicate anything. That is why independent replication, not peer review, is the real test.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Pathology reports get a version of this too. Difficult cases go to a second pathologist, and unusual findings go to a consensus conference. Same principle, faster timeline.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Understanding what peer review does and does not guarantee will matter the first time you read a preprint.

Basic science vs applied science.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

CRISPR gene editing came from researchers studying how bacteria defend themselves against viruses. Nobody was trying to build a gene editing tool. Explain what that says about funding basic research. The useful answer: you cannot know in advance which basic question turns into a technology, so a system that only funds applications will systematically miss the biggest breakthroughs.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

If you end up in a research lab, this distinction will decide which grants you can apply for.

What Is Life

What properties define something as alive?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Fire grows, consumes fuel, produces waste, responds to its environment, and spreads. Why is it not alive? It fails cellular organization, it has no genetic material, and it does not maintain homeostasis or evolve. This is the classic trap question, and the answer is that life requires the whole list, not a majority of it.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Every definition problem in biology, from viruses to prions to synthetic cells, comes back to this list.

Are viruses alive? Argue both sides.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Prions are worse. They are misfolded proteins with no genetic material at all, and they reproduce by forcing normal proteins to misfold into the same shape. Are they alive? By every criterion, no. They do not even have a genome. Yet they replicate and cause fatal disease. If you can explain why a prion is not alive but still dangerous, you have understood that being alive and being biologically active are different questions.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Prion diseases like Creutzfeldt-Jakob are diagnosed on autopsy by a pathologist, and the tissue shows a distinctive spongy pattern. It is one of the few diagnoses that is definitively pathological rather than clinical.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

The virus question reappears in microbiology and in every discussion of what counts as an infectious agent.

What is homeostasis? Give an example.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Distinguish negative from positive feedback with one example each. Negative feedback reverses a change and is the basis of nearly all homeostasis, like sweating when hot. Positive feedback amplifies a change and is rare because it is unstable, but childbirth uses it: contractions release oxytocin, which causes stronger contractions, until delivery ends the loop.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Disease is very often homeostasis failing. Diabetes is failed blood glucose regulation, hypertension is failed blood pressure regulation, and fever is homeostasis working with the set point deliberately moved.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

A&P spends entire units on this. Nearly every organ system is explained as a homeostatic mechanism.

Rank the levels of biological organization.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Which level would a pathologist work at most of the time? Tissue, primarily, which is what histology is. But the answer is really that pathology crosses levels constantly: a tissue abnormality gets explained by a cellular change, which gets explained by a molecular one. Being able to move up and down this ladder is the actual skill.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Histopathology is literally the study of the tissue level. A biopsy is a tissue sample, read for cellular abnormalities that predict organism-level disease.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This ladder is how every later biology course is organized.

What is emergence? Give an example using two levels.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Is consciousness an emergent property, and can it be explained by studying neurons alone? This is a real open argument, not a settled answer, and that is the point. A strong answer says: emergent properties can be studied at the lower level, but they cannot be predicted from it, which is why reductionism alone runs out.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Systems biology as a field exists because of this limitation.

What is reductionism? Give an example using two levels.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Give one thing reductionism explains beautifully and one thing it fails at. It explains sickle cell disease perfectly: one DNA base change, one amino acid change, one misshapen protein, one disease. It fails at something like depression, where no single molecule accounts for the condition and the explanation has to sit at several levels at once.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Molecular pathology is reductionism applied: identify the exact genetic lesion causing a cancer, then target it with a drug built for that lesion.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This tension shows up in every genetics and neuroscience course you take.

Give an example of structure relating to function.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Run the logic backwards. You are shown an unfamiliar cell under a microscope that is packed with mitochondria and has a hugely folded membrane. What does it probably do? Something enormously energy-expensive with a lot of transport, like a kidney tubule cell or cardiac muscle. Predicting function from structure is exactly what a pathologist does with an unfamiliar slide.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

This is the core reasoning skill of histology. You identify tissue and spot abnormality by reading shape, arrangement, and staining pattern, then inferring what the cell was doing or failing to do.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Histology and A&P are essentially two years of this one skill.

What is the most fundamental unit of life, and why?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Mitochondria have their own DNA, their own ribosomes, and divide independently. Why are they still not alive? Because they cannot survive or reproduce outside a host cell, and they depend on nuclear genes for most of their proteins. The endosymbiotic theory says they used to be free-living bacteria, which makes this a case of something that was alive and is no longer independently so.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Mitochondrial DNA is inherited only from the mother and mutates faster than nuclear DNA, which makes it useful in both genetic disease diagnosis and forensic identification.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Endosymbiotic theory gets a full treatment in cell biology and evolution.

Put natural selection in your own words.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Antibiotic resistance is natural selection you can watch in a week. Walk through it: a bacterial population already contains rare variants with resistance; the antibiotic kills the susceptible ones; the resistant ones survive and reproduce; the population is now mostly resistant. Note what did NOT happen: the bacteria did not develop resistance because of the antibiotic. The variation was already there.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Antibiotic resistance patterns are tracked by clinical microbiology labs, and hospital prescribing guidelines are set from that data. It is one of the most direct ways evolution touches daily medicine.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Evolution is a full unit of the MCAT biology section and underlies all of genetics.

Viruses

Describe the basic structure of a virus.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Naked viruses survive far longer on surfaces than enveloped ones and resist alcohol sanitizer better. Explain why using the lipid card. The envelope is lipid, and both soap and alcohol disrupt lipids. A naked virus has only a protein capsid, so there is no lipid to disrupt. Norovirus is naked, which is why outbreaks spread through surfaces so effectively.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Disinfection protocols in clinical labs are chosen based on whether the target pathogen is enveloped, and this is the reason.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Microbiology covers viral classification and disinfection in detail.

Why is a virus so specific about which cells it infects?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

HIV infects helper T cells specifically because its surface protein binds the CD4 receptor, which those cells carry. That single binding specificity explains the entire disease: destroy the cells that coordinate immune response, and every other infection becomes dangerous. Specificity is not a detail, it determines what the disease looks like.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

CD4 counts are the standard monitoring test in HIV care, measuring exactly the cell population the virus targets.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Receptor-ligand specificity underlies immunology and pharmacology both.

Walk through RNA virus replication inside a host cell.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Retroviruses like HIV add a step: reverse transcriptase copies their RNA genome into DNA, which then integrates into the host genome permanently. Explain why that makes the infection so hard to cure. The viral DNA becomes part of the cell's own chromosome, so eliminating it means eliminating the infected cell.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Antiretroviral drugs target specific steps of this cycle, and combination therapy works because hitting several steps at once makes resistance far less likely.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Viral replication strategies are a core microbiology topic.

Why do RNA viruses mutate so fast?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Influenza changes in two distinct ways. Antigenic drift is gradual mutation, and it is why the vaccine is updated yearly. Antigenic shift is two different flu strains infecting one cell and swapping whole genome segments, producing something the population has no immunity to at all. Shift is what causes pandemics, drift causes seasons.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Flu strain surveillance and vaccine composition decisions are made annually from global lab data.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Viral evolution is heavily tested on the MCAT and central to epidemiology.

Build a full answer to 'are viruses alive?'

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Giant viruses like mimivirus are bigger than some bacteria and carry genes for protein synthesis machinery, which was thought to be impossible for a virus. Does that change the answer? It complicates it. They still cannot replicate independently, so most biologists still say no, but they show the boundary is blurrier than a textbook implies. Acknowledging that nuance is what a strong answer does.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

The definition of life stays genuinely unsettled, and you will meet it again in microbiology and astrobiology.

How do viruses fit into the characteristics-of-life checklist?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Some argue viruses should count as alive while inside a host cell and not alive outside it, treating life as a state rather than a property. Evaluate that. It is coherent, but it breaks how we use the word everywhere else, since nothing else switches between alive and not alive. Whether you accept it or not, being able to weigh the argument is what a full-credit answer looks like.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This framing appears in current origin-of-life research.

What is a virocell, and what did Patrick Forterre argue?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Forterre's move is to change the unit of analysis. Most arguments ask whether the virion is alive and conclude no. He says you are looking at the wrong object, the way you would be wrong to judge an oak tree by an acorn. Evaluate that: it is a genuinely useful reframing, but it does not resolve whether a virus is alive independently, which is what the original question asked.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This kind of definitional argument comes back in microbiology and origin-of-life research.

What is NASA's definition of life, and why does he use it?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why would NASA deliberately avoid mentioning cells, DNA, or carbon? Because a definition built from Earth life could make them miss life that is chemically different. The cost of that generality is that it admits edge cases: some would argue a self-replicating chemical system in a lab meets it. Being able to name that trade-off is the sophisticated version of this answer.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Astrobiology and origin-of-life research both run on this definition.

Chemistry & Water

What is matter, and what is an element?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why is it CHON specifically, and not any other four elements? Because they are small, they form strong covalent bonds, and they can form multiple bonds, which lets them build stable, complex, varied molecules. Bigger atoms form weaker, longer bonds that break too easily to hold a genome together.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Chem 1A opens with atomic structure and periodicity, which is the formal version of this.

Element vs compound vs molecule. Which one is more inclusive?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Where does a growing organism's mass come from? He put that question on a slide right after this one. For a plant it is mostly carbon pulled from CO₂ in the air, plus water, not from the soil. For you it is the food you eat. In both cases, atoms get rearranged into new compounds; no new matter is made.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Conservation of mass in reactions is the opening of Chem 1A stoichiometry.

Describe the structure of an atom.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Almost all of an atom's mass is in a nucleus that occupies almost none of its volume. If an atom were the size of a football stadium, the nucleus would be a marble at the center. So why does matter feel solid? Because you never touch nuclei, you feel electron shells repelling each other.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Chem 1A will push this into orbitals and quantum numbers. The shell model you are learning now is a simplification you will later replace.

How much does each subatomic particle weigh, and how do you find mass?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Work his other practice set out loud: 11Na, 6C, 8O, each neutral. Sodium has 11 protons and 11 electrons. Carbon has 6 and 6. Oxygen has 8 and 8. Neutrons need the mass number, which is why he gives it separately. If a problem gives only the atomic number, it is asking about protons and electrons, not neutrons.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This is the first calculation in Chem 1A.

How is an element's identity determined? Atomic number vs mass number.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why is the atomic mass on a periodic table a decimal, like 12.011 for carbon, when protons and neutrons are whole numbers? Because it is a weighted average of all naturally occurring isotopes. Carbon is mostly carbon-12 with a small fraction of carbon-13, and averaging them lands just above 12.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

You will use atomic masses constantly in Chem 1A stoichiometry, so knowing why they are decimals helps.

What are isotopes, and why do they matter in medicine?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Carbon-14 dating has a limit of roughly 50,000 years. Why? Because half-life is exponential: after enough half-lives, so little carbon-14 remains that measurement error swamps the signal. Older samples need isotopes with longer half-lives, like potassium-40.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

PET imaging uses a radioactive glucose analog. Tumors consume glucose faster than normal tissue, so they light up. That is an isotope being used as a functional diagnostic, not just a structural image.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Half-life calculations show up in Chem 1A and on the MCAT.

Explain electron shells and the octet rule.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Predict the bonding behavior of oxygen (6 valence electrons), nitrogen (5), and hydrogen (1) without memorizing. Oxygen needs 2 more, so 2 bonds. Nitrogen needs 3, so 3 bonds. Hydrogen needs 1, so 1 bond. Now look at a water molecule, an ammonia molecule, and methane, and notice you could have predicted all three structures.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Lewis structures in Chem 1A are this rule applied systematically.

Draw a Bohr model and count valence electrons.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Sodium has 1 valence electron and chlorine has 7. Predict what happens when they meet without memorizing the answer: sodium loses its one to get to a full shell underneath, chlorine gains one to fill its shell, and the resulting opposite charges attract. That is an ionic bond, derived rather than memorized.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Electron configuration and Lewis structures in Chem 1A.

What is an ion? Cation vs anion, and how does an ionic bond form?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why is the inside of a resting nerve cell negative compared to the outside? Because a pump moves three sodium ions out for every two potassium ions in, and the membrane leaks potassium back out. The result is a charge difference stored across the membrane, ready to be released as a nerve signal. Every thought you have is ions moving.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Electrolyte panels are among the most ordered lab tests in medicine. Abnormal potassium can stop a heart, and abnormal sodium can cause seizures, both because of this same membrane physics.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Membrane potential is a major topic in A&P and in the MCAT biology section.

Covalent bonds: polar vs nonpolar, and what is electronegativity?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Carbon dioxide has two polar C=O bonds, yet the molecule as a whole is nonpolar. Why? Because it is linear and the two bond dipoles point in exactly opposite directions and cancel. Water has two polar bonds too, but it is bent, so they do not cancel. Shape decides molecular polarity, not just bond polarity.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Molecular geometry and VSEPR theory in Chem 1A formalize exactly this.

What is a hydrogen bond, and why does something so weak matter so much?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

A-T pairs share two hydrogen bonds, G-C pairs share three. Predict which region of DNA a cell can unzip more easily, and where you would expect a replication origin to sit. The AT-rich regions, because fewer hydrogen bonds means less energy to separate. Replication origins are in fact AT-rich, and that is not a coincidence.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

PCR, used in everything from infection testing to genetic diagnostics, relies on heating DNA until hydrogen bonds break. GC-rich sequences require higher temperatures, which is why lab protocols specify melting temperatures.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This exact fact underlies DNA replication in genetics and PCR in any molecular lab.

Why is water polar, and what does that cause?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why does ice float, and why does that matter for life? Hydrogen bonds lock water into an open lattice when it freezes, making solid water less dense than liquid. So lakes freeze from the top down, insulating the water below, which lets aquatic life survive winter. If ice sank, bodies of water would freeze solid from the bottom.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Intermolecular forces are a full unit in Chem 1A and explain boiling points, solubility, and phase behavior.

The four properties of water, the way he lists them.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

He showed a map of Southern California: Santa Barbara at 73 degrees on the coast, Palm Springs at 106 inland, on the same day. Explain that gap using heat capacity. The ocean absorbs enormous heat with little temperature change and moderates the air near it. Inland has no such reservoir, so the air heats fast.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

The same property is why body temperature is stable: you are mostly water, so you resist rapid temperature swings.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Thermoregulation in A&P is this property applied to a body.

Hydrophilic vs hydrophobic, and why water is called the universal solvent.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Soap has a charged head and a long nonpolar tail. Explain how that lets it remove grease with water. The tails bury themselves in the grease while the heads face outward into the water, forming a micelle that carries the grease away. Notice this is exactly the phospholipid principle, just with one tail instead of two.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Drug design depends on this constantly. A drug that is too hydrophilic will not cross a cell membrane; one too hydrophobic will not dissolve in blood. Most drugs are engineered compromises.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Membrane transport in A&P and pharmacology both start here.

Acids, bases, and the pH scale.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Stomach acid sits around pH 2 and blood around pH 7.4. That is more than five pH units, which means over 100,000 times the hydrogen ion concentration. How does the stomach avoid digesting itself? Mucus layer, bicarbonate secretion, and rapid cell turnover. When those defenses fail, you get an ulcer.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Arterial blood gas analysis is a core diagnostic test, and it is read almost entirely in terms of pH, bicarbonate, and carbon dioxide.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Acid-base chemistry is a major Chem 1A unit and a heavily tested MCAT topic.

How do you actually calculate pH, [H+] and [OH-]?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Watch the direction, because that is where points get lost. pH going UP means fewer hydrogen ions, so [H+] decreased. pH going DOWN means more acidic and [H+] increased. He explicitly asked 'did the [H+] increase or decrease?' on the review slide, which means direction is graded, not just magnitude.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Arterial blood gas results are read exactly this way: a pH number, then what it implies about hydrogen ion concentration and which buffer system is compensating.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Logarithms and titration curves in Chem 1A.

Strong vs weak acids and bases.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why can you drink vinegar, which is an acid, but not hydrochloric acid at the same concentration? Because acetic acid is weak and only partially dissociates, so the actual hydrogen ion concentration is far lower even at the same molarity. Concentration and strength are two different things, and mixing them up is one of the most common chemistry errors.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Acidosis and alkalosis are managed by understanding which buffer systems are still available. A patient's bicarbonate level tells you how much buffering capacity is left.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Titration curves and pKa in Chem 1A are the mathematical version of this card.

What is a buffer, and why is it crucial?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Someone hyperventilating blows off carbon dioxide. Carbon dioxide combines with water to form carbonic acid, so losing it removes acid, and blood pH rises. That is respiratory alkalosis, and it causes tingling and dizziness. Breathing into a bag works because it puts carbon dioxide back. Trace that chain out loud, it links three chapters at once.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

The bicarbonate buffer system is measured directly in every arterial blood gas, and interpreting it is a daily clinical task.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Buffer calculations and Henderson-Hasselbalch are standard Chem 1A material.

The bicarbonate equation: which way does it shift?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Now run it the other way. Hyperventilating blows off CO₂, which removes the left side of the equation, so the reaction shifts left to replace it, consuming H⁺ and raising pH. That is respiratory alkalosis, and it is why breathing into a bag helps: you put the CO₂ back.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Blood pH outside 7.35 to 7.45 is a medical emergency. His slide showed the scale with death marked at both ends.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Acid-base balance is a major A&P unit.

Why is carbon the backbone of life?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Silicon also has four valence electrons and sits directly below carbon. Why is life not silicon-based? Silicon-silicon bonds are weaker and longer, silicon does not readily form double bonds, and silicon dioxide is a solid rather than a gas, so a silicon-based organism could not exhale its waste. That last point is usually the one people miss.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Organic chemistry is an entire two-semester course built on carbon's bonding behavior.

What are hydrocarbons, and why do they store energy well?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why does fat store roughly 9 calories per gram while carbohydrate stores about 4? Because carbohydrates are already partly oxidized, with oxygen atoms attached throughout, while hydrocarbon chains are fully reduced. There is more energy to release when you oxidize something that has not been oxidized yet. Same reason gasoline is a hydrocarbon.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

This is the metabolic basis for why the body stores long-term energy as fat rather than glycogen. Glycogen also carries water with it; fat does not.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Oxidation states and metabolism connect here in both Chem 1A and biochemistry.

Isomers: structural, cis-trans, and enantiomers.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Thalidomide was sold as a mixture of both enantiomers. One treated morning sickness, the other caused severe birth defects. Even worse, the body converts one into the other, so separating them would not have solved it. Explain why a cell can tell them apart at all: receptors and enzymes have three-dimensional binding sites, so only one handedness fits, exactly like a glove.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Modern drug development requires testing single enantiomers separately, and this tragedy is the direct reason that regulation exists.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Stereochemistry is a major organic chemistry topic and a recurring MCAT theme.

Cis-trans isomers: how are they different from structural isomers?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Vision starts with a cis-trans isomerization. Light hits retinal in your eye and flips it from the cis form to the trans form, which changes the shape of the attached protein and fires a signal to your brain. A single double bond changing sides is the first physical step in seeing anything.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Trans fats were banned from the US food supply because of their effect on cholesterol, a regulatory decision made entirely on the basis of molecular geometry.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Alkene geometry is early organic chemistry material.

Name all seven functional groups and what each one does.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

An amino acid has both a carboxyl group, which donates H+, and an amino group, which accepts it. At physiological pH, what happens? Both ionize at once: the carboxyl loses its hydrogen and goes negative, the amino gains one and goes positive. The molecule carries both charges simultaneously, which is called a zwitterion, and it is why amino acids are so soluble.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Drug behavior in the body is largely predicted by functional groups, since they determine solubility, charge at blood pH, and which enzymes can process the molecule.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Organic chemistry is organized entirely around functional groups. Learning them now is a genuine head start.

Carbon & Macromolecules

What are the four classes of biological macromolecules, and what are their monomers?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Rank the four by how much energy each stores per gram and explain the ranking. Lipids are highest at about 9 calories per gram because their hydrocarbon chains are fully reduced. Carbohydrates and proteins are both around 4. Nucleic acids are not used for energy at all, because their job is information, and burning your own instructions would be a design flaw.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Biochemistry devotes a unit to each of these four.

Dehydration synthesis vs hydrolysis.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Every digestive enzyme you have is a hydrolase, meaning it performs hydrolysis. Amylase hydrolyzes starch, lipase hydrolyzes fat, protease hydrolyzes protein. Explain why digestion has to be hydrolysis and not something else: polymers are too large to cross a membrane, so they must be cut back into monomers, and water is the tool that cuts.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Pancreatic insufficiency is diagnosed partly by undigested fat in stool, which is hydrolysis failing at the organ level.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Enzyme kinetics in biochemistry begins with reactions exactly like these.

What are carbohydrates, and what is the general formula?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Deoxyribose is C5H10O4. Does it fit the 1:2:1 rule? No, it is one oxygen short, which is exactly what deoxy means. So is it still a carbohydrate? Yes. The formula is a generalization, not a law, and modified sugars break it routinely.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

You will meet many modified sugars in biochemistry, and almost none follow the ratio exactly.

Monosaccharides: name three and why they matter.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why does the body convert almost everything to glucose specifically, rather than running on fructose or galactose? Because glycolysis, the central energy pathway, takes glucose as its input, so every other sugar gets converted in the liver first. That conversion step is why fructose is metabolized differently and why high fructose intake stresses the liver.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Blood glucose, not blood sugar in general, is what gets measured in diabetes, and this is why.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Glycolysis is one of the first pathways you memorize in biochemistry.

Aldose vs ketose.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Glucose and fructose are both C6H12O6, so why is fructose noticeably sweeter? Sweetness comes from how the molecule fits taste receptors on your tongue, and the ketose arrangement fits better. Same atoms, different shape, different receptor fit, different perception. It is the structure-function principle showing up in something you can taste.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Sugar chemistry and ring formation are early biochemistry topics.

How do disaccharides form? Name three.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Lactose intolerance is extremely common worldwide, and the ability to digest lactose as an adult is the unusual trait, not the other way around. It evolved separately in populations with a long history of dairy farming. Explain what that is an example of: natural selection acting on a digestive enzyme within human history.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Lactose intolerance is diagnosed by a hydrogen breath test, because undigested lactose gets fermented by gut bacteria which produce hydrogen gas.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This is a standard example in genetics for recent human evolution.

Starch, glycogen, and cellulose: compare structure and function.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Cows cannot digest cellulose either. So how do they live on grass? Symbiotic microbes in their rumen produce cellulase and break it down for them, and the cow absorbs the products. Termites do the same thing. The lesson: the enzyme is what is missing, not the ability to use the energy.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Gut microbiome composition affects how much energy a person extracts from the same food, and it is an active research area in metabolic disease.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Microbiome work is one of the fastest growing areas in medical research.

Chitin and the other structural polysaccharides.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Fungi have chitin cell walls, while human cells have no cell wall at all. Why is that useful for treating fungal infections? Because a drug that attacks chitin synthesis has no human target to damage. Selective toxicity, the principle of hitting something the pathogen has and you do not, is the basis of nearly every antimicrobial.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Antifungal drugs are harder to design than antibacterials precisely because fungi are eukaryotes like us, so there are fewer unique targets.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Selective toxicity is a core principle in microbiology and pharmacology.

What defines a lipid, and what do lipids do?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Vitamins A, D, E, and K are lipids, which means they are stored in body fat rather than excreted in urine. What is the clinical consequence? Fat-soluble vitamins can accumulate to toxic levels if over-supplemented, while excess water-soluble vitamins mostly get urinated out. Solubility decides the toxicity risk.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Vitamin D deficiency is one of the most commonly measured lab values, and fat malabsorption disorders cause deficiency in all four at once.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Nutrition and pharmacokinetics both organize around this distinction.

Structure of a triglyceride, and saturated vs unsaturated.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Trans fats are worse for you than saturated fats, even though both are straight chains. Why? They raise LDL like saturated fat does, but they also lower HDL, which saturated fat does not. The body also has no enzyme that evolved to handle a trans double bond, because they barely exist in nature.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

A lipid panel measuring LDL, HDL, and triglycerides is one of the most ordered blood tests in medicine, and everything on it traces back to this card.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Lipid metabolism is a full biochemistry unit.

Structure of a phospholipid, and why it forms membranes.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Membranes need to stay fluid, not freeze into a solid sheet. Two things keep them fluid: unsaturated tails with kinks that prevent tight packing, and cholesterol wedged between them. Fish living in cold water have more unsaturated tails in their membranes than tropical fish. Predict why, then check: colder environment, more kinks needed to stay fluid.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Membrane fluidity affects how drugs cross into cells and how cells signal, and it changes measurably in some disease states.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Fluid mosaic model and membrane transport are the opening chapters of cell biology.

What makes steroids structurally different, and why are they still lipids?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Steroid hormones pass straight through the membrane and bind receptors inside the cell, which means they change gene expression. Protein hormones like insulin cannot cross, so they bind surface receptors and trigger a relay inside. Predict which type acts faster and which lasts longer: protein hormones act in seconds, steroid hormones take hours but the effects persist.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

This is why corticosteroid treatment takes time to work and why stopping it abruptly is dangerous, since the body has adjusted its own production.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Endocrinology in A&P is built on exactly this two-pathway distinction.

List the functions of proteins.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

One gene mutation, one changed amino acid, one misshapen protein, one disease. Sickle cell anemia is exactly that: a single base change swaps glutamic acid for valine in hemoglobin, the protein clumps, and red blood cells distort into a sickle shape that blocks capillaries. Trace the whole chain from DNA to symptom out loud.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Hemoglobin electrophoresis, a lab technique that separates proteins by charge, is the standard diagnostic for sickle cell. It works because that one amino acid change alters the protein's charge.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This example appears in genetics, biochemistry, hematology, and on the MCAT.

Structure of an amino acid, and how peptide bonds form.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

R groups sort into nonpolar, polar, acidic, and basic. Predict where each type ends up in a folded protein sitting in water: nonpolar R groups get buried in the interior away from water, polar and charged ones face outward. That single prediction explains most of tertiary structure, and it is the hydrophobic effect again.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Protein misfolding causes Alzheimer's, Parkinson's, and prion disease, all of which are diagnosed by pathologists identifying characteristic protein deposits in tissue.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

You will memorize all 20 R groups in biochemistry. Learning the four categories now makes that far easier.

The four levels of protein structure.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Which level does a mutation change directly, and which level actually causes the disease? A mutation changes primary structure, the sequence. But the disease comes from the tertiary structure being wrong, because that is what determines shape and therefore function. Primary determines tertiary, so changing one changes the other, but they are not the same level.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Immunohistochemistry, a foundational pathology technique, uses antibodies that recognize the three-dimensional shape of specific proteins in tissue. If the protein is misfolded or absent, the stain shows it.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Protein folding is a major biochemistry unit and a large open research problem.

What is denaturation, and is it reversible?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why is a fever above roughly 104 F dangerous, but a fever of 101 F is useful? Mild fever speeds immune response and slows pathogen growth. High fever begins to denature your own enzymes, and once enzymes lose their shape the reactions they catalyze stop. Above about 106 F, protein damage becomes widespread and irreversible.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Formalin fixation, which is the first step for nearly every tissue sample that reaches a pathology lab, works by cross-linking proteins to lock structure in place before it degrades. It is controlled denaturation used deliberately.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Enzyme activity and optimal conditions are standard biochemistry material.

What are nucleic acids and nucleotides?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

ATP is a nucleotide. It is adenine, ribose, and three phosphates instead of one. So the energy currency of every cell is structurally an RNA building block with extra phosphates. Explain where the energy is: in the repulsion between those clustered negative phosphates, which is released when one is broken off.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Many chemotherapy drugs are nucleotide analogs. They resemble real nucleotides closely enough to get incorporated into DNA, then stop replication, which kills fast-dividing cells.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

ATP appears in literally every metabolism chapter you will ever read.

Purines vs pyrimidines.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Gout is caused by uric acid crystals in joints, and uric acid is the breakdown product of purines specifically, not pyrimidines. That is why gout diets restrict organ meats and shellfish, which are purine-rich. A chemistry distinction you are learning for an exam turns out to explain a dietary restriction.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Joint fluid aspiration examined under polarized light for needle-shaped urate crystals is the definitive gout diagnosis, and it is done in the lab.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Nucleotide metabolism is a biochemistry unit, and gout is its standard clinical example.

Describe DNA's double helix and complementary base pairing.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Antiparallel means the two strands run in opposite directions, 5 prime to 3 prime on one and the reverse on the other. Why does that complicate replication? Because DNA polymerase can only build in one direction, so one strand is made continuously and the other in backwards fragments that get stitched together. That awkwardness is a direct consequence of antiparallel structure.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Understanding strand directionality is required for reading any sequencing result, and sequencing is now routine in cancer diagnosis.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Replication, transcription, and PCR all depend on this in genetics.

DNA vs RNA, and the three types of RNA.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

RNA has an extra hydroxyl group on its sugar that DNA lacks, and it makes RNA more chemically reactive and less stable. Why would the cell want its long-term storage molecule to be the stable one and its messenger to be the unstable one? Because messages should expire. If mRNA lasted forever, the cell could never stop making a protein it no longer needs.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

mRNA vaccines exploit this instability deliberately. The mRNA delivers instructions, gets translated, and degrades within days, which is why it cannot alter your genome.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Transcription and translation are the central topics of any genetics course.

Cells

What is the cell theory, and who gets credit?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Virchow's addition killed spontaneous generation, the idea that life arises from non-living matter. Explain why 'cells come only from pre-existing cells' was such a big deal: it means every cell in your body traces back in an unbroken line of division to the first cells, billions of years ago. No gaps.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Cancer is cell division escaping control. A pathologist diagnoses it largely by looking at how cells are dividing and how abnormal the dividing cells look.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Cell division is a whole unit later in this course and in every biology course after it.

Prokaryotic vs eukaryotic cells.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Prokaryotes are far more numerous and metabolically diverse than eukaryotes, and they were here billions of years first. So why did eukaryotic complexity evolve at all? Compartmentalization: internal membranes let a cell run incompatible reactions at the same time in separate spaces, and give far more membrane surface area for metabolism.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Gram staining, which separates bacteria by cell wall structure, is one of the oldest and still most used tests in clinical microbiology.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Microbiology is essentially a course about prokaryotes.

Lab 4: what do you identify in each specimen?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Frog red blood cells have a nucleus. Human red blood cells do not. Why would a cell give up its nucleus? More room for hemoglobin and a flexible shape for squeezing through capillaries. The trade is that human red cells cannot repair themselves and live only about 120 days.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

A blood smear read under a microscope is one of the most common pathology tests there is, and recognizing normal cell morphology is the whole skill.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Histology is this lab, for two years.

The nucleus and ribosomes: what does each do?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

mRNA is made in the nucleus but proteins are made in the cytoplasm, so something has to cross. That is what the pores are for. Explain why keeping DNA inside a separate compartment is worth the trouble: it protects the original and lets the cell regulate which genes get read.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Pathologists assess the nucleus constantly. An enlarged, irregular, darkly staining nucleus is one of the classic signs of a malignant cell.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Transcription and translation are the core of genetics.

Trace a protein through the endomembrane system.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Rough ER has ribosomes, smooth ER does not, and they do different jobs. Rough ER makes secretory and membrane proteins. Smooth ER makes lipids, detoxifies drugs, and stores calcium. Predict which one is abundant in a liver cell, and why: smooth ER, because the liver detoxifies.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Cystic fibrosis is often a protein folding failure in the ER. The CFTR protein is made but misfolds, so quality control destroys it before it ever reaches the membrane.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Protein trafficking is a major cell biology topic.

Mitochondria, chloroplasts, lysosomes and the rest.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Both mitochondria and chloroplasts have heavily folded internal membranes: cristae in mitochondria, thylakoid stacks in chloroplasts. Why the same design solution in two unrelated organelles? Both run membrane-bound reactions, so more membrane area means more reactions at once. Structure relates to function, one of his six themes.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Lysosomal storage diseases like Tay-Sachs happen when one lysosomal enzyme is missing and its substrate builds up inside cells until they fail.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Cellular respiration and photosynthesis are each a full unit later this semester.

What is endosymbiosis, and what is the evidence?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why does the double membrane specifically support engulfment? Because when one cell swallows another, the inner membrane is the bacterium's own and the outer one is the vesicle the host wrapped around it. Two membranes are exactly what you would predict from that event, and that is what we find.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Mitochondrial DNA is maternally inherited and mutates quickly, making it useful in both inherited disease diagnosis and forensic identification.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Endosymbiosis is a cornerstone example in evolution courses.

What does the cytoskeleton do?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Many chemotherapy drugs target microtubules, either preventing them from assembling or preventing them from coming apart. Why does that kill cancer cells preferentially? Because the mitotic spindle is made of microtubules, so cells that divide frequently are hit hardest. That is also why chemo damages hair follicles and gut lining, which also divide fast.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Loss of normal cell shape and polarity, both cytoskeletal, is a feature pathologists look for in tumor tissue.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

The spindle is central to mitosis and meiosis.

What are the three main functions of a cell?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Notice this list maps onto his six course themes. Building molecules is information flow, DNA to protein. Transforming energy and matter is its own theme. Dividing is how information gets transmitted. Linking a lecture detail back to a course theme is how you show depth on an exam.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Metabolism and cell division are the next two units.

Tutoring & Practice Exam

Name three characteristics that life and viruses SHARE.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

The trap is 'reproduce.' A virus does produce progeny, but not independently. If you list it, add the qualifier out loud, because a grader looking for precision will want it.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

The same framing returns in microbiology.

What is entropy, and how does it relate to energy in living systems?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

This links directly to his 'energy and matter transformation' theme. Matter cycles because atoms are conserved and reused. Energy flows one way because at every transfer some is lost as heat and cannot be reused. Say both halves of that sentence and you have answered several exam questions at once.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Thermodynamics is the foundation of metabolism.

Null hypothesis vs alternate hypothesis.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why set up a null at all, instead of just testing your idea? Because it forces a falsifiable target. You cannot prove a positive claim outright, but you can show that a no-effect result is unlikely given your data. The whole structure of statistics rests on this.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Every statistics course opens here, and every paper you read reports it.

What are the components of experimental design?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

The worksheet asks for 'a control sample' specifically. Careful: a controlled variable is a condition you keep identical everywhere; a control group or sample is the group that gets no experimental treatment. Both words appear on the sheet and they are not the same thing.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This is the structure of every clinical trial.

Turning data into a law, then into a theory.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Look at the data table: pH 6.6 gives 53.3 cm and pH 6.8 also gives 53.3 cm, while 6.0 gives 25.4 and 7.2 gives 22.9. That is a peak with a falloff on both sides, not a straight line. Describing the shape correctly, rather than saying 'higher pH means more growth,' is what makes it a good law.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Enzyme optimum curves look exactly like this, and they come back in every biochemistry chapter.

How do you read nuclide notation and draw the atom?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Sodium with a plus charge has 10 electrons, the same as neon. That is exactly why it forms: losing one electron gives it a full outer shell. The ion is stable because it now matches a noble gas configuration.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Ion formation and electron configuration in Chem 1A.

Isotope, ion, different element: what varies in each?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Notice what each change does and does not affect. Change neutrons and you change mass but not chemistry. Change electrons and you change charge and reactivity but not identity. Change protons and you have a different substance entirely. Protons are the only one that changes what the thing IS.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This distinction never stops mattering.

Functional groups by their properties, the way the worksheet asks.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Notice the sheet asks about carbonyl twice, once for ketones in the middle of the chain and once for aldehydes at the end. Same functional group, two names depending on position, and molecules with each are structural isomers of one another.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Drug behavior in the body is largely predicted from functional groups: solubility, charge at blood pH, and which enzymes can act on it.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Organic chemistry is organized entirely around these.

How do you write a complementary DNA strand?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Antiparallel is not decoration. DNA polymerase can only build in one direction, which is why replication produces one continuous strand and one made in fragments. The direction labels on your answer are the same fact that makes replication complicated.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Every sequencing result and every PCR primer is written with direction labels for this exact reason.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Replication, transcription and PCR in genetics.

What is the flow of genetic information in a eukaryotic cell?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

His Chapter 1 slide showed this with a lens cell: the crystallin gene is transcribed, translated, and folded into crystallin protein, which makes the lens transparent. That is information flow and structure-function in one example, two of his six themes.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

This is the central dogma, and it is the spine of genetics.

Polypeptide vs protein, and which level survives hydrogen bond disruption?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

This is also the definition of denaturation: hydrogen bonds and other weak interactions break, so secondary, tertiary and quaternary structure unravel, but peptide bonds hold, so the sequence survives. That is why the correct answer to 'what does denaturation entail' is the unfolding of a protein, not the breaking of peptide bonds.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Formalin fixation deliberately crosslinks proteins to lock structure before tissue degrades.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Protein folding is a full biochemistry unit.

Amylase can only break alpha glucose linkages. What can it digest?

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Notice how the question is built. It gives you a rule, alpha only, and asks you to apply it to a list. That is the format to expect: not 'define amylase' but 'here is a rule, now use it.' Learn the alpha and beta assignment for every polysaccharide and any version of this question is answerable.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Salivary amylase is why bread starts tasting sweet if you chew it long enough.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Enzyme specificity in biochemistry.

Label the blood glucose regulation diagram.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

This is homeostasis, negative feedback, and glycogen all in one diagram, so it can be asked from several angles. Type 1 diabetes is failure to produce insulin; type 2 is cells no longer responding to it. Either way blood glucose stays high because the storage signal is not working.

WHY IT MATTERS IN PATHOLOGY

Blood glucose and HbA1c are among the most ordered lab tests in medicine.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Endocrinology in A&P is built on paired opposing hormones like these.

Prokaryote vs eukaryote: the Venn diagram and the tricky ones.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Why do prokaryotes need to be small? Surface area to volume ratio. A cell relies on diffusion to move materials, and as a cell grows, volume outpaces surface area, so diffusion can no longer supply the interior. Eukaryotes get around it with internal membranes, which is exactly why compartmentalization matters.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Surface area to volume returns in cell biology and in physiology.

Fill the macromolecule table: monomer, polymer, function.

A HARDER VERSION OF THIS QUESTION

Notice the study guide says 'the SPECIFIC monomer for cellulose.' The general answer is monosaccharide; the specific answer is beta glucose. Same for its function: the general answer is structure, the specific one is the plant cell wall. When a question says specific, it is telling you the general answer will not earn full credit.

WHAT IT SETS UP LATER

Biochemistry devotes a unit to each row.

Practice questions

131 multiple choice · answer key at the back

1. A researcher tests three fertilizer doses on basil and measures final plant height. What is the dependent variable?
 - a) Fertilizer dose
 - b) Plant height
 - c) Type of soil
 - d) The basil variety
2. Which statement about a scientific theory is correct?
 - a) It is an educated guess that has not yet been tested by experiment
 - b) It is promoted to the status of a law once enough evidence accumulates
 - c) It is a broad explanation supported by many independent lines of evidence
 - d) It is a fixed conclusion that cannot be revised by later evidence
3. Which is NOT a requirement of a scientific hypothesis?
 - a) It must be testable
 - b) It must be falsifiable
 - c) It must turn out to be correct
 - d) It should be based on prior observation
4. The control group in an experiment exists in order to:
 - a) Increase the total sample size so the results are more reliable
 - b) Provide an untreated baseline that the treated groups are compared against
 - c) Hold every other condition constant across all of the treatment groups
 - d) Confirm that the researcher's original hypothesis was correct
5. On a standard scientific graph, the independent variable belongs on:
 - a) The y-axis
 - b) The x-axis
 - c) Either, it makes no difference
 - d) The legend
6. Which is the correct order, smallest to largest?
 - a) Cell, organelle, tissue, organ
 - b) Organelle, cell, tissue, organ
 - c) Tissue, cell, organ, organelle
 - d) Molecule, cell, organelle, tissue
7. A single neuron cannot store a memory, but a network of neurons can. This is an example of:
 - a) Reductionism
 - b) Homeostasis
 - c) Emergence
 - d) Natural selection
8. Which is the strongest argument that a virus is NOT alive?
 - a) It is far smaller than any known cell, only 20 to 500 nanometers
 - b) It cannot reproduce or metabolize without hijacking a host cell's machinery
 - c) It causes disease in the organism that it happens to infect
 - d) It may carry RNA as its genome rather than double-stranded DNA
9. Sweating when body temperature rises is an example of:
 - a) Emergence
 - b) Homeostasis
 - c) Reductionism
 - d) Metabolism only
0. Which statement about natural selection is accurate?
 - a) Individual organisms evolve during their lifetime to meet a new need
 - b) Populations change over generations as helpful heritable traits become common
 - c) Organisms develop new traits on demand because the environment requires them
 - d) Selection generates brand new variation that was not present beforehand
1. Why is the cell considered the fundamental unit of life?
 - a) It is the smallest biological structure that is visible under a light microscope
 - b) It is the smallest unit that independently shows all characteristics of life
 - c) It is the only structure in the body that contains genetic material
 - d) It is present in every known organism, viruses included

2. An atom has 6 protons, 8 neutrons, and 6 electrons. It is:
 - a) An ion of carbon
 - b) An isotope of carbon
 - c) An ion of oxygen
 - d) An isotope of nitrogen
3. An ionic bond forms when:
 - a) Two atoms share one or more pairs of electrons more or less equally
 - b) Two atoms share electrons unequally, producing partial charges on each
 - c) One atom transfers electrons to another and the opposite charges attract
 - d) A hydrogen already bonded to oxygen is weakly attracted to a nearby atom
4. Water is a polar molecule because:
 - a) It contains hydrogen atoms, and hydrogen is always a polar element
 - b) Oxygen pulls the shared electrons harder and the molecule is bent
 - c) It dissolves salts and other charged substances very effectively
 - d) It forms hydrogen bonds with the water molecules around it
5. Sweating cools you down because water has:
 - a) High heat capacity
 - b) High heat of vaporization
 - c) Strong cohesion
 - d) Solvent properties
6. A solution at pH 4 compared to a solution at pH 6 is:
 - a) 2 times more acidic
 - b) 10 times more acidic
 - c) 100 times more acidic
 - d) 2 times more basic
7. Which functional group makes a molecule acidic?
 - a) Amino, -NH₂
 - b) Carboxyl, -COOH
 - c) Hydroxyl, -OH
 - d) Methyl, -CH₃
8. Carbon forms the backbone of organic molecules because it:
 - a) Is the single most abundant element by mass in the Earth's crust
 - b) Has four valence electrons and forms four stable covalent bonds
 - c) Is the heaviest of the four major elements found in living things
 - d) Gives up its outer electrons easily and forms strong ionic bonds
9. Hydrogen bonds are essential in biology despite being weak because:
 - a) Individually they are in fact stronger than a covalent bond is
 - b) Large numbers together stabilize structures, and their weakness lets DNA unzip
 - c) They are permanent and never break once they have formed in a molecule
 - d) They transfer electrons completely from one atom over to another
10. Two molecules share the formula C₆H₁₂O₆ but have different structures. They are:
 - a) Isotopes
 - b) Ions
 - c) Isomers
 - d) Polymers
1. Two monomers join and a water molecule is released. This is:
 - a) Hydrolysis, where water is added in order to split a bond
 - b) Dehydration synthesis, where water is removed to form a bond
 - c) Denaturation, where a folded molecule loses its shape
 - d) Dissociation, where an ionic compound separates into ions
2. Humans cannot digest cellulose because:
 - a) The molecule is simply too large to fit into any human enzyme
 - b) We lack the enzyme needed to break its beta glycosidic bonds
 - c) It is built from a sugar other than glucose that we cannot use
 - d) It is classified as a lipid and passes through undigested
3. Glycogen is more heavily branched than starch because:
 - a) Animals need rapid glucose release and branches give enzymes more ends
 - b) Plants lack the enzymes required to form branch points at all
 - c) Glycogen is built from beta glucose, which forces branching
 - d) The branches make the molecule waterproof inside the cell

4. Butter is solid at room temperature because its fatty acids:
 - a) Contain many double bonds that put permanent kinks in the chains
 - b) Contain no double bonds, so the chains stay straight and pack tightly
 - c) Carry charged groups that make them interact strongly with water
 - d) Are considerably shorter than the fatty acid chains found in oils
5. Phospholipids form a bilayer in water because they are:
 - a) Entirely hydrophobic, so the whole molecule avoids contact with water
 - b) Entirely hydrophilic, so the whole molecule is drawn toward water
 - c) Amphipathic, with a hydrophilic head and two hydrophobic tails
 - d) Positively charged, so they are attracted to negative ions in solution
6. Which level of protein structure do alpha helices and beta pleated sheets represent?
 - a) Primary
 - b) Secondary
 - c) Tertiary
 - d) Quaternary
7. When an egg is fried, the protein is denatured. What is preserved?
 - a) Tertiary structure
 - b) Quaternary structure
 - c) Primary structure
 - d) Its biological function
8. Which base pairing is correct in DNA?
 - a) A with G, C with T
 - b) A with T, G with C
 - c) A with U, G with C
 - d) A with C, T with G
9. Which is true of RNA but not DNA?
 - a) It contains phosphate groups linking the sugars of its backbone
 - b) It contains uracil and ribose and is usually single stranded
 - c) It is arranged as two antiparallel strands in a double helix
 - d) It contains adenine as one of its four nitrogenous bases
0. Which macromolecule class is NOT a true polymer?
 - a) Carbohydrates
 - b) Lipids
 - c) Proteins
 - d) Nucleic acids
1. Which structure do ALL viruses have?
 - a) An envelope of lipid membrane taken from the host cell
 - b) Glycoprotein spikes projecting outward from the surface
 - c) A capsid of protein surrounding a nucleic acid genome
 - d) Ribosomes for translating their own genome into protein
2. A viral envelope is made of:
 - a) Protein subunits called capsomeres made by the virus itself
 - b) Lipid membrane taken from the host cell as the virus exits
 - c) Carbohydrate chains assembled on the surface of the capsid
 - d) Nucleic acid wrapped protectively around the outer surface
3. Viruses infect only specific host cells because:
 - a) They can only survive within a narrow range of temperatures
 - b) Their attachment proteins must physically match a host receptor
 - c) They are able to infect only cells already weakened by illness
 - d) They are physically too large to enter most types of cell
4. Which step of viral replication is impossible without a host cell?
 - a) Attachment of the spike proteins to a surface receptor
 - b) Replication of the genome and synthesis of viral proteins
 - c) Existing as an intact particle outside of any living cell
 - d) Being detected and identified under an electron microscope
5. RNA viruses mutate rapidly primarily because:
 - a) They replicate far more slowly than DNA viruses do
 - b) Their polymerase has no proofreading, so errors are kept
 - c) Their genomes are much larger, leaving more room for error
 - d) Their envelopes are unstable and change shape frequently

6. You measured heart rate at rest, 1, 3 and 5 minutes into exercise. Which graph fits best?
- Bar graph, because there are four groups
 - Line graph, because time is continuous
 - Pie chart, to show proportions
 - Scatter plot, because there are two variables
7. Which is the clearest sign a graph is being used to mislead?
- It carries a descriptive title above the plotted data
 - The y-axis begins partway up instead of starting at zero
 - It includes error bars showing variation within each group
 - It labels both axes together with the units of measurement
8. Why must a buffer be made from a weak acid rather than a strong one?
- Weak acids are safer to handle and store in a laboratory
 - A weak acid only partly dissociates, so it can take H^+ back
 - Strong acids are considerably more expensive to purchase
 - Weak acids maintain a higher starting pH than strong ones
9. Vinegar and hydrochloric acid at the same concentration differ because:
- Vinegar contains no hydrogen ions at all when it is dissolved
 - Acetic acid is weak and only partly dissociates, releasing fewer H^+
 - Vinegar acts as a base and accepts hydrogen ions from solution
 - Hydrochloric acid is always sold at a much lower concentration
10. Cis and trans isomers are different molecules because:
- They are built from entirely different atoms and elements
 - A carbon-carbon double bond cannot rotate, locking each form
 - They have different molecular formulas despite similar names
 - One carries a net electrical charge while the other does not
1. Which ion pair is responsible for generating a nerve signal?
- Calcium and chloride
 - Sodium and potassium
 - Magnesium and iron
 - Hydrogen and hydroxide
2. Which statement about purines and pyrimidines is correct?
- Purines have one ring; adenine and guanine are purines
 - Purines have two rings; adenine and guanine are purines
 - Pyrimidines have two rings; cytosine and thymine are pyrimidines
 - All four DNA bases are purines
3. Chitin differs from cellulose mainly because chitin:
- Is built with alpha linkages that let the chain coil up
 - Contains a nitrogen-bearing group added onto the glucose
 - Functions as a storage polysaccharide rather than structure
 - Is assembled from fructose rather than from glucose units
4. Which is the best description of what biology studies?
- Only animals and plants, the organisms visible to the eye
 - Life at every level, from molecules in cells to ecosystems
 - Only organisms small enough to require a microscope to see
 - The chemistry of substances as studied in a laboratory
5. Which statement about the scientific process is most accurate?
- It always runs in one fixed order and ends with a final conclusion
 - It loops, and results often send you back to revise hypothesis or method
 - Observation always comes first, before any hypothesis can be formed
 - Peer review happens only once, at the very end of the whole process
6. A supplement study reports 8 of 10 people felt more energetic after a week. The biggest problem is:
- The sample of ten people is slightly smaller than ideal
 - There is no control group, no blinding, and self-reported results
 - A bar graph would have displayed the findings more clearly
 - One week is far too long a period to measure energy levels
7. What does peer review NOT reliably catch?
- Flawed reasoning
 - Unclear methods
 - Fabricated data
 - Overstated conclusions

8. Researchers studying how bacteria defend against viruses accidentally enabled CRISPR gene editing. This shows:

- a) Applied science produces more valuable results than basic science
- b) Basic research can produce applications nobody could have predicted
- c) Research into bacterial defenses is a poor use of public money
- d) Gene editing had been the goal of that research from the start

9. Fire grows, consumes fuel, produces waste and spreads. Why is it not alive?

- a) It moves and spreads much faster than any living organism does
- b) It is not cellular, has no genetic material, and no homeostasis
- c) It produces heat rather than storing energy for later use
- d) It occurs only where humans have deliberately started it

0. Studying the structure of DNA to explain how traits are inherited is an example of:

- a) Emergence
- b) Reductionism
- c) Homeostasis
- d) Natural selection

1. A cell packed with mitochondria and a heavily folded membrane most likely:

- a) Performs very little work and has low energy requirements
- b) Performs energy-expensive transport, like a kidney tubule cell
- c) Has died recently, since damaged cells accumulate mitochondria
- d) Functions mainly to store fat for the organism's later use

2. Why do carbon, hydrogen, oxygen and nitrogen make up about 96% of living matter?

- a) They are the four most abundant elements in the Earth's crust
- b) They are small and form strong, stable, often multiple bonds
- c) They are the four lightest elements on the periodic table
- d) They are all metals, which makes them highly reactive

3. Which statement about atomic structure is correct?

- a) Protons carry a negative charge and electrons a positive one
- b) Nearly all mass sits in the nucleus, nearly all volume in shells
- c) Neutrons carry a positive charge equal to that of a proton
- d) Electrons are packed inside the nucleus alongside the protons

4. Why is carbon's atomic mass listed as 12.011 rather than a whole number?

- a) It is a rounding artifact left over from older measurements
- b) It is a weighted average across naturally occurring isotopes
- c) Electrons contribute a small fractional amount to the mass
- d) Carbon nuclei contain one partial proton in addition to six

5. Nitrogen has 5 valence electrons. How many covalent bonds will it form?

- a) 1
- b) 2
- c) 3
- d) 5

6. Carbon dioxide has two polar bonds but is a nonpolar molecule. Why?

- a) Its carbon-oxygen bonds are actually nonpolar to begin with
- b) It is linear, so the two bond dipoles point opposite and cancel
- c) Carbon has such low electronegativity that no dipole forms
- d) It contains no oxygen atoms in the arrangement being described

7. Oil separates from water because:

- a) Oil molecules are considerably heavier than water molecules
- b) Oil is nonpolar, so water molecules exclude it and it clumps
- c) Oil carries a positive charge that repels the water molecules
- d) Oil evaporates much faster than the surrounding water does

8. A buffer resists pH change because it:

- a) Permanently neutralizes every acid that is added to it
- b) Contains a weak acid and its conjugate base, so H^+ moves both ways
- c) Removes all hydrogen ions from the solution entirely
- d) Forces the solution back to exactly pH 7 every time

9. Fat stores about 9 calories per gram while carbohydrate stores about 4 because:

- a) Fat molecules are physically larger than carbohydrate molecules
- b) Hydrocarbon chains are fully reduced, so oxidation releases more
- c) Carbohydrates cannot be fully digested and absorbed by the body
- d) Fat contains a greater proportion of oxygen atoms per gram

0. Which formula fits the general carbohydrate ratio?
- a) $C_6H_{12}O_6$
 - b) $C_6H_{14}O_2$
 - c) C_2H_6O
 - d) $C_5H_5N_5$
1. Why does the body convert fructose and galactose into glucose?
- a) The other sugars are mildly toxic if they circulate in blood
 - b) Glycolysis, the central energy pathway, takes glucose as input
 - c) The other sugars taste too sweet to be used as cellular fuel
 - d) The other sugars are not soluble enough to travel in blood
2. Fructose is classified as a ketose because its carbonyl group sits:
- a) At the end of the chain
 - b) In the middle of the chain
 - c) On a side branch
 - d) Outside the molecule
3. Lactose intolerance happens because a person lacks:
- a) Lactose, the disaccharide found in milk and dairy products
 - b) Lactase, the enzyme that hydrolyzes the bond within lactose
 - c) Glucose, one of the two monosaccharides that make up lactose
 - d) Stomach acid, which is required to break down milk sugars
4. What do all lipids have in common?
- a) They are all assembled from the same repeating monomer unit
 - b) They are hydrophobic and do not dissolve readily in water
 - c) They all contain a glycerol backbone with fatty acids attached
 - d) They all serve primarily as long-term energy storage molecules
5. Steroid hormones can enter a cell directly because they are:
- a) Extremely small, far smaller than any other signaling molecule
 - b) Nonpolar, so they pass through the hydrophobic membrane interior
 - c) Positively charged, so the negative membrane attracts them in
 - d) Built from protein, which the membrane transports automatically
6. Which of these is NOT a typical protein function?
- a) Catalyzing chemical reactions in the role of an enzyme
 - b) Providing structural support, as collagen does in tissue
 - c) Storing genetic information across generations long term
 - d) Transporting oxygen through the blood, as hemoglobin does
7. What makes one amino acid different from another?
- a) The amino group attached to the central alpha carbon
 - b) The carboxyl group attached to the central alpha carbon
 - c) The R group, the variable side chain on that same carbon
 - d) The central alpha carbon itself, which differs in each one
8. A nucleotide is made of:
- a) A phosphate group, a five-carbon sugar, and a nitrogenous base
 - b) Two five-carbon sugars joined to a single nitrogenous base
 - c) An amino group and a carboxyl group on a central carbon
 - d) A glycerol backbone with two fatty acid chains attached
9. Which of these is NOT one of the six organizing concepts of the course?
- a) Structure relates to function
 - b) Organization and emergence
 - c) Memorization and recall
 - d) Energy and matter transformation
0. Evolution is called biology's unifying theme because it accounts for:
- a) Only the diversity of life
 - b) Only the similarities between organisms
 - c) Both the unity and the diversity of life
 - d) The origin of the universe
1. Which list matches the properties of life as presented in lecture?
- a) Order, regulation, growth, energy processing, response, reproduction, evolution
 - b) Motion, size, color, weight, shape, sound, and age of the object
 - c) Cells, tissues, organs, organ systems, organisms, and populations
 - d) Observation, question, hypothesis, experiment, analysis, conclusion

2. NASA defines life as:
- a) Any system that is constructed from one or more living cells
 - b) A self-sustained chemical system capable of Darwinian evolution
 - c) Any object capable of moving itself without an outside force
 - d) Any chemical system that contains and replicates its own DNA
3. A single virus particle is called a:
- a) Capsomere
 - b) Virion
 - c) Virocell
 - d) Capsid
4. The capsid of a virus is built from repeating protein subunits called:
- a) Glycoproteins
 - b) Capsomeres
 - c) Nucleotides
 - d) Virions
5. Measles has a narrow host range while West Nile virus has a broad one. Host range is determined by:
- a) The overall physical size of the virus particle itself
 - b) Lock and key fit between viral surface and host receptor proteins
 - c) Whether the viral genome is made of DNA or instead of RNA
 - d) The internal body temperature of the host species involved
6. Which statement is correct?
- a) Every molecule is also a compound, since atoms are bonded
 - b) Every compound is a molecule, but not every molecule is a compound
 - c) Compound is the broader term, since it includes single elements
 - d) O₂ counts as a compound because it contains two bonded atoms
7. A neutral nitrogen atom (⁷N) has an atomic mass of 16 amu. How many neutrons?
- a) 7
 - b) 9
 - c) 16
 - d) 23
8. Electrons are excluded from mass calculations because they weigh about:
- a) 1 amu, the same as a proton and the same as a neutron
 - b) 2 amu, which is double the mass of a proton or neutron
 - c) 1/2000 amu, which is negligible next to protons and neutrons
 - d) 1/10 amu, which is small but still counted in the mass number
9. How many valence electrons does oxygen (⁸O) have?
- a) 2
 - b) 4
 - c) 6
 - d) 8
10. Neon (¹⁰Ne) is chemically unreactive because:
- a) It carries no electrons at all in its outermost shell
 - b) Its outer shell is already full with eight electrons
 - c) It holds too many protons for other atoms to approach
 - d) It behaves as a metal, and metals resist forming bonds
1. A solution has a pH of 9. What is [OH⁻]?
- a) 10⁻⁹ M
 - b) 10⁻⁵ M
 - c) 10⁻¹⁴ M
 - d) 10⁻⁷ M
2. A solution has [OH⁻] of 10⁻¹² M. What is its pH?
- a) 12
 - b) 2
 - c) 7
 - d) 14
3. The pH of a solution changes from 2 to 5. The hydrogen ion concentration:
- a) Increased 3 times
 - b) Increased 1000 times
 - c) Decreased 1000 times
 - d) Stayed the same

4. Santa Barbara sits at 73 degrees while Palm Springs hits 106 on the same day. This is evidence of water's:

- a) Cohesion
- b) High heat capacity
- c) Role as a solvent
- d) Low density as a solid

5. Ice floats because:

- a) Solid water is warmer than liquid water at the same moment
- b) Hydrogen bonds hold molecules farther apart in a solid lattice
- c) Freezing traps small pockets of air throughout the solid
- d) Freezing breaks most of the hydrogen bonds between molecules

6. When table salt dissolves in water it dissociates, but when sugar dissolves it does not. Why?

- a) Sugar is not actually soluble in water, it only appears to be
- b) Salt is ionic and separates into ions; sugar is covalent and stays whole
- c) Sugar is nonpolar, so water cannot interact with it at all
- d) Salt is held together by covalent bonds that water can break

7. Which linkage description matches glycogen?

- a) Beta 1-4 linkages forming straight unbranched fibers
- b) Alpha 1-4 linkages only, producing a coiled helical fiber
- c) Alpha 1-4 and 1-6 linkages, producing extensive branching
- d) Beta 1-6 linkages that coil the chain tightly on itself

8. Starch and cellulose are both pure glucose polymers. The difference is:

- a) Cellulose contains added nitrogen while starch does not
- b) The orientation of one hydroxyl, giving alpha vs beta glucose
- c) Cellulose is assembled from fructose rather than from glucose
- d) Starch is built with beta linkages and cellulose with alpha

9. Amino acids are categorized by their R groups into:

- a) Large, medium, and small, based on the size of the side chain
- b) Nonpolar, polar, and electrically charged side chain groups
- c) Acidic and neutral only, since no amino acid is ever basic
- d) Saturated and unsaturated, based on double bonds in the chain

0. Which interactions maintain TERTIARY structure?

- a) Peptide bonds linking each amino acid to the next in sequence
- b) Hydrogen bonds between atoms of the polypeptide backbone only
- c) R group interactions: hydrogen, hydrophobic, ionic, disulfide
- d) Glycosidic linkages joining the subunits of the folded chain

1. Which is NOT a cause of denaturation listed in lecture?

- a) A change in the pH of the surrounding solution
- b) An increase in temperature above the normal range
- c) A change in the salinity of the surrounding fluid
- d) Dehydration synthesis joining two monomers together

2. Who added the principle that cells arise only from pre-existing cells?

- a) Robert Hooke
- b) Schleiden
- c) Schwann
- d) Virchow

3. Which structure is found in BOTH prokaryotic and eukaryotic cells?

- a) Nucleus
- b) Mitochondria
- c) Ribosomes
- d) Golgi apparatus

4. Internal membranes in eukaryotic cells serve to:

- a) Add mass to the cell so that it settles within the tissue
- b) Compartmentalize the cell and increase surface area for metabolism
- c) Serve as a replacement if the plasma membrane is damaged
- d) Store the cell's genetic information outside of the nucleus

5. You see a cell with a cell wall, a central vacuole and chloroplasts. This is:

- a) A human cheek cell, scraped from the inside of the mouth
- b) Frog blood, which unlike human blood still has a nucleus
- c) Elodea, a plant cell with a wall and green chloroplasts
- d) A bacterium, which has a wall but no internal organelles

6. Rod-shaped bacteria are called:
 - a) Cocci
 - b) Spirilli
 - c) Bacilli
 - d) Chromatin
7. The nucleolus is responsible for:
 - a) Storing lipids until the cell requires them for energy
 - b) Synthesizing the ribosomal subunits inside the nucleus
 - c) Digesting waste material and worn-out cellular components
 - d) Producing ATP from the breakdown of glucose and oxygen
8. Which organelle is found in plant cells but NOT animal cells?
 - a) Mitochondrion
 - b) Ribosome
 - c) Chloroplast
 - d) Golgi apparatus
9. Smooth ER differs from rough ER because smooth ER:
 - a) Has no ribosomes and handles lipid synthesis and detoxification
 - b) Carries many more ribosomes on its surface than rough ER does
 - c) Produces only the proteins that will be secreted from the cell
 - d) Contains its own DNA, separate from the DNA in the nucleus
0. Which is evidence for endosymbiosis?
 - a) Mitochondria are found in every known type of living cell
 - b) Mitochondria have their own DNA, own ribosomes, double membrane
 - c) Chloroplasts appear green because of the pigment they contain
 - d) Mitochondria are assembled by the Golgi apparatus as needed
1. The endomembrane system is thought to have originated from:
 - a) Bacteria that were engulfed and then kept by a host cell
 - b) Infolding of the plasma membrane into the cell interior
 - c) A viral infection that left membrane behind in the cytoplasm
 - d) Microtubules of the cytoskeleton flattening into sheets
2. Flagella and cilia are built from:
 - a) Microfilaments
 - b) Microtubules
 - c) Ribosomes
 - d) Lysosomes
3. Which is NOT one of the three main functions of a cell given in lecture?
 - a) Make molecules supporting cell structure and function
 - b) Transform energy and matter
 - c) Replicate through cell division
 - d) Maintain the organism's body temperature
4. Which is his definition of biology?
 - a) The scientific study of life
 - b) The study of animals and how they behave
 - c) The laboratory study of chemical reactions
 - d) The classification of organisms into groups
5. All the organisms on your campus makes up:
 - a) An ecosystem, since it includes the physical environment too
 - b) A community, meaning all the populations living in one area
 - c) A population, meaning members of a single species together
 - d) A taxonomic domain, one of the three broadest groupings
5. Which best distinguishes hypotheses from theories in science?
 - a) Theories are simply hypotheses that have now been proved true
 - b) Hypotheses are guesses while theories are the correct answers
 - c) Hypotheses are relatively narrow, theories have broad explanatory power
 - d) Theories are proved true while hypotheses are usually contradicted
7. Which of the following is hydrophobic?
 - a) Paper, which is made largely of cellulose fibers
 - b) Wax, which is a nonpolar lipid made of long chains
 - c) Table salt, which is an ionic compound of Na and Cl
 - d) Sugar, which carries many hydroxyl groups on its rings

8. The pH of a lake is 4.0. What is the hydrogen ion concentration?
- 4.0 M, reading the pH value directly as a concentration
 - 10^{-10} M, which would be the hydroxide concentration here
 - 10^{-4} M, taking the negative of the pH as the exponent
 - 10^4 M, using the pH value as a positive exponent
9. What is the hydroxide concentration of that same lake at pH 4?
- 10^{-10} M, since the two exponents must add to -14
 - 10^{-4} M, which is the hydrogen ion concentration instead
 - 10^{-7} M, which would only be true in neutral pure water
 - 10.0 M, which is not possible in an aqueous solution
10. Amylase breaks only alpha glucose linkages. Which could it break apart?
- Glycogen, starch, and amylopectin, which are all alpha linked
 - Glycogen and cellulose, one storage and one structural form
 - Cellulose and chitin, the two structural polysaccharides
 - Starch, chitin, and cellulose, a mix of both linkage types
1. Which structural level of a protein is LEAST affected by disruption of hydrogen bonds?
- Primary structure, which is held together by peptide bonds
 - Secondary structure, the alpha helices and beta pleated sheets
 - Tertiary structure, the overall folded shape of the chain
 - Quaternary structure, the assembly of multiple subunits
2. Which of the following always relates to function?
- Structure, the shape and arrangement of the thing itself
 - Behavior, meaning how an organism acts in its environment
 - Color, which often signals something about the organism
 - Age, since older organisms function differently than young
3. What carries all of the information on how an organism is meant to function?
- The cell, which contains everything the organism needs
 - The DNA, which stores the complete heritable instructions
 - The RNA, which carries messages out to the ribosomes
 - A protein, which performs nearly every job in the body
4. Energy trends from higher to lower organization. What is this called?
- Chaos, the general breakdown of order in a system
 - Entropy, the measure of disorder that tends to increase
 - Energy transfer, the movement of energy between objects
 - Endemism, a species being restricted to one location
5. Which best describes a hypothesis?
- A highly tested explanation supported by lots of evidence
 - An explanation that has not been and cannot be tested yet
 - An attempt to explain a phenomenon that can be tested
 - A tested statement that reliably predicts future phenomena
6. What is the outside layer of a virion with a viral envelope made of?
- Phospholipid bilayer that the virus synthesized itself
 - Protein capsomeres arranged into a repeating shell
 - Glycoproteins forming a continuous outer coating
 - Phospholipid bilayer taken from the host cell membrane
7. Which of the following is NOT a main element in organic molecules?
- Carbon, which forms the backbone of every organic molecule
 - Sulfur, which appears only in a few specific side chains
 - Oxygen, which is the most abundant element in the body
 - Nitrogen, found in every amino acid and every base
8. Electron shells represent:
- A quantized state where an electron is likely to exist
 - A protective covering that surrounds and shields electrons
 - A part of the atom shielding the nucleus from electrons
 - A drawing convention for configurations that are not real
9. What gives water its emergent properties?
- Polarity, the uneven distribution of charge in the molecule
 - Ionic bonds formed between neighboring water molecules
 - Covalent bonds holding each water molecule together
 - Hydrogen bonds formed between separate water molecules

0. An isotope has:
- a) A varying number of protons compared to the standard atom
 - b) A varying number of neutrons compared to the standard atom
 - c) A varying number of electrons compared to the neutral atom
 - d) No difference at all from any other atom of that element
1. An ion has:
- a) A varying number of protons compared to the neutral atom
 - b) A varying number of neutrons compared to the neutral atom
 - c) A varying number of electrons compared to the neutral atom
 - d) No difference at all from the neutral atom of that element
2. Different elements have:
- a) A varying number of protons, which defines elemental identity
 - b) A varying number of neutrons, which only changes the mass
 - c) A varying number of electrons, which only changes the charge
 - d) No difference at all beyond the name we give to each one
3. Prokaryotic cells are more _____ than eukaryotic cells.
- a) Complex, since they carry out more varied metabolic work
 - b) Simple, since they lack a nucleus and membrane organelles
 - c) Rare, since they are outnumbered by eukaryotic organisms
 - d) Popular, since they are studied more often in laboratories
4. True or false: prokaryotic cells don't need to be small.
- a) True, size makes no difference to how a prokaryote functions
 - b) False, they rely on diffusion so surface area to volume limits size
 - c) True, many prokaryotes are larger than typical eukaryotic cells
 - d) False, but only because their cell walls cannot support more mass
5. The DNA in prokaryotes lacks:
- a) Guanine, one of the four nitrogenous bases in the genome
 - b) Histones, the proteins eukaryotic DNA is packaged around
 - c) RNA, which prokaryotes produce in the same way we do
 - d) Uracil, which is not found in the DNA of any organism
6. What is the difference between a polypeptide chain and a protein?
- a) Polypeptides are built from monosaccharides rather than amino acids
 - b) Polypeptides are already folded into a functional conformation
 - c) Polypeptides are unfolded chains; a protein is the folded form
 - d) They are the same thing, and the words are interchangeable
7. What does denaturation entail?
- a) The breaking of the peptide bonds that link the amino acids
 - b) The unfolding of a protein while its sequence stays intact
 - c) A protein being converted back into the DNA that encoded it
 - d) DNA being converted directly into a functional protein
8. Phosphate groups have how many oxygens and what charge?
- a) Two oxygens and a positive charge on the central atom
 - b) Four oxygens and a negative charge on the whole group
 - c) Three oxygens and no net charge in aqueous solution
 - d) Four oxygens and a positive charge that attracts water
9. Which functional group forms covalent crosslinks in proteins?
- a) Hydroxyl, which is polar and forms hydrogen bonds instead
 - b) Sulfhydryl, which forms disulfide bridges between residues
 - c) Carboxyl, which donates hydrogen ions and turns negative
 - d) Methyl, which is nonpolar and does not react with much
0. Which is a controlled variable rather than the control group?
- a) The group of sunflowers grown in untreated neutral soil
 - b) Giving every plant the same amount of water each day
 - c) The pH level that you deliberately change between groups
 - d) The final height of each plant measured in centimeters
1. Which macromolecule class does NOT have a true monomer?
- a) Carbohydrates, which are built from monosaccharide units
 - b) Lipids, which are assembled from glycerol and fatty acids
 - c) Proteins, which are built from twenty different amino acids
 - d) Nucleic acids, which are built from nucleotide subunits

Short answer practice

Say each one out loud first, then write the version you would put on the exam

1. Explain the difference between a controlled variable and a control group, using an example.

2. A friend says evolution is 'just a theory.' Explain why that misuses the word.

3. Give an example of emergence and an example of reductionism, each using two specific levels of biological organization.

4. Describe one homeostatic feedback loop from start to finish.

5. Explain, step by step, how water's electronegativity difference leads to sweating cooling you down.

6. Name four functional groups and explain how each changes the molecule it is attached to.

7. Explain the four levels of protein structure and what stabilizes each.

8. Explain how the structure of DNA makes accurate inheritance possible.

9. Explain why a phospholipid bilayer forms spontaneously in water.

0. Are viruses alive? Build a full answer using the characteristics of life.

1. Walk through the replication cycle of an RNA virus and name the host component used at each step.

2. Design an experiment testing whether background music affects study performance. Include every required element.

3. State the general rule linking linkage type, chain shape and function in polysaccharides.

4. Walk the characteristics of life and score a virus on each one.

5. A Mars rover returns objects that look like microbes. What evidence would convince you they are alive?

6. Explain Patrick Forterre's virocell idea and evaluate it.

7. A volume of water has a pH of 3. Give $[H^+]$ and $[OH^-]$, and show your reasoning.

8. Given $CO_2 + H_2O$ in equilibrium with H_2CO_3 in equilibrium with $HCO_3^- + H^+$, what happens if blood pH begins to drop?

9. Explain how a single amino acid change causes sickle cell anemia, level by level.

0. Trace a newly synthesized protein from synthesis to secretion, then say how a lysosomal protein differs.

1. You are growing sunflowers and want the ideal soil pH. Write the null and alternate hypothesis, then set up the experiment.

2. From repeated sunflower data, state a scientific law and then a scientific theory, and explain how they differ.

3. What is the specific monomer and specific function of cellulose, and of protein?

4. Explain how blood glucose is regulated, naming the organs, hormones and storage molecule.

5. Write the complementary strand to 5'-AGGTCCG-3', and explain the two steps.

Answer key

Multiple choice

- b) Plant height**
Height is what gets measured, and it depends on the dose. The dose is the independent variable; soil and variety are controlled variables.
- c) It is a broad explanation supported by many independent lines of evidence**
Theories do not get promoted into laws. Laws describe what happens, theories explain why. And theories can always be revised with new evidence.
- c) It must turn out to be correct**
A hypothesis that gets disproven still did its job. Being wrong is a normal, useful outcome in science.
- b) Provide an untreated baseline that the treated groups are compared against**
Watch the wording carefully. Keeping variables constant is what CONTROLLED VARIABLES do. The control GROUP is the untreated comparison baseline.
- b) The x-axis**
DRY MIX: Dependent, Responding, Y-axis; Manipulated, Independent, X-axis.
- b) Organelle, cell, tissue, organ**
Organelles are parts inside a cell, so they come before it. Then cells build tissues, tissues build organs.
- c) Emergence**
Emergence is a property that appears at a higher level of organization and does not exist in the individual parts.
- b) It cannot reproduce or metabolize without hijacking a host cell's machinery**
Size and disease are irrelevant, and plenty of living things use RNA. Lacking independent reproduction and metabolism is the real argument.
- b) Homeostasis**
Homeostasis is maintaining a stable internal state through feedback when the external environment changes.
- b) Populations change over generations as helpful heritable traits become common**
Individuals do not evolve, populations do. Selection acts on variation that already exists; it does not generate traits on demand.
- b) It is the smallest unit that independently shows all characteristics of life**
Organelles contain DNA too and some are visible, but nothing below the cell can independently metabolize, maintain homeostasis, and reproduce.
- b) An isotope of carbon**
6 protons means carbon, always. Protons equal electrons, so no charge and therefore not an ion. Extra neutrons make it an isotope, carbon-14.
- c) One atom transfers electrons to another and the opposite charges attract**
Sharing equally is nonpolar covalent, sharing unequally is polar covalent, and the hydrogen option describes a hydrogen bond.
- b) Oxygen pulls the shared electrons harder and the molecule is bent**
Watch the direction of causation. Polarity is the CAUSE; dissolving salt and hydrogen bonding are the RESULTS. Reversing cause and effect is a classic lost point.
- b) High heat of vaporization**
Heat of vaporization is the heat needed to turn liquid into gas. That heat leaves your skin with the escaping water. High heat capacity is about resisting temperature change, a different property.
- c) 100 times more acidic**
The pH scale is logarithmic, so each unit is a factor of 10. Two units means $10 \times 10 = 100$.
- b) Carboxyl, -COOH**
Carboxyl donates an H^+ , which is the definition of an acid. Amino accepts H^+ , making it basic.
- b) Has four valence electrons and forms four stable covalent bonds**
Four bonding sites, including bonds to other carbons, is what allows chains, branches, and rings of unlimited variety.
- b) Large numbers together stabilize structures, and their weakness lets DNA unzip**
The weakness is a feature. If hydrogen bonds were strong, DNA could never be separated for replication.
- c) Isomers**
Isotopes involve neutrons, ions involve charge. Same formula with different arrangement is the definition of an isomer, like glucose and fructose.
- b) Dehydration synthesis, where water is removed to form a bond**
Building removes water; breaking adds water. Hydrolysis is the reverse and is what digestion does.
- b) We lack the enzyme needed to break its beta glycosidic bonds**
Cellulose is pure glucose, same as starch. The difference is the beta linkage, and we have no cellulase to cut it, so it passes through as fiber.
- a) Animals need rapid glucose release and branches give enzymes more ends**
More branch ends means more places enzymes can start cutting at once, so energy releases faster. Animals move; plants can afford to wait.
- b) Contain no double bonds, so the chains stay straight and pack tightly**
Saturated means no double bonds, so straight chains, tight packing, solid. Double bonds cause kinks and keep oils liquid.

5. **c) Amphipathic, with a hydrophilic head and two hydrophobic tails**
Two opposite personalities in one molecule. Heads face the water on both sides, tails hide in the middle, and it assembles itself.
6. **b) Secondary**
Secondary, and it is stabilized by hydrogen bonds along the backbone, not by R-group interactions. R groups drive tertiary structure.
7. **c) Primary structure**
Denaturation destroys folding but does not break peptide bonds, so the amino acid sequence survives. Function is lost because function depends on shape.
8. **b) A with T, G with C**
A-T and G-C in DNA. A-U appears in RNA, where uracil replaces thymine.
9. **b) It contains uracil and ribose and is usually single stranded**
Both contain phosphate and adenine. The RNA-only features are uracil, ribose, and single-stranded structure.
0. **b) Lipids**
Lipids are not built from repeating identical monomers strung into a chain. They are grouped together by being hydrophobic, not by a shared building block.
1. **c) A capsid of protein surrounding a nucleic acid genome**
Envelopes and spikes are optional, and no virus has ribosomes. Genome plus capsid is the universal minimum.
2. **b) Lipid membrane taken from the host cell as the virus exits**
It is stolen host membrane, which is lipid. That is exactly why soap, which disrupts lipids, destroys enveloped viruses.
3. **b) Their attachment proteins must physically match a host receptor**
Key and lock. No matching receptor means no attachment and no entry, which is why host range is narrow.
4. **b) Replication of the genome and synthesis of viral proteins**
Viruses have no ribosomes, no metabolic enzymes, and no ATP. Every bit of the manufacturing is borrowed, and that is the core argument against them being alive.
5. **b) Their polymerase has no proofreading, so errors are kept**
No proofreading means errors stay in. Combined with huge numbers of copies, variants appear fast, which is why flu shots are reformulated yearly.
6. **b) Line graph, because time is continuous**
Time is continuous, so a line graph shows the change across it. Bar graphs are for separate categories, not points along a continuum.
7. **b) The y-axis begins partway up instead of starting at zero**
Truncating the y-axis exaggerates small differences. Error bars, units and titles are all signs of a graph being made honestly.
8. **b) A weak acid only partly dissociates, so it can take H⁺ back**
Buffering requires a reversible reaction. A strong acid dissociates completely and has nothing left to take back, so it cannot absorb added base.
9. **b) Acetic acid is weak and only partly dissociates, releasing fewer H⁺**
Concentration and strength are different things. Same molarity, very different actual hydrogen ion concentration, because a weak acid only partly lets go.
0. **b) A carbon-carbon double bond cannot rotate, locking each form**
Identical atoms, identical connections. The double bond is a locked hinge rather than a swivel, so the two spatial arrangements cannot interconvert.
1. **b) Sodium and potassium**
Sodium and potassium gradients across the membrane store the charge difference that becomes an action potential. Calcium triggers muscle contraction, which is a different job.
2. **b) Purines have two rings; adenine and guanine are purines**
Pure As Gold: purines are adenine and guanine, and they carry two rings. A purine always pairs with a pyrimidine so the helix stays a constant width.
3. **b) Contains a nitrogen-bearing group added onto the glucose**
Both are straight beta-linked structural polysaccharides. Chitin is built from a nitrogen-containing glucose derivative, and it forms shells and fungal cell walls.
4. **b) Life at every level, from molecules in cells to ecosystems**
Biology claims anything alive, at any level. That range is why it overlaps chemistry below it and ecology above it.
5. **b) It loops, and results often send you back to revise hypothesis or method**
The textbook draws a clean loop, but the important part is that it is iterative. Results feed back into the question.
6. **b) There is no control group, no blinding, and self-reported results**
Several fatal flaws at once. Self-reported feelings with no control group and no blinding cannot separate the product from the placebo effect.
7. **c) Fabricated data**
Reviewers evaluate the reasoning and methods described, not the raw data. Independent replication is what catches fabrication.
8. **b) Basic research can produce applications nobody could have predicted**
You cannot know in advance which basic question becomes a technology, which is the core argument for funding basic research.
9. **b) It is not cellular, has no genetic material, and no homeostasis**
Life requires the whole checklist, not a majority of it. Fire fails cells, heredity, homeostasis and evolution.

0. **b) Reductionism**
Reductionism explains a system by breaking it into parts. Emergence is the opposite direction, looking at what appears when parts combine.
1. **b) Performs energy-expensive transport, like a kidney tubule cell**
Predicting function from structure is the core skill here. Lots of mitochondria means high energy demand; folded membrane means lots of surface for transport.
2. **b) They are small and form strong, stable, often multiple bonds**
Small atoms form short, strong bonds. Bigger atoms form weaker, longer ones that would break too easily to hold a genome together.
3. **b) Nearly all mass sits in the nucleus, nearly all volume in shells**
Protons positive, neutrons neutral, electrons negative. The nucleus holds the mass; the shells take up essentially all the space.
4. **b) It is a weighted average across naturally occurring isotopes**
Carbon is mostly carbon-12 with a small fraction of carbon-13, and averaging the two lands just above 12.
5. **c) 3**
It needs 3 more electrons to reach 8, so it forms 3 bonds. You can predict bonding for any of these atoms this way instead of memorizing.
6. **b) It is linear, so the two bond dipoles point opposite and cancel**
Shape decides molecular polarity, not just bond polarity. Water has polar bonds too, but it is bent so they do not cancel.
7. **b) Oil is nonpolar, so water molecules exclude it and it clumps**
The real answer is about what water does. Water molecules stick to each other and exclude anything nonpolar, which forces the oil together.
8. **b) Contains a weak acid and its conjugate base, so H⁺ moves both ways**
Buffering needs a reversible pair. The bicarbonate system holds blood near 7.4 by absorbing or releasing H⁺ as needed.
9. **b) Hydrocarbon chains are fully reduced, so oxidation releases more**
Carbohydrates are already partly oxidized. There is more energy left to release in a chain of C-H bonds that has not been oxidized yet.
0. **a) C₆H₁₂O₆**
The ratio is roughly one carbon to two hydrogens to one oxygen, which glucose fits exactly. Modified sugars like deoxyribose break the rule.
1. **b) Glycolysis, the central energy pathway, takes glucose as input**
Every other sugar gets converted in the liver first, which is why blood glucose specifically is what gets measured.
2. **b) In the middle of the chain**
Aldose means at the end, forming an aldehyde. Ketose means internal, forming a ketone. Glucose is an aldose, fructose a ketose.
3. **b) Lactase, the enzyme that hydrolyzes the bond within lactose**
The disaccharide is fine; the enzyme that cuts the glycosidic bond is missing, so undigested lactose reaches gut bacteria.
4. **b) They are hydrophobic and do not dissolve readily in water**
Lipids are grouped by a physical property rather than a building block, which is why steroids count despite looking nothing like a fat.
5. **b) Nonpolar, so they pass through the hydrophobic membrane interior**
Being nonpolar lets them cross the membrane and bind receptors inside the cell, which is why they act slowly but last longer than protein hormones.
6. **c) Storing genetic information across generations long term**
Long-term genetic storage is DNA's job. DNA is the manual, proteins are the workers.
7. **c) The R group, the variable side chain on that same carbon**
All 20 share the same central carbon, amino group, carboxyl group and hydrogen. Only the R group changes, and it decides how that residue behaves.
8. **a) A phosphate group, a five-carbon sugar, and a nitrogenous base**
Three parts, every time. The sugar is deoxyribose in DNA and ribose in RNA, and ATP is a nucleotide with two extra phosphates.
9. **c) Memorization and recall**
The six are organization and emergence, structure relates to function, information storage and flow, energy and matter transformation, interactions within systems, and evolution.
0. **c) Both the unity and the diversity of life**
One idea explains two opposite facts: shared ancestry gives unity, adaptation to different environments gives diversity.
1. **a) Order, regulation, growth, energy processing, response, reproduction, evolution**
Seven properties, and something is considered alive when it displays them collectively rather than one at a time.
2. **b) A self-sustained chemical system capable of Darwinian evolution**
Deliberately substrate-independent, so it does not assume carbon, water, or cells. Two requirements: self-sustaining chemistry and Darwinian evolution.
3. **b) Virion**
Virion is the particle. Capsid is the protein shell, capsomeres are the repeating subunits that build it, and virocell is Forterre's term for the infected cell.
4. **b) Capsomeres**
Capsomeres assemble into the capsid. Glycoproteins are the spikes on an envelope, not the shell itself.
5. **b) Lock and key fit between viral surface and host receptor proteins**
Surface proteins have to physically fit host receptors. No fit means no attachment and no infection.

6. **b) Every compound is a molecule, but not every molecule is a compound**
A compound requires two or more DIFFERENT elements. O₂ is a molecule but not a compound, which is why molecule is the broader category.
7. **b) 9**
Mass number minus protons: 16 minus 7 equals 9. Protons and electrons are both 7 because the atom is neutral.
8. **c) 1/2000 amu, which is negligible next to protons and neutrons**
Negligible compared to protons and neutrons, which are each about 1 amu. So mass number is just protons plus neutrons.
9. **c) 6**
First shell takes 2, leaving 6 in the outer shell. It needs 2 more to reach 8, which is why oxygen forms 2 bonds.
0. **b) Its outer shell is already full with eight electrons**
A full outer shell means no tendency to gain, lose, or share. That is the octet rule doing its job.
1. **b) 10⁻⁵ M**
pH 9 means [H⁺] is 10⁻⁹. The exponents must add to -14, so [OH⁻] is 10⁻⁵. Basic solution, more hydroxide than hydrogen, which checks out.
2. **b) 2**
The exponents add to -14, so [H⁺] is 10⁻², and pH is the flipped exponent: 2. Strongly acidic.
3. **c) Decreased 1000 times**
Three pH units means 10³, so 1000 times. And pH went UP, which means fewer hydrogen ions, so it decreased. Direction matters here.
4. **b) High heat capacity**
The ocean absorbs huge amounts of heat with little temperature change and moderates the coastal air. Inland has no such reservoir.
5. **b) Hydrogen bonds hold molecules farther apart in a solid lattice**
Freezing locks water into an open hydrogen-bonded lattice, so the solid is less dense than the liquid. Lakes freeze from the top down as a result.
6. **b) Salt is ionic and separates into ions; sugar is covalent and stays whole**
Ionic solutes dissociate into separate ions. Covalent molecules get surrounded by water and carried into solution without breaking apart.
7. **c) Alpha 1-4 and 1-6 linkages, producing extensive branching**
The 1-6 linkages are the branch points, and heavy branching is what lets animals mobilize glucose fast. Starch is alpha 1-4 helical; cellulose is beta 1-4 unbranched.
8. **b) The orientation of one hydroxyl, giving alpha vs beta glucose**
One hydroxyl flipped on carbon 1. Alpha coils and stores energy, beta stays straight and builds structure.
9. **b) Nonpolar, polar, and electrically charged side chain groups**
Nonpolar ones are hydrophobic and bury inside the folded protein. Polar and charged ones are hydrophilic and face the water. Charged splits into acidic and basic.
0. **c) R group interactions: hydrogen, hydrophobic, ionic, disulfide**
Secondary structure uses backbone hydrogen bonds. Tertiary uses R group interactions, and his slide listed all four types.
1. **d) Dehydration synthesis joining two monomers together**
His four: pH, heat, salinity, and polarity. Dehydration synthesis is how polymers are built, not how they unfold.
2. **d) Virchow**
Schleiden and Schwann gave the first two parts in 1839. Virchow added the third in 1855. Hooke first saw and named cells in 1665.
3. **c) Ribosomes**
Every cell has to make proteins, so every cell has ribosomes. His slide listed what all cells contain: plasma membrane, protoplasm, and DNA/RNA.
4. **b) Compartmentalize the cell and increase surface area for metabolism**
Those are the two functions he listed. Compartments let incompatible reactions run at once; extra membrane area gives more room for reactions.
5. **c) Elodea, a plant cell with a wall and green chloroplasts**
Cell wall plus chloroplasts means plant. Elodea was the specimen with the central vacuole and chloroplasts. Onion has a wall but no chloroplasts in the epidermis.
6. **c) Bacilli**
Bacilli are rods, cocci are spheres, spirilli are spirals. Three shapes, three names.
7. **b) Synthesizing the ribosomal subunits inside the nucleus**
NucleolUS makes riboSOMES. It sits inside the nucleus, and the pores in the nuclear envelope let the subunits out.
8. **c) Chloroplast**
Chloroplasts, cell wall and a large central vacuole are plant features. Mitochondria are in nearly all eukaryotes, including plants.
9. **a) Has no ribosomes and handles lipid synthesis and detoxification**
Rough is rough because of studded ribosomes and it handles protein manufacture. Smooth handles lipids, detox and calcium storage.
0. **b) Mitochondria have their own DNA, own ribosomes, double membrane**
They behave like the free-living bacteria they descended from, including dividing on their own. The double membrane is exactly what engulfment would produce.
1. **b) Infolding of the plasma membrane into the cell interior**
Different origin from mitochondria and chloroplasts. He put both origins on the same slide: it is all membrane, folded inward.

2. **b) Microtubules**
Microtubules form the core of flagella and cilia and also the mitotic spindle. Microfilaments are actin, involved in shape and muscle contraction.
3. **d) Maintain the organism's body temperature**
Build, burn, divide. Thermoregulation is an organism-level job, not a function of the individual cell.
4. **a) The scientific study of life**
Four words on his slide: the scientific study of life. Do not overbuild it. The word scientific matters, because it says biology uses the methods of science.
5. **b) A community, meaning all the populations living in one area**
A population is one species. A community is all the species in an area. An ecosystem adds the nonliving environment. 'All the organisms' means every species, so community.
6. **c) Hypotheses are relatively narrow, theories have broad explanatory power**
Scope is the difference, not proof. Science never proves anything absolutely, so any option containing the word 'proved' is wrong on principle.
7. **b) Wax, which is a nonpolar lipid made of long chains**
Nonpolar means hydrophobic. Wax is lipid. Salt is ionic, and sugar and cellulose are loaded with polar hydroxyl groups, so all three interact with water.
8. **c) 10^{-4} M, taking the negative of the pH as the exponent**
 $\text{pH} = -\log[\text{H}^+]$, so $[\text{H}^+] = 10^{-\text{pH}}$. Flip the sign of the pH and that is your exponent.
9. **a) 10^{-10} M, since the two exponents must add to -14**
 $[\text{H}^+][\text{OH}^-] = 10^{-14}$ always. If $[\text{H}^+]$ is 10^{-4} , then $[\text{OH}^-]$ must be 10^{-10} , because -4 and -10 sum to -14.
0. **a) Glycogen, starch, and amylopectin, which are all alpha linked**
Amylopectin is just the branched portion of starch, so it is alpha too. Cellulose and chitin are beta linked, which is exactly why humans cannot digest them.
1. **a) Primary structure, which is held together by peptide bonds**
Peptide bonds are covalent and far stronger than hydrogen bonds, so the sequence survives. Secondary structure is the most vulnerable, since it is held by backbone hydrogen bonds.
2. **a) Structure, the shape and arrangement of the thing itself**
One of his six course themes, stated almost word for word: structure relates to function at every level of biological organization.
3. **b) The DNA, which stores the complete heritable instructions**
DNA is the master copy. RNA carries a working copy of part of it, and proteins are the product, not the storage.
4. **b) Entropy, the measure of disorder that tends to increase**
Entropy. It is on his vocabulary list, and it is why energy must flow continuously through an ecosystem rather than cycling like matter.
5. **c) An attempt to explain a phenomenon that can be tested**
Testability is the defining feature. The first option describes a theory, and the last describes a law.
6. **d) Phospholipid bilayer taken from the host cell membrane**
Stolen, not made. The envelope is host membrane picked up as the virus buds out, which is why soap destroys enveloped viruses.
7. **b) Sulfur, which appears only in a few specific side chains**
CHON are the main four. Sulfur shows up in cysteine and methionine but is a trace element, not a main one.
8. **a) A quantized state where an electron is likely to exist**
Shells are energy levels, not physical shields. The Bohr model draws them as neat circles, but they represent probable energy states.
9. **d) Hydrogen bonds formed between separate water molecules**
Careful here, because two options are defensible. Polarity is the root cause, but hydrogen bonds are what polarity produces and what directly creates cohesion, high heat capacity, ice floating, and solvent behavior. The chain is: polar covalent bonds, then partial charges, then hydrogen bonds, then the four properties. If the exam offers both, hydrogen bonds is the more direct answer, but be ready to explain the whole chain.
0. **b) A varying number of neutrons compared to the standard atom**
Neutrons for isotopes. Change protons and you have a different element; change electrons and you have an ion.
1. **c) A varying number of electrons compared to the neutral atom**
Electrons for ions. Gaining them gives a negative charge, losing them gives a positive one, and the element itself does not change.
2. **a) A varying number of protons, which defines elemental identity**
Protons are the identity. Change that number and it is a different substance entirely.
3. **b) Simple, since they lack a nucleus and membrane organelles**
Structurally simpler, though metabolically they are actually more diverse than eukaryotes. Simple refers to the architecture.
4. **b) False, they rely on diffusion so surface area to volume limits size**
False. Without internal membranes they depend on diffusion, and as volume grows faster than surface area, the interior can no longer be supplied.
5. **b) Histones, the proteins eukaryotic DNA is packaged around**
Histones. Prokaryotic DNA is not wound around histone proteins the way eukaryotic chromatin is. Guanine is in all DNA, and uracil is in no DNA.
6. **c) Polypeptides are unfolded chains; a protein is the folded form**
The chain is a polypeptide. Once it folds into its working three-dimensional shape, it is a protein.

7. **b) The unfolding of a protein while its sequence stays intact**
Unfolding, not breaking. Peptide bonds are covalent and survive, so primary structure is retained, which is why the sequence is still there afterward.
8. **b) Four oxygens and a negative charge on the whole group**
Four oxygens, negative charge. That negative charge is what makes the phospholipid head polar and what drives ATP energy transfer.
9. **b) Sulfhydryl, which forms disulfide bridges between residues**
Sulfhydryl (-SH) on cysteine. Two of them form a disulfide bridge, which is a covalent bond and the strongest thing holding tertiary structure together.
0. **b) Giving every plant the same amount of water each day**
A controlled variable is a condition held identical everywhere. The control group is the group with no treatment. Both words appear on the worksheet and they are not the same thing.
1. **b) Lipids, which are assembled from glycerol and fatty acids**
Lipids are grouped by a property, being hydrophobic, rather than by a shared repeating subunit. The table will tempt you to invent a monomer for that row.

Short answer — what a full-credit answer sounds like

1. **Explain the difference between a controlled variable and a control group, using an example.**
A controlled variable is a factor deliberately kept identical across all groups so it cannot explain the results, such as giving every basil plant the same soil, light, and water. A control group is an entire experimental group that receives no treatment, such as the basil plants given zero fertilizer, and it exists to provide a baseline to compare the treated groups against. The first is about keeping conditions constant; the second is about having something to compare to.
2. **A friend says evolution is 'just a theory.' Explain why that misuses the word.**
In everyday speech a theory means a guess, but in science a theory is the opposite: it is a broad explanation that has been tested repeatedly and is supported by many independent lines of evidence. A guess in science is called a hypothesis. Evolution by natural selection is supported by fossil evidence, genetics, comparative anatomy, and direct observation, so calling it 'just a theory' confuses the everyday meaning with the scientific one.
3. **Give an example of emergence and an example of reductionism, each using two specific levels of biological organization.**
Emergence: individual heart muscle cells can only contract, but organized together at the organ level the heart pumps blood through an entire body, a function no single cell possesses. Reductionism: studying the structure of DNA at the molecule level to explain how traits are inherited at the organism level. Emergence looks upward at what appears when parts combine; reductionism looks downward by breaking a system into parts to explain it.
4. **Describe one homeostatic feedback loop from start to finish.**
Body temperature rises above the set point. Temperature sensors in the skin and hypothalamus detect the increase. The hypothalamus acts as the control center and signals effectors: sweat glands release sweat and blood vessels in the skin dilate. Evaporation of sweat removes heat and dilated vessels release heat at the surface, so body temperature falls back toward the set point. Because the response reverses the original change, this is negative feedback.
5. **Explain, step by step, how water's electronegativity difference leads to sweating cooling you down.**
Oxygen is more electronegative than hydrogen, so it pulls the shared electrons closer and the bent shape of the molecule gives oxygen a partial negative charge and each hydrogen a partial positive charge. These partial charges let water molecules form hydrogen bonds with each other. Breaking those many hydrogen bonds to convert liquid water into vapor takes a large amount of energy, which is water's high heat of vaporization. When sweat evaporates from skin it takes that heat energy with it, lowering body temperature and helping maintain homeostasis.
6. **Name four functional groups and explain how each changes the molecule it is attached to.**
Hydroxyl (-OH) is polar, so it makes the molecule more soluble in water; it is found in alcohols and sugars. Carboxyl (-COOH) is acidic because it donates a hydrogen ion; it is found in amino acids and fatty acids. Amino (-NH₂) is basic because it accepts a hydrogen ion; it is the other reactive end of every amino acid. Phosphate (-PO₄) carries a negative charge and is central to energy transfer in ATP and to the backbone of DNA. (Sulfhydryl forming disulfide bridges, carbonyl defining aldehydes and ketones, and nonpolar methyl acting as a tag are also acceptable.)
7. **Explain the four levels of protein structure and what stabilizes each.**
Primary structure is the linear sequence of amino acids joined by peptide bonds, determined by the gene. Secondary structure is local folding into alpha helices and beta pleated sheets, stabilized by hydrogen bonds between atoms of the backbone rather than the R groups. Tertiary structure is the overall three-dimensional shape of the whole polypeptide, stabilized by interactions between R groups including hydrophobic clustering, hydrogen bonds, ionic bonds, and covalent disulfide bridges. Quaternary structure is the assembly of two or more separate polypeptide chains into one functional protein, as in hemoglobin's four subunits, and not every protein has it.
8. **Explain how the structure of DNA makes accurate inheritance possible.**
DNA is a double helix with a sugar-phosphate backbone on the outside and bases pointing inward. Because adenine always pairs with thymine and guanine always pairs with cytosine, the sequence of one strand exactly specifies the sequence of the other. That means when the two strands separate, each one serves as a template for building a new complementary partner, producing two identical double helices. The complementary base pairing is what makes the copying accurate, so the structure of the molecule is the direct reason inheritance works.
9. **Explain why a phospholipid bilayer forms spontaneously in water.**
A phospholipid is amphipathic: its phosphate head is polar and hydrophilic while its two fatty acid tails are nonpolar and hydrophobic. In water, the hydrophilic heads form favorable interactions with the surrounding water while the hydrophobic tails cannot, so the tails cluster together to minimize contact with water. The most stable arrangement is a double layer with heads facing outward into the water on both sides and tails sequestered in the interior. Nothing assembles it deliberately; the hydrophobic effect makes this the lowest-energy arrangement, and the resulting bilayer is what allows a cell to exist as a separate compartment.

0. **Are viruses alive? Build a full answer using the characteristics of life.**

Viruses fail most of the standard criteria for life. They are acellular, so they violate cell theory. They have no metabolism, no ribosomes, and cannot produce ATP, so they cannot process energy. They do not maintain homeostasis or grow and develop. They can only reproduce by entering a host cell and hijacking its machinery, so reproduction is not independent. However, they do possess genetic material in the form of DNA or RNA, and they clearly mutate and undergo natural selection, as seen with new influenza and coronavirus variants. Because they meet only the heredity and evolution criteria, most biologists describe viruses as existing at the border of life, or as alive only while inside a host cell. The deciding property is the inability to reproduce or metabolize independently.

1. **Walk through the replication cycle of an RNA virus and name the host component used at each step.**

First, attachment: a glycoprotein spike on the virus binds a specific receptor protein on the host cell surface. Second, entry and uncoating: the virus enters the cell and the capsid comes off, releasing the RNA genome into the cytoplasm. Third, replication and biosynthesis: the host cell's ribosomes, amino acids, and ATP are used to translate viral proteins, while viral RNA polymerase copies the genome. Fourth, assembly: newly made capsid proteins package copies of the genome into new virions. Fifth, release: new viruses either bud out through the host membrane, taking an envelope with them, or burst the cell open by lysis. The virus supplies only the instructions; the ribosomes, energy, and raw materials are all the host's.

2. **Design an experiment testing whether background music affects study performance. Include every required element.**

Hypothesis: students who study with background music will score lower on a recall test than students who study in silence. Independent variable: presence of background music. Dependent variable: score on the recall test. Controlled variables: same study material, same study duration, same room, same time of day, same test. Control group: the silence group. Design: recruit enough participants for a meaningful result, randomly assign them to the two groups so that existing study habits are distributed evenly, and run the test the same way for both. Analysis method decided in advance: compare the mean scores of the two groups. A limitation worth naming is that people already used to studying with music may respond differently, which random assignment helps but does not fully remove.

3. **State the general rule linking linkage type, chain shape and function in polysaccharides.**

Alpha glycosidic linkages produce chains that coil and branch, which suits energy storage because branching creates many ends for enzymes to attack, as in starch and glycogen. Beta glycosidic linkages produce straight chains that stack and hydrogen bond to each other into rigid fibers, which suits structure, as in cellulose and chitin. Most animals lack the enzymes to break beta linkages, which is why cellulose passes through as fiber and why chitin is indigestible. Alpha coils for storage, beta is a beam for building.

4. **Walk the characteristics of life and score a virus on each one.**

Made of cells: no, viruses are acellular. Own metabolism and energy: no, they have no ribosomes and cannot make ATP. Homeostasis: no, they do not regulate an internal environment. Grows and develops: no, they are assembled rather than grown. Reproduces independently: no, they can only replicate inside a host cell using its machinery. Has genetic material: yes, DNA or RNA. Evolves by natural selection: yes, clearly and quickly, as new influenza and coronavirus variants show. That is two out of seven, which is why most biologists describe viruses as sitting at the border of life rather than answering yes or no.

5. **A Mars rover returns objects that look like microbes. What evidence would convince you they are alive?**

I would test for the properties of life collectively rather than any single trait. Do they show internal order and complexity rather than random structure? Do they regulate an internal environment? Do they grow and develop over time rather than simply accumulating material? Do they take in energy or nutrients and transform them, meaning metabolism? Do they respond to changes in their environment, such as light, temperature, or chemicals? Do they reproduce, producing more of themselves? And across generations, does the population change, showing evolution? The attempt to culture them on different substrates and under different conditions tests several of these at once, especially metabolism, growth, and reproduction. A single positive result would not be enough, because nonliving chemical systems can mimic individual properties. Using NASA's definition, I would specifically want evidence that the system is self-sustaining and capable of Darwinian evolution.

6. **Explain Patrick Forterre's virocell idea and evaluate it.**

Forterre argues that the virion, the free particle, is comparable to a seed or a spore: a dormant package that is not metabolically active. The living form, in his view, is the virocell, meaning the host cell together with the virus that is now directing it. He treats the virocell as a novel organism whose function is producing new virions. The strength of the argument is that it reframes the question: judging a virus by its inert particle may be like judging an oak tree by an acorn. The weakness is that it does not establish that a virus is alive independently, which is what the original question asks, since the virocell still requires a host cell that the virus did not build. It is a useful reframing rather than a resolution.

7. **A volume of water has a pH of 3. Give [H+] and [OH-], and show your reasoning.**

pH is the negative log of the hydrogen ion concentration, so a pH of 3 means $[H^+] = 10^{-3} \text{ M}$. In any aqueous solution the ion product of water holds: $[H^+] \times [OH^-] = 10^{-14}$. So $[OH^-] = 10^{-14} \text{ divided by } 10^{-3}$, which is 10^{-11} M . A quick check: the two exponents must always sum to -14, and -3 plus -11 equals -14. Since $[H^+]$ is much larger than $[OH^-]$, the solution is acidic, which is consistent with a pH below 7.

8. **Given $\text{CO}_2 + \text{H}_2\text{O}$ in equilibrium with H_2CO_3 in equilibrium with $\text{HCO}_3^- + \text{H}^+$, what happens if blood pH begins to drop?**

A drop in pH means the hydrogen ion concentration is rising, so there is excess H^+ on the right side of the equation. The equilibrium shifts to the left, away from the excess: hydrogen ions combine with bicarbonate to form carbonic acid, which can further convert to carbon dioxide and water. This removes free hydrogen ions from the blood. The net effect is that pH rises back toward the normal range of 7.35 to 7.45. This works because the system is built from a weak acid and its conjugate base, so the reaction can run in both directions. Excess carbon dioxide can then be exhaled by the lungs.

9. **Explain how a single amino acid change causes sickle cell anemia, level by level.**

A single base change in the DNA alters the primary structure of hemoglobin, substituting valine for glutamic acid at one position. Glutamic acid is charged and hydrophilic while valine is nonpolar and hydrophobic, so that one residue now behaves completely differently during folding. This changes the R group interactions that maintain tertiary structure, and it creates a hydrophobic patch on the protein surface. Hemoglobin molecules then stick to one another and polymerize into fibers, which distorts the red blood cell into a rigid sickle shape. Those cells block capillaries and are destroyed early, causing pain crises and anemia. The chain is primary structure to tertiary structure to function to disease, and it is why sequence matters.

0. **Trace a newly synthesized protein from synthesis to secretion, then say how a lysosomal protein differs.**

The gene is transcribed into mRNA in the nucleus, and the mRNA exits through a nuclear pore. Ribosomes bound to the rough endoplasmic reticulum translate the mRNA, and the growing protein enters the ER lumen where it is folded and modified. The rough ER buds off a transport vesicle containing the protein. That vesicle travels to and fuses with the Golgi apparatus, where the protein is further modified, sorted, and tagged for its destination. The Golgi then packages it into a secretory vesicle, which travels to the plasma membrane and fuses with it, releasing the protein outside the cell by exocytosis. A lysosomal protein follows the identical path up to the Golgi. The difference is at the sorting step: the Golgi tags it for delivery to a lysosome rather than for export, so the vesicle fuses with a lysosome and the enzyme stays inside the cell.

1. **You are growing sunflowers and want the ideal soil pH. Write the null and alternate hypothesis, then set up the experiment.**

Null hypothesis: soil pH has no effect on the height of sunflower plants. Alternate hypothesis: soil pH does affect the height of sunflower plants. Prediction: if soil pH affects growth, then sunflowers grown in soil near pH 6.6 to 6.8 will reach a greater average height than those grown in more acidic or more basic soil. Independent variable: the pH of the soil, set at several levels across the range. Dependent variable: average plant height in centimeters. Controlled variables: the same sunflower variety, the same amount of water, the same light exposure, the same soil type, the same pot size, the same temperature, and the same growing period. Control group: plants grown in untreated neutral soil, so the treated groups have a baseline to be compared against. I would use many plants in each pH group rather than one, assign them randomly, repeat the whole experiment, and decide in advance to compare mean heights between groups.

2. **From repeated sunflower data, state a scientific law and then a scientific theory, and explain how they differ.**

Law: sunflower growth is greatest in soil with a pH near 6.6 to 6.8, and average height decreases as soil pH moves either above or below that range. That statement only describes what consistently happens; it makes no claim about why. Theory: soil pH affects the activity of the enzymes that sunflowers depend on for growth, so plants grow tallest where the pH keeps those enzymes closest to their optimal shape and activity, and growth declines where pH moves away from that optimum and enzyme function drops. The difference is that a law describes a consistent pattern while a theory explains the mechanism behind it. You do not need one to form the other, since a law can be stated from data alone and a theory can be developed from mechanism, and a hypothesis never becomes a law. Neither is set in stone. Both remain open to revision if new evidence contradicts them.

3. **What is the specific monomer and specific function of cellulose, and of protein?**

Cellulose: the specific monomer is beta glucose, and the specific function is structural support in the plant cell wall, where straight beta-linked chains hydrogen bond to one another into rigid fibers. Saying the monomer is a monosaccharide is the general answer; beta glucose is the specific one the question is asking for. Protein: the specific monomer is the amino acid, and proteins serve many specific functions including catalyzing reactions as enzymes, providing structure as in collagen and keratin, transporting substances as hemoglobin does, enabling movement through actin and myosin, and defending the body as antibodies. Amino acids are joined by peptide bonds into polypeptides, which fold into functional proteins.

4. **Explain how blood glucose is regulated, naming the organs, hormones and storage molecule.**

After a meal, blood glucose rises above the normal range. The pancreas detects this and secretes insulin. Insulin signals body cells to take up glucose and signals the liver to convert glucose into glycogen for storage, which lowers blood glucose back toward normal. Later, during fasting or exercise, blood glucose falls below the normal range. The pancreas detects this and secretes glucagon. Glucagon signals the liver to break stored glycogen back down into glucose and release it into the bloodstream, which raises blood glucose back toward normal. Because each response reverses the change that triggered it, this is negative feedback, and it is a clear example of homeostasis. The pancreas is the sensor and signal source, the liver is the storage site, and glycogen is the storage form of glucose.

5. **Write the complementary strand to 5'-AGGTCCG-3', and explain the two steps.**

The complementary strand is 3'-TCCAGGC-5', which written conventionally in the 5' to 3' direction reads 5'-CGGACCT-3'. Two steps produce it. First, apply complementary base pairing to each position: adenine pairs with thymine, thymine with adenine, guanine with cytosine, and cytosine with guanine, which turns A G G T C C G into T C C A G G C. Second, reverse the directionality, because the two strands of DNA run antiparallel: if the given strand runs 5' to 3', its partner runs 3' to 5'. Leaving off the direction labels is the most common way to lose credit on this question, because antiparallel orientation is part of what is being tested.